

PREFACE

in this unique collection of mystery stories, a superb raconteur presents thirteen surprise-ending masterpieces. In each of them she leads the reader gently down the garden path of her tale, planting clues right and left before his eyes while she deftly diverts his attention elsewhere. And each conclusion comes as a surprise, as logical as it is unexpected. Young people, good and bad as in real life, play an important part in these stories, and young readers will enjoy matching wits with them in these thirteen baffling mysteries.
R.T.B.

I had called in at my friend Poirot's rooms to find him sadly overworked. So much had he become the rage that every rich woman who had mislaid a bracelet or lost a pet kitten rushed to secure the services of the great Hercule Poirot. My little friend was a strange mixture of Flemish thrift and artistic fervor. He accepted many cases in which he had little interest owing to the first instinct being predominant.

He also undertook cases in which there was a little or no monetary reward sheerly because the problem involved interested him. The result was that, as I say, he was overworking himself. He admitted as much himself, and I found little difficulty in persuading him to accompany me for a week's holiday to that well-known South Coast resort, Ebermouth. We had spent four very agreeable days when Poirot came to me, an open letter in his hand. "Mon ami, you remember my friend Joseph Aarons, the theatrical agent?" I assented after a moment's thought. Poirot's friends are so many and so varied, and range from dustmen to dukes. "Eh bien, Hastings, Joseph Aarons finds himself at Charlock Bay. He is far from well, and there is a little affair that it seems is worrying him. He begs me to go over and see him. I think, mon ami, that I must accede to his request. He is a faithful friend, the good Joseph Aarons, and has done much to assist me in the past." "Certainly, if you think so," I said. "I believe Charlock Bay is a beautiful spot, and as it happens I've never been there." . . . " ?

10 AGATHA CHRISTIE "Then we combine business with pleasure," said Poirot. "You will inquire the trains, yes?" "It will probably mean a change or two," I said with grimace. "You know what these cross-country lines are. To go from the South Devon coast to the North Devon coast is sometimes a day's journey." However, on inquiry, I found that the journey could be accomplished by only one change at Exeter and that the trains were good. I was hastening back to Poirot with information when I happened to pass the offices of the Speedy cars and saw written up: Tomorrow. All-day excursion to Charlock Bay. Starting

8:30 through some of the most beautiful scenery in Devon. I inquired a few particulars and returned to the hotel full of enthusiasm. Unfortunately, I found it hard to make Poirot share my feelings. "My friend, why this passion for the motor coach? The train, see you, it is sure? The tires, they do not burst; accidents, they do not happen. One is not incommoded too much air. The windows can be shut and no draught admitted." I hinted delicately that the advantage of fresh air somewhat attracted me most to the motor-coach scheme. "And if it rains? Your English climate is so uncertain." "There's a hood and all that. Besides, if it rains bad the excursion doesn't take place." "Ah!" said Poirot. "Then let us hope that it rains." ^ "Of course, if you feel like that and ..." "No, no, mon ami. I see that you have your heart set on the trip. Fortunately, I have my great coat with me and two mufflers." He sighed. "But shall we have sufficient time at Charlock Bay?" "Well, I'm afraid it means staying the night there. You see, the tour goes round by Dartmoor. We have lunch at Monkhampton. We arrive at Charlock Bay about five o'clock, and the coach starts back at five, arriving here at six o'clock."

./ "DOUBLE SIN ; 11 "So!" said Poirot. "And there are people who do this for pleasure! We shall, of course, get a reduction of the fares since we do not make the return journey?" "I hardly think that's likely." " ; j ? , , , , "You must insist." "Come now, Poirot, don't be mean. You know

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you're.coming money.""My friend, it is not the meanness. It is the business „sense. If I were a millionaire, I would pay only what was;just and right." . |HAs I had foreseen, however, Poirot'was doomed to failin this respect. The gentleman who issued tickets at theSpeedy office was calm and unimpassioned but adamant.His point was that we ought to return. He even impliedthat we ought to pay extra for the privilege of leaving thecoach at Charlock Bay.Defeated, Poirot paid over the required sum and left theoffice. ^ "The English, they have no sense of money," he grumbled."Did you observe a young man, Hastings, who paid overthe full fare and yet mentioned his intention of leaving thecoach at Monkhampton?" :1:" '5^'- W^ff.

"S^"I don't .think I did. As a matter of fact;. ." """" v!""You were observing the pretty young lady who bookedNo. 5, the next seat to ours. Ah! Yes, my

friend, I saw you. And that is why when I was on the point of taking seats No. 13 and 14--which are in the middle and as well sheltered as it is possible to be--you rudely pushed yourself forward and said that 3 and 4 would be better." "Really, Poirot," I said, blushing. " "

"Auburn hair--always the auburn hair!"

"At any rate, she was more worth looking at than an odd young man."

"That depends upon the point of view. To me, the young man was interesting."

Something rather significant in Poirot's tone made me look at him quickly. "Why? What do you mean?"

"Oh! Do not excite yourself. Shall I say that he interested me because he was trying to grow a mustache and as yet

the result is poor." Poirot stroked his own magnificent 12 AGATHA CHRISTIE

mustache tenderly. "It is an art," he murmured, "the growing of the mustache! I have sympathy for all who attempt it."

It is always difficult with Poirot to know when he is serious and when he is merely amusing himself at one's expense. I judged it safest to say no more.

The following morning dawned bright and sunny. / really glorious day! Poirot, however, was taking no chances. He wore a woolly waistcoat, a mackintosh, a heavy overcoat, and two mufflers, in addition to wearing his

thickest suit. He also swallowed two tablets of "Anti grippe" before starting and packed a further supply.

We took a couple of small suitcases with us. The pretty girl we had noticed the day before had a small suitcase and so did the young man whom I gathered to have been the object of Poirot's sympathy. Otherwise, there was no luggage. The four pieces were stowed away by the driver and we all took our places.

Poirot, rather maliciously, I thought, assigned me this outside place as "I had the mania for the fresh air" and himself occupied the seat next to our fair neighbor. Presently, however, he made amends. The man in seat 6 was a

noisy fellow, inclined to be facetious and boisterous, and

Poirot asked the girl in a low voice if she would like to change seats with him. She agreed gratefully, and the change having been effected, she entered into conversation

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with us and we were soon all three chattering together merrily.

She was evidently quite young, not more than nineteen and as ingenuous as a child. She soon confided to us the reason for her trip. She was going, it seemed, on business for her aunt who kept a most interesting antique shop in Ebermouth.

This aunt had been left in very reduced circumstance; on the death of her father and had used her small capital and a houseful of beautiful things which her father had left to start in business. She had been extremely successful and had made quite a name for herself in the trade. This girl, Mary Durrant, had come to be with her aunt and to learn the business and was very excited about it—much

DOUBLE SIN 13

preferring it to the other alternative--becoming a nursery governess or companion.

Poirot nodded interest and approval to all this.

"Mademoiselle will be successful, I am sure," he said gallantly. "But I will give her a little word of advice. Do; j,|^ not be too trusting, mademoiselle. Everywhere in the world"1'"-"there are rogues and vagabonds, even it may be on this very coach of ours. One should always be on the guard, suspicious!" She

stared at him open-mouthed, and he nodded not wisely. "But yes, it is as I say. Who knows? Even I who speak to you may be a malefactor of the worst description." And he twinkled more than ever at her surprised face. We stopped for lunch at Monkhampton, and, after a few words with the waiter, Poirot managed to secure us a small table for three close by the window. Outside, in a big courtyard, about twenty char-a-bancs were parked--char-a-bancs which had come from all over the county. The hotel dining room was full, and the noise was rather considerable, if "One can have altogether too much of the holiday spirit," I said with a grimace. Mary Durrant agreed. "Ebermouth is quite spoiled in the summers nowadays. My aunt says it used to be quite different. Now one can hardly get along the pavements for the crowd."

, "But it is good for business, mademoiselle." <y^ "Not for ours particularly. We sell only rare and valuable things. We do not go in for cheap bric-a-brac. My aunt has clients all over England.

If they want a particular period table or chair, or a certain piece of china, they write to her, and, sooner or later, she gets it for them. That is what has happened in this case." We looked interested and she went on to explain. A certain American gentleman, Mr. J. Baker Wood, was a connoisseur and collector of miniatures. A very valuable set of miniatures had recently come into the market, and Miss Elizabeth Perm--Mary's aunt had purchased them. She had written to Mr.

Wood describing the miniatures and

flaming a price prepared to pay. I said asking him to see where I had according "They're lo imagine any hundred pound. Cosway I me; Poirot sir it. mademoiselle? "I've had none brought up to her. She sighed. prise. She was now dire. With a hurrit ran out of the breathless and "I'm so sorry man taking after him, and exactly like mine. Were accusing her. She laughed. Poirot, how mademoiselle? D "He had one. a very interesting "Aha," said You know him before?" "No, never," Nothing. 1 He relapsed conversation in attention. "Eh, madei" I said the careful of 'n DOUBLE SIN 15 Wood always pays for things in cash. If I have five hundred pounds in notes on me, I shall be worth some malefactor's attention." She laughed but again Poirot did not respond. Instead, he asked her what hotel she proposed to stay at in Charlock Bay. "The Anchor Hotel. It is small and not expensive, but quite good." "So!" said Poirot. "The Anchor Hotel. Precisely where Hastings here has made up his mind to stay. How odd!" He twinkled at **Page 3**

me. "tfrt- ^!. "You are staying long in Charlock Bay?" asked Mary. "One night only. I have business there. You could not guess, I am sure, what my profession is, mademoiselle?" I saw Mary consider several possibilities and reject them--probably from a feeling of caution. At last, she hazarded the suggestion that Poirot was a conjurer. He was vastly entertained. "Ah! But it is an idea that! You think I take the rabbits out of the hat? No, mademoiselle. Me, I am the opposite of a conjurer. The conjurer, he makes things disappear. Me, I make things that have disappeared, reappear." He leaned forward dramatically so as to give the words full effect. "It is a secret, mademoiselle, but I will tell you, I am a detective!" He leaned back in his chair pleased with the effect he had created. Mary Durrant stared at him spellbound. But any further conversation was barred for the braying of various horns outside announced that the road monsters were ready to proceed. ^/As Poirot and I went out together I commented on the charm of our luncheon companion. Poirot agreed. (, "?:;"Yes, she is charming. But, also rather silly?" "Silly?" "Do not be outraged. A girl may be beautiful and have auburn hair and yet be silly. It is the height of foolishness to take two strangers into her confidence as she has done." "Well, she could see we were all right." ; "That is imbecile, what you say, my friend. Anyone who knows his job--naturally he will appear 'all right.' That lit 16 AGATH/ tie one she talked of being five hundred pounds in moi B| hundred pounds with her noj "In miniatures." "Exactly. In miniatures. 1 there is no great difference,;. "But no one knows about II "And the waiter and the ni doubtless, several people|j Durrant, she is charming," Perm, I would first of all in common sense." He paused voice: "You know, my friend in the world to remove a sui banes while we were all at lui "Oh! Come, Poirot, someb" And what would they sei| gage. It would be done in i J ner, and it would be nobody|

"Do you mean--Poirot, arj in the brown suit--it was hi| Poirot frowned. "So it see 11 Hastings, that he should have I fore, when the car first arri'you notice."; "If Miss Durrant hadn't| dow, she wouldn't have see h| "And since it was his owrj mattered," said Poirot. "S<j thoughts, mon ami." || Nevertheless, when we haispeeding along once more, ting Mary Durrant a further 'j cretion which she received n| of thinking it all rather a jolt We arrived at Charlock : fortunate enough to get toj charming old-world inn in on Poirot had just unpackci applying a little cosmetic t(

DOUBLE SIN 17 going out to call upon Joseph Aarons when there came afrenzied knocking at Ae door. I called "Come in," and, to my utter amazement, Mary Durrant appeared, her face white and large tears standing in

her eyes. "I do beg your pardon--but--but the most awful thing has happened. And you did say you were a detective?" This to Poirot. "What has happened, mademoiselle?" "I opened my suitcase. The miniatures were in a crocodile dispatch case--locked, of course. Now, look!" She held out a small square crocodile-covered case. The lid hung loose.

Poirot took it from her. The case had been forced; great strength must have been used. The marks were plain enough. Poirot examined it and nodded.

"The miniatures?" he asked, though we both knew the answer well enough.

"Gone. They've been stolen. Oh! What shall I do?"

"Don't worry," I said. "My friend is Hercule Poirot.

You must have heard of him. He'll get them back for you if anyone can."

"Monsieur Poirot. The great Monsieur Poirot."

Poirot was vain enough to be pleased at the obvious reverence in her voice. "Yes, my child," he said. "It is I, myself.

And you can leave your little affair in my hands. I will do all that can be done. But I fear--I much fear--that it will be too late. Tell me, was the lock of your suitcase forced also?" .;

She shook her head.

"Let me see it, please." '

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--We went together to her room, and Poirot examined the suitcase closely. It had obviously been opened with a key.

"Which is simple enough. These suitcase locks are all much of the same pattern. Eh, bien, we must ring up the police and we must also get in touch with Mr. Baker Wood as soon as possible. I will attend to that myself."

I went with him and asked what he meant by saying it

might be too late. "Mon cher, I said today that I was the opposite of the conjurer--that I make the disappearing things reappear--but suppose someone has been beforehand with me. You do not understand?

You will in a minute."

B

IS AGATHA CHRISTIE

He disappeared into the telephone box. He came out five

minutes later looking very grave. "It is as I feared. A lady called upon Mr. Wood with the miniatures half an hour

ago. She represented herself as coming from Miss Elizabeth II Penn. He was delighted with the miniatures and paid for

them forthwith."

"Half an hour ago--before we arrived here."

Poirot smiled rather enigmatically. "The Speedy cars are quite speedy, but a fast motor from say, Monkhampton, | would get here a good hour ahead of them at least."

j "And what do we do now?"

"The good Hastings--always practical. We inform the

-police, do all we can for Miss Durrant, and--yes, I thinkj decidedly, we have an interview with Mr. J. Baker Wood."We carried out this program. Poor Mary Durrant wasterribly upset, fearing her aunt would blame her."Which she probably will," observed Poirot, as we setout for the Seaside Hotel where Mr. Wood was staying."And with perfect justice. The idea of leaving five hundredpounds' worth of valuables in a suitcase and going tolunch! All the same, man ami, there are one or two curiouspoints about the case. That dispatch box, for instance, whywas it forced?"

^, .,.;.^ _I "To get out the miniatures."("But was not that a foolishness? Say our thief is tamperingwith the luggage at lunch time under the pretext of gettingout his own. Surely it is much simpler to open the suit^case,transfer the dispatch case unopened to his own suitcase, and get away, than to waste the time forcing thelockr ss: ^ "He had to make sure the miniatures were inside." Poirot did not look convinced, but, as we were just beingshown into Mr. Wood's suite, we had no time for more""discussion. ^; '/-,-.^ :-;.y I took an immediate dislike to Mr. Baker Wood.He was a large vulgar man, very much overdressed andwearing a diamond solitaire ring.

He, was blustering andnoisy. .,,Of course, he'd not suspected anything amiss. Whyshould he?

The woman said she had the miniatures all

DOUBLE SIN 19 ght Very fine specimens, too! Had he the numbers of thenotes? No, he hadn't.

And who was Mr.--er--Poirot, anywayto come asking him aU these questions? ."I will not ask you anything more, monsieur, except forone thing. A description of the woman who called uponyou. Was she young and pretty?""No sir she was not. Most emphatically not. A tallwoman, middle-aged, grey hair, blotchy complexion and abudding mustache. A siren? Not on your life.""Poirot," I cried, as we took our departure. "A mustache.Did you hear?" I^ K-,"I have the use of my ears, thank you, Hastings.""But what a very unpleasant man.""He has not the charming manner, no." ""Well, we ought to get the thief all right," I remarked."We can identify him.""You are of such a naive simplicity, Hastings. Do younot know that there is such a thing

as **Page 5**

an alibi?" "You think he will have an alibi?" Poirot replied unexpectedly: "I sincerely hope so." "The trouble with you is," I said, "that you like a thing to be difficult." "Quite right, mon ami.

I do not like--how do you say it--the bird who sits!" Poirot's prophecy was fully justified. Our traveling companion in the brown suit turned out to be a Mr. Norton Kane. He had gone straight to the George Hotel at Monkhampton and had been there during the afternoon. The only evidence against him was that of Miss Durrant who declared that she had seen him getting out his luggage from the car while we were at lunch. "Which in itself is not a suspicious act," said Poirot meditatively. After that remark, he lapsed into silence and refused to discuss the matter any further, saying when I pressed him, "I was thinking of the baches in general, and that I should be well advised to do the same. I discovered, however, that he had asked Joseph Aaron with whom he spent the evening--to give him every detail possible about Mr. Baker Wood. As both men were

20 AGATHA CHRISTIE staying at the same hotel, there was a chance of gleaning some stray crumbs of information. Whatever Poirot

learned, he kept to himself, however. 1

Mary Durrant after various interviews with the police,

had returned to Ebermouth by an early morning train. We ^lunched with Joseph Aarons, and, after lunch, Poirot an- p'

nounced to me that he had settled the theatrical agent's

problem satisfactorily, and that we could return to Eber- ', mouth as soon as we liked. "But not by road, mon ami; we a go by rail this time."

"Are you afraid of having your pocket picked, or of ;?

meeting another damsel in distress?"

"Both those affairs, Hastings, might happen to me on the train. No, I am in haste to be back in Ebermouth, because

I want to proceed with our case." , a'^ljAW"

"Our case?" -- :/

"But, yes, my friend. Mademoiselle Durrant appealed to me to help her. Because the matter is now in the hands of the police, it does not follow that I am free to wash my hands of it. I came here to oblige an old friend, but it shall never be said of Hercule Poirot that he deserted a stranger in need!" And he drew himself up grandiloquently. »

"I think you were interested before that," I said shrewdly.

"In the office of cars, when you first caught sight of that young man, though what drew your attention to him I don't know."

"Don't you, Hastings? You should. Well, well, that must | remain my little secret."

We had a short conversation with the police inspector in ,a charge of the case before leaving. He had interviewed Mr. f|

Norton Kane, and told Poirot in confidence that the young man's manner had not impressed him favorably. He had . blustered, denied, and contradicted himself.

"But just how the trick was done, I don't know," he confessed.

"He could have handed the stuff to a confederate who pushed off at once in a fast car. But that's just theory.

We've got to find the car and the confederate and pin the!thing down."

Poirot nodded thoughtfully. . ysr,

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DOUBLE SIN 21

"Do you think that was how it was done?" I asked him, as we were seated in the train.

"No, my friend, that was not how it was done. It was cleverer than that."

"Won't you tell me?"

"Not yet. You know--it is my weakness--I like to keep my little secrets till the end."

"Is the end going to be soon?"

"Very soon now."

We arrived in Ebermouth a little after six and Poirot

drove at once to the shop which bore the name "Elizabeth Penn." The establishment was closed, but Poirot rang the bell, and presently Mary herself opened the door, and expressed surprise and delight at seeing us.

"Please come in and see my aunt," she said.

She led us into a back room. An elderly lady came forward to meet us; she had white hair and looked rather like , a miniature herself with her pink-and-white skin and her blue eyes. Round her rather bent shoulders she wore a cape of priceless old lace.

"Is this the great Monsieur Poirot?" she asked in a low charming voice. "Mary has been telling me. I could hardly believe it. And you will really help us in

our trouble. You

will advise us?"

Poirot looked at her for a moment, then bowed.

"Mademoiselle Perm--the effect is charming. But you should really grow a mustache."

Miss Penn gave a gasp and drew back. '<:

"You were absent from business yesterday, were you not?"

"I was here in the morning. Later I had a bad headache and went directly home." ' >

"Not home, mademoiselle. For your headache you tried the change of air, did you not? The air of Charlock Bay is very bracing, I believe."

He took me by the arm and drew me toward the door.

He paused there and spoke over his shoulder.

"You must comprehend, I know everything. This little--farce--it must cease."

There was a menace in his tone. Miss Penn, her face ghastly white, nodded mutely.

Poirot turned to the girl.

"Mademoiselle," he said gently, "you are young and charming. But participating in these little affairs will lead to that youth and charm being hidden behind prison walls --and I, Hercule Poirot, tell you that that will be a pity."

Then he stepped out into the street and I followed him
bewildered.

"From the first, won ami, I was interested. When tha
young man booked his place as far as Monkhampton only

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I saw the girl's attention suddenly riveted on him. Now why? He was not of the type to make a woman look at him for himself alone. When we started on that coach, I had a feeling that something would happen. Who saw the young man tampering with the luggage? Mademoiselle and Mademoiselle only, and remember she chose that seat--a seat facing the window--a most unfeminine choice.

"And then she comes to us with the tale of robbery--the dispatch box forced open which makes not the common sense as I told you at the time.

"And what is the result of it all? Mr. Baker Wood has paid over good money for stolen goods. The miniature will be returned to Miss Penn. She will sell them and will have made a thousand pounds instead of five hundred. / make the discreet inquiries and learn that her business is in a bad state--touch and go. I say to myself--the aunt and niece are in this together."

"Then you never suspected Norton Kane?" .

"Mon ami! With that mustache? A criminal is either clean shaven or he has a proper mustache that can be relied on to move at will. But what an opportunity for the clever Miss Penn--a shrinking elderly lady with a pink-and-white

complexion as we saw her. But if she holds herself erect wears large boots, alters her complexion with a few unseemly blotches and--crowning touch--adds a few spars< hairs to her upper lip. What then? A masculine woman says Mr. Wood, and--'a man in disguise' say we at once."

"She really went to Charlock yesterday?" i""Assuredly. The train, as you may remember telling me left here at eleven and got to Charlock Bay at two o'clock DOUBLE SIN 23 Then the return train is even quicker--the one we came by. It leaves Charlock at four:five and gets here at six; fifteen. Naturally, the miniatures were never in the dispatch case at all. That was artistically forced before being packed. Mademoiselle Mary has only to find a couple of mugs who will be sympathetic to her charm and champion beauty in distress. But one of the mugs was no mug--he was Hercule Poirot!" I hardly liked the inference. I said hurriedly: "Then, when you said you were helping a stranger, you were willfully deceiving me."

That's exactly what you were doing." "Never do I deceive you, Hastings. I only permit you to deceive yourself. I was referring to Mr. Baker Wood--a stranger to these shores." His face darkened. "Ah! When I think of that imposition, that iniquitous overcharge; the same fare single to Charlock as return, my blood boils to protect the visitor! Not a pleasant man, Mr. Baker Wood, not, as you would say, sympathetic. But a visitor! And we visitors, Hastings, must stand together. Me, I am all for the visitors!" fc-^ I' . ' £, c^-

The ARCADIAN DEER hercule poirot stamped his feet, seeking to warm them. He blew upon his fingers. Flakes of snow melted and dripped from the corners of his mustache. There was a knock at the door and a chambermaid appeared. She was a slow-breathing, thickset country girl and she stared with a good deal of curiosity at Hercule Poirot. It was possible that she had never seen anything quite like him before. She asked, "Did you ring?" "I did. Will you be so good as to light the fire?" She went out and came back again immediately with paper and sticks. She knelt down in front of the big Victorian grate and began to lay a fire. Hercule Poirot continued to stamp his feet, swing his arms, and blow on his fingers. He was annoyed. His car--an expensive Messaro Gral--had not behaved with that mechanical perfection which he expected of a car. His chauffeur, **Page 8**

a young man who enjoyed a handsome salary, had not succeeded in putting things right. The car had staged a final refusal in a secondary road a mile and a half from anywhere with a fall of snow beginning. Hercule Poirot, wearing his usual smart patent leather shoes, had been forced to walk that mile and a half to reach the riverside village of Hartly Dene--a village which, though showing every sign of animation in summertime, was completely moribund in winter. The Black Swan had registered something like dismay at the arrival

of a guest. The landlord had been almost eloquent as he pointed out that the local garage could supply a car in

which the gentleman could continue his journey.

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Hercule Poirot repudiated the suggestion. His Latin thrift was offended. Hire a car? He already had a car--a large car--an expensive car. In that car and no other he proposed to continue his journey back to town. And in

any case, even if repairs to it could be quickly effected, he was not going on in this snow until next morning. He demanded a room, a fire, and a meal. Sighing, the landlord, ' ?'

showed him to the room, sent the maid to supply the fire, and then retired to discuss with his wife the problem of the meal.

An hour later, his feet stretched out toward the comforting blaze, Hercule Poirot reflected leniently on the dinner

he had just eaten. True, the steak had been both tough and , ,

full of gristle, the Brussels sprouts had been large, pale,

and definitely watery, the potatoes had had hearts of [stone. Nor was there much to be said for the portion of * stewed apple and custard which had followed. The cheese

had been hard and the biscuits soft. Nevertheless, thought

Hercule Poirot, looking graciously at the leaping flames,

and sipping delicately at a cup of liquid mud euphemistically called coffee, it was better to be full than empty, and after tramping snowbound lanes in patent leather shoes, to

sit in front of the fire was Paradise! < i5K ; . jsfc

There was a knock on the door and the chambermaid appeared.

"Please, sir, the man from the garage is here and would like to see you." 's!i? ';

Hercule Poirot replied amiably, "Let him mount."

The girl giggled and retired. Poirot reflected kindly that

her account of him to her friends would provide entertainment for many winter days to come.

There was another knock--a different knock--and

Poirot called:

"Come in." ; He

looked up with approval at the young man who entered

and stood there looking ill at ease, twisting his cap in

his hands.

Here, he thought, was one of the handsomest specimens

of humanity he had ever seen, a simple young man with the outward semblance of a Greek god. '

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agatha CHR1S11E g|

The young man said in a low, liusky voice, "About the car, sir, we've brought it in. And we've got at the trouble.

It's a matter of an hour's work or so." »;

Poirot said, "What is wrong witi it?" ||

The young man plunged eageiV into technical details.

Poirot nodded his head gently, lit he was not listening.

Perfect physique was a thing he admired greatly. There were, he considered, too many rat in spectacles about. He said to himself approvingly. Yes, a Greek God--a young shepherd in Arcady.

The man stopped abruptly. II was then that Hercule

Poirot's brows knitted themselves for a second. His first reaction had been esthetic, his seond was mental. His eyes narrowed themselves curiously as e looked up.

He said, "I comprehend. Yes, I;omprehend." He paused and then added, "My chauffeur he has already told me

that which you have just said." ||

He saw the flush that came to ie other's cheek, saw the fingers grip the cap nervously.

The young man stammered "Yes--er--yes, sir. I

know."

Hercule Poirot went on smoothly: "But you thought that you would also come and tell me yourself?"

"Er--yes, sir, I thought I'd better."

"That," said Hercule Poirot, was very conscientious of you. Thank you."

There was a faint but unmistakable note of dismissal in

the last words but he did not expect the other to go and he was right. The young man did not move. |||.

His fingers moved convulsively, crushing the tweed cap, and he said in a still lower, embarrassed voice:

"Er--excuse me, sir--but it's true, isn't it, that you're the detective gentleman--you're Mr. Hercule Poirot?"

He said the name carefully.

Poirot said, "That is so."

Red crept up the young man's face.

He said, "I read a piece about you in the paper."

"Yes?"

The boy was now scarlet. There was distress in his eyes--distress and appeal.

Hercule Poirot came to his aid.

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He said gently, "Yes? What is it you want to ask me?"

The words came with a rush now.

"I'm afraid you may think it's awful cheek of me, sir.

But your coming here by chance like this--well, it's too good to be missed. Having read about you and the clever things you've done, anyway, I said as after all I might as

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well ask you. There's no harm in asking, is there?"

Hereule Poirot shook his head. He said, "You want my help in some way?" w!&! ®"

The other nodded. He said, his voice husky and embar" rassed, "It's--it's about a young lady. If--if you could find her for me."

"Find her? Has she disappeared, then?"

"That's right, sir." .p.^< t- , »,

Hereule Poirot sat up in his chair?^ ' ' ;<, . ' .a

He said sharply, "I could help you, perhaps, yes. But the proper people for you to go to are the police. It is their job and they have far more resources at their disposal than I

have." ,... ,,,, ,.^,,^ ...,_.,:,,,.

The boy shuffled his feet. '? ^v. ^-lyN^ ^.sS^flw..

He said awkwardly, "I couldn't do that, sir. It's not like that at all. It's all rather peculiar, so to speak."

Hereule Poirot stared at him. Then he indicated a chair.

"Eh bien, then, sit down--what is your name?"

"Williamson, sir, Ted Williamson." ^w *»

"Sit down, Ted. And tell me all about it."

"Thank you, sir." -He drew forward the chair and sat down carefully on the edge of it. His eyes had still that appealing doglike look.

Hereule Poirot said gently, "Tell me."

Ted Williamson drew a deep breath.

"Well, you see, sir, it was like this. I never saw her but the once. And I don't know her right name nor anything.

But it's queer like, the whole thing, and my letter coming back and everything."

"Start," said Hercule Poirot, "at the beginning. Do not flatter yourself. Just tell me everything that occurred." ?

^ "Yes, sir. Well, perhaps you know Grasslawn, sir, that big house down by the river past the bridge?"

"I know nothing at all."

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"Belongs to Sir George Sanderfield, it does. He uses it in the summertime for week-ends and parties--rather a gay

lot he has down as a rule. Actresses and that. Well, it was

in last June--and the radio was out of order and they sent me up to see to it."

Poirot nodded.

"So I went along. The gentleman was out on the river

with his guests and the cook was out and his manservant

had gone along to serve the drinks and all that on the

launch. There was only this girl in the house--she was the

lady's-maid to one of the guests. She let me in and showed

me where the set was, and stayed there while I was working

on it. And so we got to talking and all that. Nita her

name was, so she told me, and she was lady's-maid to a

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Russian dancer who was staying there." |;

"What nationality was she, English?" ' fe

"No, sir, she'd be French, I think. She'd a funny sort of accent. But she spoke English all right. She--she was

friendly and after a bit I asked her if she could come out

that night and go to the pictures, but she said her lady

would be needing her. But then she said as how she could

get off early in the afternoon because as how they wasn't

going to be back off the river till late. So the long and the short of it was that I took the afternoon off without asking (and nearly got the sack for it too) and we went for a

walk along by the river." |,

He paused. A little smile hovered on his lips. His eyes

were dreamy, gg;

/ Poirot said gently, "And she was pretty, yes?" £

"She was just the loveliest thing you ever saw. Her hair was like gold--it went up each side like wings--and she

had a gay kind of way of tripping along. I--I--well, I fell

for her right away, sir. I'm not pretending anything else."

Poirot nodded.

The young man went on: "She said as how her lady

would be coming down again in a fortnight and we fixed

up to meet again then." He paused. "But she never came. I waited for her at the spot she'd said, but not a sign of her, and at last I made bold to go up to the house and ask for

her. The Russian lady was staying there all right and her

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maid, too, they said. Sent for her, they did, but when she

came, why, it wasn't Nita at all! Just a dark, catty-looking girl--a bold lot if there ever was one. Marie, they called

her. 'You want to see me?' she says, simpering all over. She must have seen I was took aback. I said was she the Russian

lady's-maid and something about her not being the one

I'd seen before, and then she laughed and said that the last maid had been sent away sudden. 'Sent away?' I said.

'What for?' She sort of shrugged her shoulders and stretched out her hands. 'How should I know?' she said. 'I was not there.'

"Well, sir, it took me aback. At the moment I couldn't

think of anything to say. But afterward I plucked up courage and I got to see this Marie again and asked her to get

me Nita's address. I didn't let on to her that I didn't even know Nita's last name. I promised her a present if she did.

what I asked--she was the kind as wouldn't do anything

for you for nothing. Well, she got it all right for me--an

address in North London, it was, and I wrote to Nita there

--but the letter came back after a bit--sent back through

the post office with no longer at this address scrawled on

it."

Ted Williamson stopped. His eyes, those deep blue

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steady eyes, looked across at Poirot. He said:

"You see how it is, sir? It's not a case for the police. But I want to find her. And I don't know how to set about it

K--if you could find her for me." His color deepened.

"I've--I've a bit put by. I could manage five pounds--or even ten."

Poirot said gently, "We need not discuss the financial

side for the moment. First reflect on this point--this girl, this Nita--she knew your name and where you worked?"-;" "Oh, yes, sir." ^ "She could have communicated with you if she had

wanted to?" w ;

Ted said iD01^ slowly, "Yes, sir." '-v- ,,,;>

Poirot look^1 at him thoughtfully, lISt".'

He rnumii""®'1. "And you still want very much to find her?"

The color s^Sed up in Ted Williamson's face. ;

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He said, "Yes, I do, and that's that! I want to marry her if she'll have me. If you'll only try and find her for me,

sir?"

Hercule Poirot smiled. He said to himself, "Hair like

wings of gold." Yes, I think this is the third Labor of Hercules.

If I remember rightly, that happened in Arcady.

' Hercule Poirot looked thoughtfully at the sheet of paper

on which Ted Williamson had laboriously inscribed a name and address.

Miss Valetta, 17 Upper Renfrew Lane, VI.15.

He wondered if he would learn anything at that address.

Somehow he fancied not. But it was the only help Ted could give him.

Seventeen Upper Renfrew Lane was a dingy but respectable street. A stout woman with bleary eyes opened the door to Poirot's knock.

"Miss Valetta?" " i

"Gone away a long time ago, she has."

Poirot advanced a step into the doorway just as the door was about to close. .

"You can give me, perhaps, her address?" &

"Couldn't say, I'm sure. She didn't leave one." '

"When did she go away?"

"Last summer it was." gy

"Can you tell me exactly when?" . SSk

A clinking noise came from Poirot's right hand where two half crowns jostled each other in friendly fashion.

The bleary-eyed woman softened in an almost magical manner. She became graciousness itself.

"Well, I'm sure I'd like to help you, sir. Let me see now.

August, no, before that--July--yes, July it must have

been. About the third week in July. Went off in a hurry,

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she did. Back to Italy, I believe." .

"She was an Italian, then?"

"That's right, sir."

"And she was at one time lady's-maid to a Russian dancer, was she not?"

"That's right. Madame Semoulina or some such name.

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Danced at the Thespian in this Bally everyone's so wild
about. One of the stars, she was."

Poirot said, "Do you know why Miss Valetta left her
post?"

The woman hesitated a moment before saying, "I
|couldn't say, I'm sure." ^>.

"She was dismissed, was she not?"

"Well--I believe there was a bit of a dust up! But mind you, Miss Valetta
didn't let on much about it. She wasn't

one to give things away. But she looked wild about it.

Wicked temper she had--real Eytalian--her black eyes all
snapping and looking as if she'd like to put a knife into you.

I wouldn't have crossed her when she was in one of her
moods!" ajs^~ ^S;:' y1'...' <

"And you are quite sure you do not know Miss Valeria's

present address?"

The half crowns clinked again encouragingly.

The answer rang true enough: "I wish I did, sir. I'd be only too glad to tell you. But there--she went off in a hurry and there it is!" .;., ;,

Poirot said to himself thoughtfully. Yes, there, it m,, t;;*'

1§^ I??' ^ Mis y^". Ambrose Vahdel, diverted from his enthusiastic account of the decor he was designing for a forthcoming ballet, supplied information easily enough.

"Sanderfield? George Sanderfield? Nasty fellow. Rolling in money but they say he's a crook. Dark horse! Affair

with a dancer? But of course, my dear--with Katrina. Katrina Samoushenka. You must have seen her? Oh, my dear

--too delicious. Lovely technique. The Swan of Tuolela--

you must have seen that? My decor! And the other thing of

Debussy, or is it Mannine, 'La Biche au Bois'? She danced

it with Michael Novgin. He's so marvelous, isn't he?"

"And she was a friend of Sir George Sanderfield?"

"Yes, she used to week-end with him at his house on the river. Marvelous parties I believe he gives."

"Would it be possible, mon cher, for you to introduce me to Mademoiselle Samoushenka?"

"But, my dear, she isn't here any longer. She went to

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Paris or somewhere quite suddenly. You know, they do say

that she was a Russian spy or something--not that I believe

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it myself--you know people love saying things like

that. Katrina always pretended that she was a White Russian--her father was a prince or a grand duke--the usual

thing! It goes down so much better." Vandel paused and |

returned to the absorbing subject of himself. "Now as I I was saying, if you want to get the spirit of Bathsheba ' you've got to steep yourself in the Semitic tradition. I ex- ;

press it by--" K|

He continued happily.

The interview that Hercule Poirot managed to arrange

with Sir George Sanderfield did not start too auspiciously.

The "dark horse," as Ambrose Vandel had called him, was slightly ill at ease. Sir George was a short square man

with dark coarse hair and a roll of fat in his neck.

He said, "Well, M. Poirot, what can I do for you? Er--

we haven't met before, I think?" 1,--

"No, we have not met." I'

"Well, what is it? I confess, I'm quite curious."

"Oh, it is very simple--a mere matter of information."

The other gave an uneasy laugh.

"Want me to give you some inside dope, eh? Didn't

know you were interested in finance."

"It is not a matter of les affaires. It is a question of a certain lady."

"Oh, a woman." Sir George Sanderfield leaned back in his armchair. He seemed to relax. His voice held an easier

note.

Poirot said, "You were acquainted, I think, with Mademoiselle Katrina Samoushenka?"

Sanderfield laughed. "Yes. An enchanting creature. Pity she's left London."

"Why did she leave London?"

"My dear fellow, I don't know. Row with the management, I believe. She was temperamental, you know--very

Russian in her moods. I'm sorry that I can't help you but I

haven't the least idea where she is now. I haven't kept up

with her at all."

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There was a note of dismissal in his voice as he rose to his feet.

Poirot said, "But it is not Mademoiselle Samoushenka

that I am anxious to trace."

"It isn't?"

"No, it is a question of her maid."

"Her maid?"

Sanderfield stared at him.

Poirot said, "Do you--perhaps--remember her maid?"

All Sanderfield's uneasiness had returned.

He said awkwardly, "No, how should I? I remember she

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had one, of course. Bit of a bad lot, too, I should say.

Sneaking, prying sort of girl. If I were you I shouldn't put any faith in a word that girl says. She's the kind of girl

who's a born liar."

Poirot murmured, "So actually you remember quite a lot about her?"

Sanderfield said hastily, "Just an impression, that's all.

Don't even remember her name. Let me see, Marie something or other--no, I'm afraid I can't help you to get hold of her. Sorry."

Poirot said gently, "I have already got the name of Marie Hellin from the Thespian Theater--and her address. But

I am speaking, Sir George, of the maid who was with Mademoiselle Samoushenka before Marie Hellin. I am speaking of Nita Valetta."

Sanderfield stared.

He said, "Don't remember her at all. Marie's the only one / remember. Little dark girl with a nasty look in her eye."

Poirot said, "The girl I mean was at your house, Grasslawn, last July." '

Sanderfield said sulkily, "Well, all I can say is I don't remember her. Don't

believe she had a maid with her. I

think you're making a mistake."

Hercule Poirot shook his head. He did not think he was making a mistake.

Marie Hellin looked swiftly at Poirot out of small intelli-

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gent eyes and as swiftly away again. She said in smooth, even tones:

"But I remember perfectly, Monsieur. I was engaged by Madame Samoushenka the last week in July. Her former maid had departed in a hurry." ∴ 1

"Did you ever hear why that maid left?" '

"She went--suddenly--that is all I know! It may have been illness--something of that kind. Madame did not say."

Poirot said, "Did you find your mistress easy to get on with?"

The girl shrugged her shoulders.

"She had great moods. She wept and laughed in turns.

Sometimes she was so despondent she would not speak or

eat. Sometimes she was wildly gay. They are like that, these dancers. It is temperament."

"And Sir George?"

The girl looked up alertly. An unpleasant gleam came into her eyes.

"Ah, Sir George Sanderfield? You would like to know about him? Perhaps it is that that you really want to know? The other was only an excuse, eh? Ah, Sir George, I could

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tell you some curious things about him, I could tell you--"

Poirot interrupted. "It is not necessary."

She stared at him, her mouth open. Angry disappointments showed in her eyes. , ;-, , "I always say you know everything, Alexis Pavlovitch." Hercule Poirot murmured the words with his most flattering intonation. , He was reflecting to himself that this third Labor of Hercules had necessitated more traveling and more interviews than could have been imagined possible. This little matter of a missing lady's-maid was proving one of the most and most difficult problems he had ever tackled. Every clue, when examined, led exactly nowhere. , It had brought him this evening to the Samovar Restaurant in Paris whose proprietor, Count Alexis Pavlovitch, prided himself on knowing everything that went on in the artistic world.

THE ARCADIAN DEER 35 He nodded now complacently. "Yes, yes, my friend, / know--I always know. You ask me where she is gone--the little Samoushenka, the exquisite dancer? Ah! she was the real thing, that little one." He kissed his finger tips. "What fire--what abandon! She would have gone far--she would have been the Premiere Ballerina of her day--and then suddenly it all ends--she creeps away--to the end of the world--and soon, ah! so soon, they forget her." "Where is she then?" demanded Poirot. "In Switzerland. At Vagray les Alpes. It is there that they go, those who have the little dry cough and who grow thinner and thinner. She will die, yes, she will die!

She has a fatalistic nature. She will surely die." Poirot coughed to break the tragic spell. He wanted information. "You do not, by chance, remember a maid she had? A maid called Nita Valetta?" "Valetta? Valetta I remember seeing a maid once--at the station when I was seeing Katrina off to London. She was an Italian from Pisa, was she not? Yes, I am sure she was an Italian who came from Pisa." Hercule Poirot groaned. "In that case," he said, "I must now journey to Pisa." Hercule Poirot stood in the Campo Santo at Pisa and looked down on a grave. So it was here that his quest had come to an end--hereby this humble mound of earth. Underneath it lay the joyous creature who had stirred the heart and imagination of a simple English mechanic. Was this perhaps the best end to that sudden, strange romance? Now the girl would live always in

the young man's memory as he had seen her for those few enchanted hours of a July afternoon. The clash of opposing nationalities, of different standards, the pain of disillusionment, all that was ruled out forever. Hercule Poirot shook his head sadly. His mind went back to his conversation with the Valetta family. The

36 " AGATHA CHRISTIE mother, with her broad peasant face; the upright, grief-stricken father; the dark, hard-lipped sister." It was sudden, Signore, it was very sudden.

Though for many years she had had pains on and off. The doctor gave us no choice--he said there must be an operation immediately for the appendicitis. He took her off to the hospital then and there. Si, si, it was under the anesthetic she died. She never recovered consciousness." The mother sniffed, murmuring, "Bianca was always such a clever girl. It is terrible that she should have died so young." ; < ^ Hercule Poirot repeated to himself, She died young. '- & That was the message he must take back to the young man who had asked for his help so confidently. ; ' She is not for you, my friend. She died young. "His quest had ended--here where the Leaning Tower was silhouetted against the sky and the first spring flowers were showing pale and creamy with their promise of life and joy to come. Was it the stirring of spring that made him feel so rebelliously disinclined to accept this final verdict? Or was it something else? Something stirring at the back of his brain--words--a phrase--a name? Did not the whole thing finish too neatly--dovetail too obviously? Hercule Poirot sighed. He must take one more journey to put things beyond any possible doubt. He must go to Vagray les Alpes. w|fe| ""'s ay y. Here, he thought, really was the world's end. This shelf of snow--these scattered huts and shelters in each of which lay a motionless human being fighting an insidious death. So he came at last to Katrina Samoushenka. When he saw her, lying there with hollow cheeks in each of which was a vivid red stain, and long, thin, emaciated hands stretched out on the coverlet, a memory stirred him.

He had not remembered her name, but he had seen her dance--had been carried away and **Page 17**

fascinated by the supreme art that can make you forget art. He remembered Michael Novgin, the Hunter, leaping and

THE ARCADIAN DEER 37 twirling in that outrageous and fantastic forest that the brain of Ambrose Vandell had conceived. And he remembered the lovely flying Hind, eternally pursued, eternally desirable--a golden beautiful

creature with horns on her head and twinkling bronze feet.

He remembered her final collapse, shot and wounded, and Michael Novgin standing bewildered, with the body of the slain Deer in his arms. Katrina Samoushenka was looking at him with faint curiosity. She said, "I have never seen you before, have I? What is it you want of me?"

Hercule Poirot made her a little bow. "First, I wish to thank you--for your art which made for me once an evening of beauty." She smiled faintly.

* "But also I am here on a matter of business. I have been looking, for a long time for a certain maid of yours--her

name was Nita."

"Nita?"

She stared at him. Her eyes were large and startled.

She said, "What do you know about--Nita?"

"I will tell you." ? ^,

He told her of the evening when his car had broken down and of Ted Williamson standing there twisting his cap between his fingers and stammering out his love and his pain. She listened with close attention.

She said when he had finished, "It is touching, that--yes, it is touching."

Hercule Poirot nodded. \$ a ';

"Yes," he said. "It is a tale of Arcady, is it not? What can you tell me, Madame, of this girl?"

Katrina Samoushenka sighed.

"I had a maid--Juanita. She was lovely, yes--gay, light of heart. It happened to

her what happens so often to those

the gods favor. She died young."

They had been Poirot's own words--final words--irrevocable words. Now he heard them again--and yet he

persisted.

He asked, "She is dead?"

"Yes, she is dead."

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Hercule Poirot was silent a minute, then he said:

"Yet there is one thing I do not quite understand. I asked Sir George Sanderfield about this maid of yours and he

seemed afraid. Why was that?"

There was a faint expression of disgust on the dancer's face.

"You just said a maid of mine. He thought you meant

Marie--the girl who came to me after Juanita left. She

tried to blackmail him, I believe, over something that she

found out about him. She was an odious girl--inquisitive^ always prying into letters and locked drawers."

, Poirot murmured, "Then that explains that"

i-^ He paused a minute, then he went on, still persistent:

' "Juamta's other name was Valetta and she died of an

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| operation for appendicitis in Pisa. Is that correct?" a " am He noted the hesitation, hardly perceptible but nevertheless

there, before the dancer bowed her head. „ sw , "Yes, that is right" ' ' BiBl |

Poirot said meditatively, "And yet--there is still a little point--her people spoke of her, not as Juanita but as Bianca." „ , Katrina shrugged her thin shoulders. ;?'4 ||

She said, "Bianca--Juanita, does it matter? I suppose

her real name is Bianca but she thought the name of Juanita

was more romantic and so chose to call herself by it"

"Ah, you think that?" He paused and then, his voice changing, he said, "For me, there is another explanation."

"What is it?" - j

Poirot leaned forward.

He said, "The girl that Ted Williamson saw had hair

that he described as being like wings of gold."

He leaned still a little farther forward. His finger just

touched the two springing waves of Katrina's hair.

"Wings of gold, horns of gold? It is as you look at it, it is whether one sees you as devil or as angel! You might be either. Or are they perhaps only the golden horns of the stricken deer?" 'll.-'

Katrina murmured, "The stricken deer . . ." and her voice was the voice of one without hope.

|Poirot said, "All along Ted Williamson's description,

THE ARCADIAN DEER 39 has worried me--it brought something to my mind--that something was you, dancing on your twinkling bronze feet through the forest. Shall I tell you what I think, Mademoiselle? I think there was a week when you had no maid, when you went down alone to Grasslawn, for Bianca Valetta had returned to Italy and you had not yet engaged a new maid. Already you were feeling the illness which has since overtaken you, and you stayed in the house one day when the others went on an all-day excursion on the river. There was a ring at the door and you went to it and you saw--shall I tell you what you saw? You saw a young man who was as simple as a child and as handsome as a god! And you invented for him a girl--not Juanita--but incognita--- and for a few hours you walked with him in Arcady." There was a long pause. Then Katrina said in a low hoarse voice: "In one thing at least I have told you the truth. I have given you the right end of the story. Nita will die young." "Ah, non!" Hercule Poirot was transformed. He struck his hand on the table. He was suddenly prosaic, mundane, practical. He said, "It is quite unnecessary! You need not die. You can fight for your life, can you not, as well as another?" She shook her head--sadly, hopelessly. "What life is there for me?" "Not the life of the stage, bien entendu! But think, there is another life. Come now, Mademoiselle, be honest, was your father really a prince or a grand duke, or even a general?" She laughed suddenly. "He drove a lorry." "Very good! And why should you not be the wife of a garage hand in a country village? And have children as beautiful as gods, and with feet, perhaps, that will dance as you once danced." Katrina caught her breath. "But the whole idea is fantastic!" "Nevertheless,"

said Hercule Poirot with great self-satisfaction, "I believe it is going to come true!"

^ w l-'E'yL ' "" I 'I^Ai.^: THE ADVENTURE OF JOHNNIE WAVERLY
iM^" a^ "; "you can understand the feelings of a mother," said Mrs. Waverly for perhaps the sixth time. She looked appealingly at Poirot. My little friend, always sympathetic to motherhood in distress, gesticulated reassuringly. "But yes, but yes, I comprehend perfectly. Have faith in Papa Poirot." "The police--" began Mr. Waverly. '^:, His wife waved the interruption aside. "I won't have anything more to do with the police. We trusted to them and look what happened! But I'd heard so much of M. Poirot and the wonderful things he'd done, that I felt he might possibly be able to help us. A mother's feelings--" Poirot hastily stemmed the reiteration with an eloquent gesture. Mrs. Waverly's emotion was obviously genuine, but it assorted strangely with **Page 19**

her shrewd, rather hard type of countenance. When I heard later that she was the daughter of a prominent steel manufacturer of Birmingham who had worked his way up in the world from an office boy to his present eminence, I realised that she had inherited many of the paternal qualities. Mr. Waverly was a big florid jovial looking man. He stood with his legs straddled wide apart and looked the Ugl type of the country squire. "I suppose you know all about this business, M. Poirot?" The question was almost superfluous. For some days past the paper had been full of the sensational kidnapping of little Johnnie Waverly, the three-year-old son and heir THE ADVENTURE OF JOHNNIE WAVERLY 41 of Marcus Waverly, Esq., of Waverly Court, Surrey, one of the oldest families in England. "The main facts I know, of course, but recount to me the whole story, Monsieur, I beg of you. And in detail if you please." "Well, I suppose the beginning of the whole thing was about ten days ago when I got an anonymous letter--beastly things, anyway--that I couldn't make head or tail of. The writer had the impudence to demand that I should pay him twenty-five thousand pounds--twenty-five thousand pounds, M.

Poirot!--Failing my agreement, he threatened to kidnap Johnnie. Of course I threw the thing into the waste paper basket without more ado. Thought it was some silly joke. Five days later I got another letter. 'Unless you pay, your son will be kidnapped on the twenty-ninth,' That was on the twenty-seventh. Ada was worried, but I couldn't bring myself to treat the matter seriously.

After all, we're in England. Nobody goes about kidnapping children and holding them up to ransom." "It is not a common practice, certainly," said Poirot. "Proceed, Monsieur." "Well, Ada gave me no peace, so--feeling a bit of a fool--I laid the matter before Scotland Yard. They didn't seem to take the thing very seriously--inclined to my view that it was some silly joke. On the 28th I got a third letter. 'You have not paid. Your son will be taken from you at twelve o'clock noon to-morrow, the twenty-ninth. It will cost you fifty thousand pounds to recover him.' Up I drove to Scotland Yard again. This time they were more impressed. They inclined to the view that the letters were written by a lunatic, and that in all probability an attempt of some kind would be made at the hour stated. They assured me that they would take all due precautions.

Inspector McNeil and a sufficient force would come down to Waverly on the morrow and take charge, it was said; "I went home much relieved in my mind. Yet we already had the feeling of being in a state of siege. I gave orders that no stranger was to be admitted, and that no one was to leave the house. The

evening passed off without any untoward incident, but on the following morning my wife

42 AGATHA CHRISTIE |was seriously unwell. Alarmed by her condition, I sent for Doctor Dakers. Her symptoms appeared to puzzle him. Whilst hesitating to suggest that she had been poisoned, I could see that that was what was in his mind. There was no danger, he assured me, but it would be a day or two before she would be able to get about again. Returning to my own room, I was startled and amazed to find a note pinned to my pillow. It was in the same handwriting as the others and contained just three words: 'At twelve o'clock.'"I admit, M. Poirot, that then I saw red! Someone in the house was in this--one of the servants. I had them all up, blackguarded them right and left. They never split one each other; it was Miss Collins, my wife's companion, who informed me that she had seen Johnnie's nurse slip down the drive early that morning. I taxed her with it, and she broke down. She had left the child with the nurserymaid and stolen out to meet a friend of hers--a man! Pretty goings on! She denied having pinned the note to my pillow--she may have been speaking the truth, I don't know. I felt I couldn't take the risk of the child's own nurse being in the plot. One of the servants was implicated--of that I was sure.

Finally I lost my temper and sacked the whole bunch, nurse and all. I gave them an hour to pack their boxes and get out of the house. Mr. Waverly's red face was quite two shades redder as he remembered his just wrath. "Was not that a little injudicious. Monsieur?" suggested ^Poirot.

"For all you know, you might have been playing into the enemy's hands." Mr. Waverly stared at him. "I don't see that. Send the whole lot packing, that was my idea. I wired to London for a fresh lot to be sent down that evening. In the meantime, there'd be only people I could trust in the house, my wife's secretary, Miss Collins, and Tredwell, the butler, who had been with me since

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I was a boy." "And this Miss Collins, how long has she been with you?" "Just a year," said Mrs.

Waverly. "She has been my alu-

THE ADVENTURE OF JOHNNIE WAVERLY 43 able to me as a secretary companion, and is also a very efficient housekeeper." - ^

"The nurse?" ^ --s

"She has been with me six months. She came to me with excellent references. All the same I never really liked her, although Johnnie was quite devoted to her."

"Still, I gather she had already left when the catastrophe occurred. Perhaps, Monsieur Waverly, you will be so kind

as to continue." '

Mr. Waverly resumed his narrative.

"Inspector McNeil arrived about 10:30. The servants had all left then. He declared himself quite satisfied with the internal arrangements. He had various men posted in the Park outside, guarding all the approaches to the house, and he assured me that if the whole thing were not a hoax, we should undoubtedly catch my mysterious correspondent.

"

"I had Johnnie with me, and he and I and the Inspector went together into a room we call the Council Chamber. The Inspector locked the door. There is a big grandfather clock there, and as the hands drew near to twelve I don't mind confessing that I was as nervous as a cat. There was a whirring sound, and the clock began to strike. I clutched Johnnie. I had a feeling a man might drop from the skies.

The last stroke sounded, and as it did so, there was a great commotion outside--shouting and running. The Inspector [^]lung up the window and a constable came running up.

| " 'We've got him, sir,' he panted. 'He was sneaking up through the bushes. He's got a whole dope outfit on him.'

"We hurried out on the terrace where two constables were holding a ruffianly looking fellow in shabby clothes, who was twisting and turning in a vain endeavour to escape.

One of me policemen held out an unrolled parcel which they had wrested from their captive. It contained a pad of cotton wool and a bottle of chloroform. It made my blood boil to see it. There was a note, too, addressed to me.

I tore it open. It bore the following words: 'You should have paid up. To ransom your son will now cost you fifty thousand. In spite of all your precautions he has been abducted at twelve o'clock on the 29th as I said.'

^ 44 AGATHA CHRISTIE i "I gave a great laugh, the laugh of relief, but as I did so I heard the hum of a motor and a shout. I turned my head. | Racing down the drive toward the South Lodge at a furious speed was a low, long grey car. It was the man who drove it who had shouted, but that was not what gave me a shock of horror. It was the sight of Johnnie's flaxen curls. The child was in the car beside him. ; "The Inspector let go a shout. "The child was here not a minute ago,'

he cried. His eyes swept over us. We were all there, myself, Tredwell, Miss Coffins. 'When did you see him last, Mr. Waverly?' "I cast my mind back, trying to remember. When the constable had called us, I had run out with the Inspector, forgetting all about Johnnie. 1 "And then there came a sound that startled us, the chiming of a church clock from the village. With an exclamation the **Page 21**

Inspector pulled out his watch. It was exactly twelve o'clock. With one common accord we ran to the Council Chamber, the clock there marked the

hour as ten minutes past. Someone must have deliberately tampered with it, for I have never known it gain or lose before. It is a perfect timekeeper." Mr. Waverly paused. Poirot smiled to himself and straightened a little mat which the anxious father had pushed askew. "A pleasing little problem, obscure and charming,"

murmured Poirot. "I will investigate it for you with pleasure. Truly it was planned a merveille." Mrs. Waverly looked at him reproachfully. "But my boy," she wailed. Poirot hastily composed his face and looked the picture of earnest sympathy again. "He is safe, Madame, he is unharmed. Rest assured, these miscreants will take the greatest care of him. Is he not to them the turkey--no, the goose--that lays the golden eggs?" "M. Poirot, I'm sure there's only one thing to be done--Pay up. I was all against it at first--but now! A mother's feelings--"

THE ADVENTURE OF JOHNNIE WAVERLY 45 "But we have interrupted Monsieur in his history," cried Poirot hastily. "I expect you know the rest pretty well from the papers," said Mr.

Waverly. "Of course. Inspector McNeil got on to the telephone immediately. A description of the car and the man was circulated all round, and it looked at first as though everything was going to turn out all right. A car, answering to the description, with a man and a small boy, had passed through various villages, apparently making for London. At one place they had stopped, and it was noticed that the child was crying and obviously afraid of his companion. When Inspector McNeil announced that the car had been spotted and the man and boy detained, I was almost ill with relief. You know the sequel. The boy was not Johnnie, and the man was an ardent motorist, fond of children, who had picked up a small child playing in the streets of Edenswell, a village about fifteen miles from us, and was kindly giving him a ride. Thanks to the cocksure blundering of the police, all traces have disappeared. Had they not persistently followed the wrong car, they might by now have found the boy." "i;»!>j" "Calm yourself, Monsieur. The police are a brave and intelligent force of men. Their mistake was a very natural one. And altogether it was a clever scheme. As to the man they caught in the grounds, I understand that his defence has consisted all along of a persistent denial. He declares that the note and parcel were given to him to deliver at Waverly Court. The man who gave them to him handed him a ten shilling note and promised him another if it were delivered at exactly ten minutes to twelve. He was to approach the house through the grounds and knock at the side

door."

"I don't believe a word of it," declared Mrs. Waverly hotly. "It's all a parcel of lies."

"En verite, it is a thin story," said Poirot reflectively.

"But so far they have not shaken it. I understand also that he made a certain accusation?"

His glance interrogated Mr. Waverly. The latter got rather red again.

46 AGATHA CHRISTIE |

"The fellow had the impertinence -to pretend that he recognized in Tredwell the man who gave him the parcel.

'Only the bloke has shaved off his moustache.' Tredwell, who was born on the estate!"

Poirot smiled a little at the country gentleman's indignation.

"Yet you yourself suspect an inmate of the house to have been accessory to the abduction."

"Yes, but not Tredwell." 3

"And you, Madame?" asked Poirot, suddenly turning to her.

"It could not have been Tredwell who gave this tramp

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the letter and parcel--if anybody ever did, which I don't believe-- It was given him at ten o'clock, he says. At ten o'clock, Tredwell was with my husband in the smoking room."

"Were you able to see the face of the man in the car, Monsieur? Did it resemble that of Tredwell in any way?"

"It was too far away for me to see his face."

"Has Tredwell a brother, do you know?"

"He had several, but they are all dead. The last one was killed in the war."

"I am not yet clear as to the grounds of Waverly Court.

The car was heading for the South Lodge. Is there another entrance?"

"Yes, what we call the East Lodge. It can be seen from the other side of the house."

"It seems to me strange that nobody saw the car entering the grounds."

"There is a right of way through, and access to a small chapel. A good many cars pass through. The man must

have stopped the car in a convenient place, and run up to

the house just as the alarm was given and attention attracted elsewhere."

"Unless he was already inside the house," mused Poirot.

"Is there any place where he could have hidden?"

to Waverly Court. If I arrive this afternoon, will it suit you?"

"Oh! as soon as possible, please. Monsieur Poirot," cried **Page 23**

Mrs. Waverly. "Read this once more."

She thrust into his hands the last missive from the enemy

which had reached the Waverlys that morning and

which had sent her post haste to Poirot. It gave clear and

explicit directions for the paying over of the money, and 'ended with a threat that the boy's life would pay for any, .;.;'

treachery. It was clear that a love of money warred with the essential mother love of Mrs. Waverly, and that the latter

was at last gaining the day.

Poirot detained Mrs. Waverly for a minute behind her

husband.

"Madame, the truth, if you please. Do you share your

husband's faith in the butler, Tredwell?"

"I have nothing against him. Monsieur Poirot, I cannot

see how he can have been concerned in this, but--well, I

have never liked him--never!" , "~

"One other thing, Madame, can you give me the address

of the child's nurse?"

"149 Netberall Road, Hammersmith. You don't imagine--" ..y:, A.:, AGATHA CHRISTIE

--ever do I imagine. Only--I employ the little"New And sometimes, just sometimes, I have a little idea--cells. Poirot came back to me as the door closed. |Poirot; Madame has never liked the butler. It is intolerable--"Sol eh, Hastings?" ^^ that, ehrefused to be drawn. Poirot has deceived me sooft I refij

now go warily. There is always a catch somewhere that I nifter completing an elaborate toilet, we set off for Nerii Aftei Road. We were fortunate enough to find Miss Jessieerall R*iers at home. She was a pleasant faced woman of thir. Witherive, capable and superior. I could not believe that shety-five, d be mixed up in the affair. She was bitterly resentful could the way she had been dismissed, but admitted that she of the been in the wrong.

She was engaged to be married to a had beiter and decorator who happened to be in the neigh.

pamtermood, and she had run out to meet him. The thing bourhoned natural enough. I could not quite understand. seemed'01. All his questions seemed to me quite irrelevant. Poirot.;y were concerned mainly with the daily routine of her They N at Waverly Court. I was frankly bored, and glad when life at rot took his departure.

Poirot 'Kidnapping is an easy job, man ami," he observed, a

'^" hailed a taxi in the Hammersmith Road and ordered it he haL drive to Waterloo. "That child could have been

to driucted with the greatest ease any day for the last three abducts."

years.'*! don't see that that advances us much," I remarked

"I <dly.

coldly s'au contraire, it advances us enormously, but enor"^^ usiy!

M you must wear a tie pin, Hastings, at least let it mousl in the exact centre of your tie. At present it is at least»

be in feenth of an inch too much to the right."

sixteei waveriy Court was a fine old place and had recenW

Waen restored with taste and care. Mr. Waverly sbowe(' been; Council Chamber, the terrace and all the various spo^ the Cnnected with the case. Finally, at Poirot's t^"^^,^ conneessed a spring in the wall, a panel slid aside, and a sb press(.ssage led us into the "Priest's Hole."

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passa "you see," said Waverly. "There is nothing here.

"^The tiny room was bare enough, there was not eve

THE ADVENTURE OF JOHNNIE WAVERLY 49

mark of a footstep on the floor. I joined Poirot where he

was bending attentively over a mark in the corner.

"What do you make of this, my friend?" ^There were four imprints close together.

"A dog," I cried. -W:

"A very small dog, Hastings."

"A porn."

"Smaller than a porn."

"A gryphon?" I suggested doubtfully.

"Smaller even than a gryphon. A species unknown to the Kennel Club."

I looked at him. His face was alight with excitement and satisfaction.

"I was right," he murmured. "I knew I was right. Come, Hastings."

As we stepped out into the hall and the panel closed behind

us, a young lady came out of a door farther down the passage. Mr. Waverly presented her to us.

"Miss Collins."

Miss Collins was about thirty years of age, brisk and Mert in manner. She had fair, rather dull hair, and wore

Nncenez.

At Poirot's request, we passed into a small morning

'oom and he questioned her closely as to the servants and particularly as to Tredwell. She admitted that she did not

ike the butler. ;;

"He gives himself airs," she explained.

They then went into the question of the food eaten by was . Waverly on the night of the 28th. Miss Collins delared

that she had partaken of the same dishes upstairs in ^sr sitting room and had felt no ill effects. As she was departing

I nudged Poirot.

"The dog," I whispered.

^ "Ah! yes, the dog!" He smiled broadly. "Is there a dog ^t here by any chance, Mademoiselle?"

JThere are two retrievers in the kennels outside."

^No, I mean a small dog, a toy dog."

No--nothing of the kind."

i Poirot permitted her to depart. Then, pressing the bell, 6 remarked to me: 50 . AGATHA CHRISTIE "She h'es, that Mademoiselle Collins. Possibly I shouldalso in her place. Now for the butler."Tredwell was. a. cH^njfiefiL 'ffifcYftodL. ^^tofti' ms Siorywith perfect aplomb, and it was essentially the same as thatof Mr. Waverly. He admitted that he knew the secret ofthe Priest's Hole. When he finally withdrew, pontifical to the last, I metPoirot's quizzical eyes. _|"What do you make of it all, Hastings?" .,-& ;1 ^ "What do you?" I parried.

5H "How cautious you become. Never, will the grey cells function unless you stimulate them. Ah!

but I will not tease you! Let us make our deductions together. What points strike us specially as being difficult?" "There is one thing that strikes me," I said. "Why did the man who kidnapped the **Page 25**

child go out by the South Lodge instead of by the East Lodge where no one would see him?"

"That is a very good point, Hastings, an excellent one. I will match it with another. Why warn the Waverlys before- 3hand? Why not simply kidnap the child and hold him for ransom?" "Because they hoped to get the money without being forced to action." "Surely it was very unlikely that the money would be paid on a mere threat?" "Also they wanted to focus attention on 12 o'clock, so that when the tramp man was seized, the other could emerge from his hiding place and get away with the child unnoticed." IT "That does not alter the fact that they were making a thing difficult that was perfectly easy. If they do not specify a time or date, nothing would be easier than to wait their chance, and carry off the child in a motor one, when he is out with his nurse."

;"Ye--es," I admitted doubtfully. "In fact, there is a deliberate playing of the farce! Now let us approach the question from another side. Everything goes to show that there was an accomplice inside the house. Point No. 1, the mysterious poisoning of Mrs. W»-

THE ADVENTURE OF JOHNNIE WAVERLY 51 verly. Point No. 2, the letter pinned to the pillow. Point No. 3, the putting on of the clock ten minutes- all inside jobs. And an additional fact that you may not have noticed. There was no dust in the Priest's Hole. It had been swept out with a broom." Now then, we have four people in the house. We can exclude the nurse, since she could not have swept out the Priest's Hole, though she could have attended to the other three points. Four people. Mr. and Mrs. Waverly, Tredwell, the butler, and Miss Collins. We will take Miss Collins first. We have nothing much against her, except that we know very little about her, that she is obviously an intelligent young woman, and that she has only been here a year." "She lied about the dog, you said," I reminded him. "Ah! yes, the dog," Poirot gave a peculiar smile.

"Now let us pass to Tredwell. There are several suspicious facts against him. For one thing, the tramp declares that it was Tredwell who gave him the parcel

in the village." "But Tredwell can prove an alibi on that point." "Even then, he could have poisoned Mrs. Waverly, pinned the note to the pillow, put on the clock and swept out the Priest's Hole. On the other hand, he has been born and bred in the service of the Waverlys. It seems unlikely in the last degree that he should connive at the abduction of the son of the house. It is not in the picture!" "Well, then?" "We must logically--however absurd it may seem. We will briefly consider Mrs. Waverly. But she is rich, the money is hers. It is her money which has restored this impoverished estate. There would be no reason for her

to kidnap her son and pay over her money to herself. Her husband, now, is in a different position.

He has a rich wife. « is not the same thing as being rich himself--in fact I have a little idea that the lady is not very fond of parting with her money, except on a very good pretext. But Mr. Waverly, you can see at once, he is bon viveur." I "Impossible," I spluttered. "Not at all. Who sends away the servants? Mr. Waverly. He can write the notes, drug his wife, put on the hands of the clock and establish an excellent alibi for his faithful retainer Tredwell. Tredwell has never liked Mrs. Waverly. He is devoted to his master, and is willing to obey his orders implicitly. There were three of them in it. Waverly, Tredwell, and some friend of Waverly. That is the mistake the police made, they made no further inquiries about the man who drove the grey car with the wrong child in it. He was the third man. He picks up a child in a village near by, a boy with flaxen curls. He drives in through the East Lodge and passes out through the South Lodge just at the right moment, waving his hand and shouting. They cannot see his face or the number of the car, so obviously they cannot see the child's face either.

Then he lays a false trail to London. In the meantime, Tredwell has done his part in arranging for the parcel and note to be delivered by a rough-looking gentleman. His master can provide an alibi in the unlikely case of the man recognizing him, in spite of the false moustache he wore. As for Mr. Waverly, as soon as the hullabaloo occurs outside, and the Inspector rushes out, he quickly hides the child in the Priest's Hole, and follows him out. Later in the day, when the Inspector is gone and Miss Collins is out of the way, it will be easy enough to drive him off to some safe place in his own car." "But what about the dog?" I asked. "And Miss Collins lying?" "That was my little joke. I asked her if there were any toy dogs in the house, and she

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said no--but doubtless there are some--in the nursery! You see, Mr. Waverly

placed some toys in the Priest's Hole to keep Johnnie amused and quiet."

"M. Poirot." Mr. Waverly entered the room. "Have you discovered anything? Have you any clue to where the boy has been taken?" i.-:

Poirot handed him a piece of paper.

. "Here is the address."

"But this is a blank sheet." «

"Because I am waiting for you to write it down for me."

"What the--" Mr. Waverly's face turned purple.

' "I know everything. Monsieur. I give you twenty-four hours to return the Jxsy. Your ingenuity will be equal to rs--

THE ADVENTURE OF JOHNNIE WAVERLY 53

I the task of explaining his reappearance. Otherwise, Mrs. Waverly will be informed of the exact sequence of events." Mr. Waverly sank down in a chair and buried his face in his hands.

"He is with my old nurse, ten miles away. He is happy and well cared for."

"I have no doubt of that. If I did not believe you to be a good father at heart, I should not be willing to give you another chance."

I "The scandal--"

"Exactly. Your name is an old and honored one. Do not jeopardize it again. Good evening, Mr. Waverly. Ah!

by the way, one word of advice. Always sweep in the cornersI " , WHERE THERE'S A WILL

"above all, avoid worry and excitement," said Dr.

Meynell, in the comfortable fashion affected by doctors.

Mrs. Harter, as is often the case with people hearing these soothing but meaningless words, seemed more doubtful than relieved.

"There is a certain cardiac .weakness," continued the doctor fluently, "But nothing to be alarmed about I can assure you of that. All the same," he added, "it might be as

, well to have an elevator installed. Eh? What about it?"

Mrs. Harter looked worried. |

Dr. Meynell, on the contrary, looked pleased with himself.

The reason he liked attending rich patients rather than poor ones was that he could exercise his active imagination in prescribing for their ailments.

"Yes, an elevator," said Dr. Meynell trying to think of something else even more dashing--and failing. "Then we shall avoid all undue exertion. Daily exercise on the level

on a fine day, but avoid walking up hills. And, above all, plenty of distraction for the mind. Don't dwell on your health."

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To the old lady's nephew, Charles Ridgeway, the doctor was slightly more explicit.

"Do not misunderstand me," he said. "Your aunt may live for years, probably will. At the same time, shock or

overexertion might carry her off like that!" He snapped his fingers. "She must lead a very quiet life. No exertion. No fatigue. But, of course, she must not be allowed to brood.

She must be kept cheerful and the mind well distracted." .

; "Distracted," said Charles Ridgeway thoughtfully. ^ j WHERE THERE'S A WILL 55

Charles was a thoughtful young man. He was also a young man who believed in furthering his own inclinations whenever possible. That evening he suggested the installation of a radio set. Mrs.

Harter, already seriously upset at the thought of the elevator, was disturbed and unwilling.

Charles was persuasive. "I do not know that I care for these newfangled things," said Mrs. Harter piteously. "The waves, you know. _the electric waves. They might affect me." Charles, in a superior and kindly fashion, pointed out the futility of this idea. Mrs. Harter, whose knowledge of the subject was of the vaguest but who was tenacious of her own opinion, remained unconvinced.

"All that electricity," she murmured timorously. "You may say what you like, Charles, but some people are affected by electricity. I always have a terrible headache before a thunderstorm. I know that." She nodded her head triumphantly. Charles was a patient young man. He was also persistent. "My dear Aunt Mary," he said, "let me make the thing clear to you." He was something of an authority on the subject. He delivered quite a lecture on the theme; warming to his task, he spoke of tubes, of high frequency and low frequency, of amplification and of condensers. Mrs.

Harter, submerged in a sea of words that she did not understand, surrendered.--
--^-"Of course, Charles," she murmured, "if you really think--" "My dear Aunt Mary," said Charles enthusiastically, "it is the very thing for you, to keep you from moping and all that." I The elevator prescribed by Dr. Meynell was installed shortly afterward and was very nearly the death of Mrs. Harter since, like many other old ladies, she had a rooted objection to strange men in the house. She suspected them, one and all, of having designs on her old silver.

56 AGATHA CHRISTIE ^ After the elevator the radio arrived. Mrs. Harter was left to contemplate the, to her, repellent object--a large, ugly-looking box, studded with knobs. It took all Charles's enthusiasm to reconcile her to it but Charles was in his element, turning knobs and discoursing eloquently. Mrs. Harter sat in her high-backed chair, patient and polite, with a rooted conviction in her own mind that the newfangled notions were neither more nor less than unmitigated nuisances. "Listen, Aunt Mary, we are on to Paris! Isn't that splendid? Can you hear the fellow?" "I can't hear anything except a good deal of buzzing or clicking," said Mrs. Harter. Charles continued to turn knobs. "Brussels," he announced with enthusiasm. "Is it really?" said Mrs. Harter with no more than a trace of interest. Charles again turned knobs and an unearthly howl echoed forth into the room. "Now we seem to be on to the Dogs' Home,"

said Mr. Harter, who was an old lady with a certain amount of spirit. "Ha, ha!" said Charles, "you will have your joke, won't you. Aunt Mary? Very good that!" Mrs. Harter could not help smiling at him. She was very fond of Charles. For some years a niece, Miriam Hart, had lived with her. She had intended to make the girl a heiress, but Miriam had not been a success. She was impatient and obviously bored by her aunt's society. She was in ways out, "gadding about" as Mrs.

Harter called it. In the end she had entangled herself with a young man of whose aunt thoroughly disapproved. Miriam had been returned to her mother with a curt note much as if she had been goods on approval. She had married the young man in question and Mrs. Harter usually sent her a handkerchief case or a table center at Christmas. Having found nieces disappointing, Mrs. Harter turned her attention to nephews. Charles, from the first, had been an unqualified success. He was always pleasantly deferential.

WHERE THERE'S A WILL 57 Hal told his aunt and listened with an appearance of **Page 28**

intense interest to the reminiscences of her youth. In this he was a great contrast to Miriam who had been frankly bored and showed it. Charles was never bored; he was always goodtempered, always gay. He told his aunt many times a day that she was a perfectly marvelous old lady. Highly satisfied with her new acquisition, Mrs. Harter had written to her lawyer with instructions as to the making of a new will. This was sent to her, duly approved by her, and signed. And now even in the matter of the radio, Charles was soon proved to have won fresh laurels. Mrs. Harter, at first antagonistic, became tolerant and finally fascinated. She enjoyed it very much better when Charles was out. The trouble with Charles was that he could not leave the thing alone. Mrs. Harter would be seated in her chair comfortably listening to a symphony concert or a lecture on Lucrezia Borgia or Pond Life, quite happy and at peace with the world.

Not so Charles. The harmony would be shattered by discordant shrieks while he enthusiastically attempted to get foreign stations. But on those evenings when Charles was dining out with friends, Mrs. Harter enjoyed the radio very much indeed. She [would turn on the switch, sit in her high-backed chair, and enjoy the program of the evening. ^It was about three months after the radio had been in? stalled that the first eerie happening occurred. Charles was absent at a bridge party. [

The program for that evening was a ballad concert. A well-known soprano was singing Annie Laurie, and in the "middle of Annie Laurie a strange thing happened.

There was a sudden break, the music ceased for a moment, the buzzing, clicking noise continued, and then that, too, died away- There was silence, and then very faintly a low buzz- 'ng sound was heard.

Mrs. Harter got the impression, why she did not know,

at the machine was tuned into somewhere very far away, and then, clearly and distinctly, a voice spoke, a man's ^ce with a faint Irish accent.

| wary--can you hear me, Mary? It is Patrick speak,

58 AGATHA CHRISTIE

ing, . . . I am coming for you soon. You will be ready,

won't you, Mary?"

Then, almost immediately the strains of Annie Laurie once more filled the room.

Mrs. Harter sat rigid in her chair, her hands clenched on each arm of it. Had she been dreaming? Patrick! Patrick's voice! Patrick's voice in this very room, speaking to her.

No, it must be a dream, a hallucination perhaps. She must just have dropped off to sleep for a minute or two. A curious thing to have dreamed--that her dead husband's

voice should speak to her over the ether. It frightened her just a little. What were the words he had said?

"I am coming for you soon. You will be ready, won't you. Mary?" ,^,|

Was it, could it be a premonition? Cardiac weakness.

Her heart. After all, she was getting on in years.

"It's a warning--that's what it is," said Mrs. Harter, rising slowly and painfully from her chair, and added characteristically,

"All that money wasted on putting in an elevator!"

She said nothing of her experience to anyone, but for the next day or two she was thoughtful and a little preoccupied.

And then came the second occasion. Again she was alone in the room. The radio, which had been playing an

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orchestral selection, died away with the same suddenness as before. Again there was silence, the sense of distance, and finally Patrick's voice, not as it had been in life--but a voice rarefied, faraway, with a strange unearthly quality.

"Patrick speaking to you, Mary. I will be coming for you very soon now--"

Then click, buzz, and the orchestral selection was in full swing again.

Mrs. Harter glanced at the clock. No, she had not been asleep this time. Awake and in full possession of her faculties,

she had heard Patrick's voice speaking. It was no hallucination, she was sure of that. In a confused way she tried to think over all that Charles had explained to her of the theory of ether waves.

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Could it be that Patrick had really spoken to her? That his actual voice had been wafted through space? There were missing wave lengths or something of that kind. She remembered Charles speaking of "gaps in the scale." Perhaps the missing waves explained all the so-called psychological phenomena? No, there was nothing inherently impossible in the idea. Patrick had spoken to her. He had

availed himself of modern science to prepare her for what must soon be coming.

Mrs. Harter rang the bell for her maid, Elizabeth.

Elizabeth was a tall, gaunt woman of sixty. Beneath an unbending exterior she concealed a wealth of affection and tenderness for her mistress.

"Elizabeth," said Mrs. Harter when her faithful retainer had appeared, "you remember what I told you? The top

lefthand drawer of my bureau. It is locked--the long key with the white label. Everything there is ready."

"Ready, ma'am?" -'^f". ®j|'"

"For my burial," snorted Mrs. Harter. "You know perfectly well what I mean, Elizabeth. You helped me to put

the things there yourself."

Elizabeth's face began to work strangely. "Oh, ma'am,"

she wailed, "don't dwell on such things, I thought you was a sight better."

"We have all got to go sometime or another," said Mrs.

Harter practically. "I am over my three years and ten,

Elizabeth. There, there, don't make a fool of yourself. If

you must cry, go and cry somewhere else." :g®

Elizabeth retired, still sniffing. WK -'"

Mrs. Harter looked after her with a good deal of affection.

"Silly old fool, but faithful," she said, "very faithful. Let me see, was it a hundred pounds, or only fifty I left her? It ought to be a hundred."

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The point worried the old lady and the next day she sat down and wrote to her lawyer asking if he would send her her will so that she might look it over. It was the same day ^t Charles startled her by something he said at lunch.

"By the way. Aunt Mary," he said, "who is that funny: DU

old josser up in the spi

I telpiece, I mean. The '

| whiskers?"

Mrs. Harter looked:

"That is your Uncle

["Oh, I say. Aunt :

mean to be rude."

Mrs. Harter accepte

of the head.

Charles went on r.

You see—"

He stopped undeci<

"Well? What were yoi

"Nothing," said C

sense, I mean."

For the moment th

ter that day, when th
to the subject.

"I wish you woulc
made you ask me aboi
Charles looked emi

"I told you. Aunt 1
of mine—quite absur

"Charles," said Mr

"I insist upon knowi

"Well, my dear au
him—the man in the
end window when I
Some effect of the 1
earth he could be, th
know what I mean.

one, no visitor or st
evening I happened 1
li was the picture over
is quite easily expl
and all that. Must h
realizing that I had
face at the window.'

"The end window^

"Yes, why?"

WHERE THERE'S A WILL 61

"Nothing," said Mrs. Barter.

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But she was startled all the same. That room had been her husband's dressing-room.

That same evening, Charles again being absent, Mrs. Harter sat listening to the wireless with feverish impatience.

If for the third time she heard the mysterious voice, it would prove to her finally without a shadow of doubt that she was really in communication with some other world.

Although her heart beat faster, she was not surprised when the same break occurred, and after the usual interval of deathly silence the faint faraway Irish voice spoke once more. P" ;,_""? j11.

"Mary--you are prepared now. ... On Friday I shall come for you. . . . Friday at half past nine. . . . Do not be afraid--there will be no pain. . . . Be ready. . . ."

Then, almost cutting short the last word, the music of the orchestra broke out again, clamorous and discordant.

Mrs. Harter sat very still for a minute or two. Her face had gone white and she looked blue and pinched round the . lips.^ 'ig / '.:?--; ': , "€'

Presently she got up and sat down at her writing desk.

In a somewhat shaky hand she wrote the following lines:

Tonight, at 9:15, I have distinctly heard the voice

of my dead husband. He told me that he would come ^ for me on Friday night at 9:30. If I should die on that 'K day and at that hour I should like the facts made known so as to prove beyond question the possibility of communicating with the spirit world.--Mary Harter. Mrs. Harter read over what she had written, enclosed it in an envelope, and addressed the envelope. Then she rang the bell which was promptly answered by Elizabeth. Mrs. Harter got up from her desk and gave the note she had just written to the old woman. "Elizabeth," she said, "if I should die on Friday night I should like that note given to Doctor Meynell. No"--as Elizabeth appeared about to protest--"do not argue with ^s^ou have often told me you believe in premonitions. I

^HA Christie self before I die, Mr. Charles y^ see to it." As before, Mrs. Harter cut ^^

Elizabeth's tearful protest. In pursuance of her intention the old lady spoke to her nephew on the subject the following morning. "Remember, Charles, that if anything should happen to me, Elizabeth is to have an extra fifty pounds." "You are very gloomy these days, Ami Mary,"

said Charles cheerfully. "What is going to happen to you? According to Doctor Meynell, celebrating your hundredth birthday in twenty y^rs or so" Mrs. Harter smiled affectionately at him but did not answer. After a minute or two she said, "What are you doing on Friday evening, Charles?" Charles looked a trifle surprised. "As a matter of fact, the E^g's asked me to go in and play bridge, but if you would rather I stayed at home--" "No," said Mrs. Harter with determination. "Certainly not. I mean it, Charles. On that night of all nights I should much rather be alone." Charles looked at her curiously, but Mrs. Harter vouchsafed no further information.

She was an old lady of courage and determination. She felt that she must go through it with her strange experience singlehanded. Friday evening found the house very silent. Mrs. Harter sat as usual in her straight-backed chair drawn up to the fireplace. All her preparations were made.

That morning she had been to the bank, had drawn out £50 in notes, and had

handed them over to Elizabeth despite the latter's tearful protests. She had sorted and arranged all her personal belongings and had labeled one or two pieces of jewelry with the names of friends or relatives. She had also written out a list of instructions for Charles. The Worcester tea service **Page 32**

was to go to Cousin Emma, the Sevres jars to young William, and so on. Now she looked at the long envelope she held in her hand and drew from it a folded document. This was her *WHERE THERE'S A WILL* 63 ^{^^} sent to her by Mr. Hopkinson in accordance with her wishes. She had already read it carefully, but now she looked over it once more to refresh her memory. It was a concise document. A bequest of £50 to Elizabeths, [^]hall in consideration of faithful service; two bequests of £500 to a sister and a first cousin, and the remainder to, her beloved nephew Charles Ridgeway. Mrs. Harter nodded her head several times. Charles would be a very rich man when she was dead. Well, he had been a dear good boy to her. Always kind, always affectionate, and with a merry tongue which never failed to please her. She looked at the clock. Three minutes to the half-hour. Well, she was ready. And she was calm--quite calm.

Although she repeated these last words to herself several times, her heart beat strangely and unevenly. She hardly realized it herself, but she was strung up to a fine point of overwrought nerves. Half past nine. The wireless was switched on. What would she hear? A familiar voice announcing the weather forecast or that faraway voice belonging to a man who died twenty-five years before? But she heard neither. Instead there came a familiar sound, a sound she knew well but which tonight made her feel as though an icy hand were laid on her heart. A fumbling at the front door--It came again. And then a cold blast seemed to sweep through the room. Mrs.

Harter had now no doubt what her sensations were. She was afraid. She was more than afraid

--she was terrified--And suddenly there came to her the thought:
Twenty-five years is a long time.

Patrick is a stranger to me now. Terror! That was what was invading her. A soft step outside the door--a soft, halting footstep. Then the door swung silently open--Mrs. Harter staggered to her feet, swaying slightly from side to side, her eyes fixed on the open doorway. Some- [^]ing slipped from her fingers into the grate. She gave a strangled cry which died in her throat. In the 64
AGATHA CHRISTIE dim light of the doorway stood a familiar figure with chestnut beard and whiskers and an old-fashioned Victorian coat. Patrick had

come for her! Her heart gave one terrified leap and stood still. She slipped to the ground in a crumpled heap. There Elizabeth found her, an hour later. Dr. Meynell was called at once and Charles Ridgeway[^] was hastily summoned from his bridge party. But nothing could be done. Mrs. Harter was beyond human aid. It was not until two days later that Elizabeth remembered the note given to her by her mistress. Dr. Meynell read it with great interest and showed it to Charles Ridgeway. "A very curious coincidence," he said. "It seems clear that your aunt had been having hallucinations about her dead husband's voice. She must have strung herself up to such a point that the excitement was fatal, and when the time actually came she died of the shock." "Auto-suggestion?" asked Charles.

"Something of the sort. I will let you know the result of the autopsy as soon as possible, though I have no doubt of it myself. In the circumstance an autopsy is desirable, though purely as a matter of form." Charles nodded comprehendingly. On the preceding night, when the household was in bed, he had removed a certain wire which ran from the back of the radio cabinet to his bedroom on the floor above. Also, since the evening had been a chilly one, he had asked Elizabeth to light a fire in his room, and in that fire he had burned a chestnut beard and whiskers. Some Victorian clothing belonging to his late uncle he replaced in the camphor-scented chest in the attic. ; As far as he could see, he was perfectly safe. His plan, the shadowy outline of which had first formed in his brain when Doctor Meynell had told him that his aunt might with due care live for many years, had succeeded admirably. A sudden shock. Dr. Meynell had said. Charles, that WHERE THERE'S A WILL 65 affectionate young man, beloved of old ladies, smiled to himself. When the doctor had departed, Charles went about his duties mechanically. Certain funeral arrangements had to be finally settled. Relatives coming from a distance had to have trains looked up for them. In one or two cases they would have to stay the night. Charles went about it all efficiently and methodically, to the accompaniment of an undercurrent of his own thoughts. A very good stroke of business.' That was the burden of them. Nobody, least of all his dead aunt, had known in what perilous straits Charles stood. His activities, carefully concealed from the world, had landed him where the shadow of a prison loomed ahead. Exposure and ruin had **Page 33**

stared him in the face unless he could in a few short months raise a considerable sum of money.

Well--that was all right now. Charles smiled to himself. Thanks to--yes, call it

a practical joke--nothing criminal about that--he was saved. He was now a very rich man. He had no anxieties on the subject, for Mrs. Harter had never made any secret of her intentions. Chiming in very appositely with these thoughts, Elizabeth put her head round the door and informed him that Mr.

Hopkinson was here and would like to see him. About time, too, Charles thought. Repressing a tendency to whistle, he composed his face to one of suitable gravity and went to the library. There he greeted the precise old gentleman who had been for over a quarter of a century the late Mrs.

Harter's legal adviser. The lawyer seated himself at Charles's invitation and with a dry little cough entered upon business matters. "I did not quite understand your letter to me, Mr. Ridgeway. You seemed to be under the impression that the late Mrs. Harter's will was in our keeping." Charles stared at him. "But surely--I've heard my aunt say as much." "Oh! quite so, quite so. It was in our keeping." "Was?" "That is what I said. Mrs. Harter wrote to us, asking that it might be forwarded to her on Tuesday last."

66 AGATHA CHRISTIE An uneasy feeling crept over Charles. He felt a far-off premonition of unpleasantness. "Doubtless it will come to light among her papers," continued the lawyer smoothly. Charles said nothing. He was afraid to trust his tongue. He had already been through Mrs. Harter's papers pretty thoroughly, well enough to be quite certain that no will was among them. In a minute or two, when he had regained control of himself, he said so. His voice sounded

unreal to himself, and he had a sensation as of cold water trickling down his back.

"Has anyone been through her personal effects?" asked the lawyer.

Charles replied that the maid, Elizabeth, had done so. At

Mr. Hopkinson's suggestion Elizabeth was sent for. She

came promptly, grim and upright, and answered the questions put to her.

She had been through all her mistress's clothes and personal belongings. She was quite sure that there had been no

legal document such as a will among them. She knew what the will looked like--her poor mistress had had it in her hand only the morning of her death.

"You are sure of that?" asked the lawyer sharply.

"Yes, sir. She told me so. And she made me take fifty pounds in notes. The will was in a long blue envelope.",,

"Quite right," said Mr. Hopkinson. Hft ^

"Now I come to think of it," continued Elizabeth, "that same blue envelope was lying on this table the morning after--but empty. I laid it on the desk." »y

"I remember seeing it there," said Charles. ||gg

He got up and went over to the desk. In a minute or two he turned round with an envelope in his hand which he handed to Mr. Hopkinson. The latter examined it and nodded his head.

"That is the envelope in which I dispatched the will on Tuesday last."

Both men looked hard at Elizabeth. '

"Is there anything more, sir?" she inquired respectfully.

"Not at present, thank you." ?"":, §5 ;

Elizabeth went toward the door. ; ; ,

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WHERE THERE'S A WILL 67

"One minute," said the lawyer. "Was there a lire in the rate that evening?"

"Yes, sir, there was always a fire."

"Thank you, that will do."

Elizabeth went out. Charles leaned forward, resting a

Shaking hand on a table. "What do you think? What are you driving at?"
Mr.

Hopkinson shook his head.

"We must still hope the will may turn up. If it does

not--"

"Well, if it does not?"

"I am afraid there is only one conclusion possible. Your aunt sent for that will in order to destroy it. Not wishing

Elizabeth to lose by that, she gave her the amount of her

legacy in cash."

"But why?" cried Charles wildly. "Why?" ,Mr.

Hopkinson coughed. A dry cough. S:J. "You have had no--er--disagreement with your aunt,

Mr. Ridgeway?" he murmured. ; ^? Charles gasped. """"

"No, indeed," he cried warmly. "We were on the kindest, most affectionate terms, right up to the end."

"Ah!" said Mr. Hopkinson, not looking at him.

It came to Charles with a shock that the lawyer did not believe him. Who knew what this dry old stick might not have heard? Rumors of Charles's doings might have come round to him. What more natural than that he should suppose that these same rumors had come to Mrs. Harter, and that aunt and nephew should have had an altercation on the subject?

But it wasn't so! Charles knew one of the bitterest moments of his career. His lies had been believed. Now that ^ spoke the truth, belief was withheld. The irony of it!

Of course his aunt had never burned the will! Of course--

His thoughts came to a sudden check. What was that

Picture rising before his eyes? An old lady with one hand Gaspd to her heart--

something slipped--a paper--falling

°" the red-hot embers- Charles's face grew livid. He heard a hoarse voice--his own--asking, "If that will's never found?"

68 AGATHA CHRISTIE

"There is a former will of Mrs. Harttrter's still extant. Dat.

ed September, 1950. By it Mrs. Hartersr leaves everything to her niece, Miriam Barter, now Miriam n Robinson."

What was the old fool saying? Miririam? Miriam with her

nondescript husband, and her four wwhining brats. AU his

cleverness--for Miriam! ?M;< ^ |

II The telephone rang sharply at his elbow. He took up the
'receiver. It was the doctor's voice, hearty and kindly.

"That you, Ridgeway? Thought you'd like to know. The

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autopsy's just concluded. Cause of death as I surmised. But as a matter of fact the cardiac trouble was much more serious than I suspected when she was alive. With the utmost

care she couldn't have lived longer than two months at the outside. Thought you'd like to know. Might console you more or less."

"Excuse me," said Charles, "would you mind saying that again?"

"She couldn't have lived longer than two months," said the doctor in a slightly louder tone. "All things work out for the best, you know, my dear fellow--"

But Charles had slammed back the receiver on its hook. He was conscious of the lawyer's voice speaking from a

long way off. :: |

"Dear me, Mr. Ridgeway, are you ill?" - <Curse them all! The smug-faced lawyer. That poisonous

old ass Meynell. No hope in front of him--only the shadow of the prison wall.

He felt that Somebody had been playing with him-- playing with him like a cat with a mouse. Somebody must

_be_laughing. ._. _ ^ - 1 I

GREENSHAW'S FOLLY

the two men rounded the corner of the shrubbery.

"Well, there you are," said Raymond West. "That's it."

Horace Bindler took a deep, appreciative breath.

"But my dear," he cried, "how wonderful." His voice rose in a high screech of esthetic delight, then deepened in reverent awe. "It's unbelievable. Out of this world! A period

piece of the best."

"I thought you'd like it," said Raymond West,

complacently.

"Like it? My dear--" Words failed Horace. He unbuckled the strap of his camera and got busy. "This will be one of the gems of my collection," he said happily. "I do think, don't you, that it's rather amusing to have a collection of monstrosities? The idea came to me one night seven years ago in my bath. My last real gem was in the Campo Santo at Genoa, but I really think this beats it. What's it called?" "I haven't the least idea," said Raymond. "I suppose it's got a name?" "It must have. But the fact is that it's never referred to round here as anything but Greenshaw's Folly." "Greenshaw being the man who built it?" "Yes. In 1860 or '70 or thereabouts. The local success story of the time. Barefoot boy who had risen to immense prosperity. Local opinion is divided as to why he built this house, whether it was sheer exuberance of wealth or whether it was done to impress his creditors. If the latter, it didn't impress them. He either went bankrupt or the next thing to it. Hence the name, Greenshaw's Folly." Horace's camera clicked. There," he said in a satisfied voice- "Remind me to show you Number 310 in my collection. A really incredible marble mantelpiece in the Italian manner."

He added, looking at the house, "I can't conceive of how Mr. Greenshaw thought of it all." "Rather obvious in some ways," said Raymond. "He had visited the chateaux of the Loire, don't you think? Those turrets. And then, rather unfortunately, he seems to have traveled in the Orient. The influence of the Taj Mahal is unmistakable. I rather like the Moorish wing," he **Page 36**

added, "and the traces of a Venetian palace." "One wonders how he ever got hold of an architect to carry out these ideas." "If- %!¥* |*^c 'Raymond shrugged his shoulders. ' ' Mfet""No difficulty about that, I expect," he said. "Probably the architect retired with a good income for life while poor old Greenshaw went bankrupt." "Could we look at it from the other side?" asked

Horace, "or are we trespassing?" "We're trespassing all right," said Raymond, "but I don't think it will matter." ^^ He turned toward the corner of the house and Horace skipped after him. "But who lives here? Orphans or holiday visitors? It can't be a school. No playing fields or brisk efficiency." "Oh, a Greenshaw lives here still," said Raymond over his shoulder. "The house itself didn't go in the crash. Old Greenshaw's son inherited it. He was a bit of a miser and lived here in a corner of it. Never spent a penny. Probably never had a penny to spend. His daughter lives here now. Old Lady--very eccentric." As he spoke Raymond was congratulating himself on having thought of Greenshaw's Folly as a means of entertaining his guest. These literary critics always professed themselves as longing for a weekend in the country, and were wont to find the country extremely boring when they got there. Tomorrow there would be the Sunday papers, and for today Raymond West congratulated himself on

suggesting a visit to Greenshaw's Polly to enrich Horace

Bindler's well-known collection of monstrosities.

They turned the corner of the house and came out on a

neglected lawn. In one corner of it was a large artificial

Sl- GREENSHAW'S FOLLY 71, rockery, and bending over it was a figure at the sight of - : ' .

which Horace clutched Raymond delightedly by the arm. ::'

"My dear," he exclaimed, "do you see what she's got on?

A sprigged print dress. Just like a housemaid--when there

were housemaids. One of my most cherished memories is

staying at a house in the country when I was quite a boy >i|§|

where a real housemaid called you in the morning, all crack-; ^y ^ ling in a print dress and a cap. Yes, my boy, really--a 4' -i '^^ cap. Muslin with streamers. No, perhaps it was the parlor- j'^^lls maid who had the streamers.

But anyway she was a reality housemaid and she brought in an enormous brass can of

hot water. What an exciting day we're having."

The figure in the print dress had straightened up and

turned toward them, trowel in hand. She was a sufficiently

startling figure. Unkempt locks of iron-grey fell wispily on vff, ' her shoulders and a straw hat, rather like the hats that 'ft^ horses wear in Italy, was crammed down on her head. The ; .;;

colored print dress she wore fell nearly to her ankles. Out ;:^^ of a weather-beaten, not too clean face, shrewd eyes sur- ;^ .

veyed them appraisingly. 1 ^

"I must apologize for trespassing. Miss Greenshaw,"

said Raymond West, as he advanced toward her, "but Mr.

Horace Bindler who is slaying with me--" ?;§! Ife

Horace bowed and removed his hat. ' *' "sl ,-, ;;

"--is most interested in--er--ancient history and--er-- ys:% fine buildings." : ,
;;

Raymond West spoke with the ease of a famous author (^ who knows that he is a celebrity, that he can venture where '

other people may not.

Miss Greenshaw looked up at the sprawling exuberance

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behind her.

"It is a fine house," she said appreciatively. "My grandfather built it--before my time, of course. He is reported

as having said that he wished to astonish the natives."

"I'll say he did that, ma'am," said Horace Bindler.

"Mr. Bindler is the well-known literary critic," said Raymond West.

Miss Greenshaw had clearly no reverence for literary cntlcs- She remained unimpressed. ^_I consider it," said Miss Greenshaw, referring to the 72
AGATHA CHRISTIE

house, "as a monument to my grandfather's genius. Silly fools come here and ask me why I don't sell it and go and

live in a flat. What would / do in a flat? It's my home and I live in it," said Miss Greenshaw. "Always have lived here."

She considered, brooding over the past. "There were three of us. Laura married the curate. Papa wouldn't give her

any money, said clergymen ought to be unworldly. She

died, having a baby. Baby died, too. Nettie ran away with

the riding master. Papa cut her out of his will, of course.

Handsome fellow, Harry Fletcher, but no good. Don'tthink Nettie was happy with him.

Anyway, she didn't livelong. They had a son. He writes to me sometimes, but ofcourse he isn't a Greenshaw. I'm the last of the Greenshaws." She drew up her bent shoulders with a certain pride,and readjusted the rakish angle of the straw hat. Then,turning, she said sharply: ,,,;"Yes, Mrs. Cresswell, what is it?"
-; ' ||*Approaching them from the house was a figure that,seen side by side with Miss Greenshaw, seemed ludicrouslydissimilar. Mrs. Cresswell had a

marvelously dressed head of well-blond hair towering upward in meticulously arranged curls and rolls. It was as though she had dressed her head to go as a French marquise to a fancy dress party. The rest of her middle-aged person was dressed in what ought to have been rustling black silk but was actually one of the shinier varieties of black rayon. Although she was not a large woman, she had a well-developed and sumptuous bosom. Her voice, when she spoke, was unexpectedly deep. She spoke with exquisite diction--only a slight hesitation over words beginning with "h" and the final pronunciation of them with an exaggerated aspirate gave rise to a suspicion that at some remote period in her youth she might have had trouble over dropping her h's. "The fish, madam," said Mrs. Cresswell, "the slice of cod. It has not arrived. I have asked Alfred to go down for it and he refuses." Rather unexpectedly, Miss Greenshaw gave a cackle of laughter. "Refuses, does he?" "Alfred, madam, has been most disobliging."

: >?.' GREENSHAW'S FOLLY - i* 73 Miss Greenshaw raised two earth-stained fingers to her lips, suddenly produced an ear-splitting whistle and at the same time yelled, "Alfred. Alfred, come here." Round the corner of the house a young man appeared in answer to the summons, carrying a spade in his hand. He had a bold, handsome face and as he drew near he cast an unmistakably malevolent glance toward Mrs. Cresswell. "You want me, miss?" he said. "Yes, Alfred. I hear you've refused to go down for the fish. What about it, eh?" "Alfred spoke in a surly voice. "I'll go down for it if you want it, miss. You've only got to say." , ^y "I do want it. I want it for my supper." ; g^ "Right you are, miss. I'll go right away." He threw an insolent glance at Mrs. Cresswell, who flushed and murmured below her breath. "Now that I think of it," said Miss Greenshaw, "a couple of strange visitors are just what we need, aren't they, Mrs. Cresswell?"

: ; Mrs. Cresswell looked puzzled. , ^i ""^1 "1*-^ "I'm sorry, madam--" ||N ^ ""::' | "For you-know-what," said Miss Greenshaw, nodding her head. "Beneficiary to a will mustn't witness it. That's

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right, isn't it?" She appealed to Raymond West.

"Quite correct," said Raymond.

"I know enough law to know that," said Miss Greenshaw,

"and you two are men of standing." >

She flung down the trowel on her weeding basket. !

"Would you mind coming up to the library with me?"

"Delighted," said Horace eagerly.

She led the way through French windows and through a

vast yellow and gold drawing-room with faded brocade on the walls and dust covers arranged over the furniture, then

through a large dim hall, up a staircase, and into a room ¹ the second floor. .
,

^B "My grandfather's library," she announced. :

Horace looked round with acute pleasure. It was a room from his point of view quite full of monstrosities. The

heads of sphinxes appeared on the most unlikely pieces of ., furniture, , ^m
which representing, he thought, Acre was a colossal br^{^ ^ ^ ^}

classical n^A and V[^]--d to take a photograph. L "A fine ^{ifs} of which he
Songe Raymo[^] of books," said miss_Or ^{^ ^ ^ ^} he

could ^d was already looking ^{^ ^ ^} book her<;l

of any re^e from a ^{so}f? book which appeared to

have been{i interest or, ^{^ ^ ^}biy bound sets of the

classics a[^] read. They were all sup^{^ ^} a gentleman's fV supplied ninety years B eriod were included.

^rary. Some no^{^ ° ^} „ having been read. }ut they too showeo Miss C} -. „ ;_ the drawers of a vast

desk. Fin[^]eenshaw was fEumbli[^]; ^ ^nt.

"MY vvXally she pulled cout ^rf^{^ ^} ^ oney to

someoneA[^]ffl," she explaimed[^] Go ^ ^ ^ I suppose

that[^]__or so they sazy. H 1[^] „. Handsome fel.

low, Ha[^] ^n of a horse, cope w[°]"

Don't se[^]ry Fletcher, biut a ^ ^is place. No, she went o^{^ ^}hy hi. son should m[^]i

^

"I-ve ma[^]::, as though ar[^]eri S 0[^] „, cresswell." ^ "You[^], deupmymindi.lmlea b _

"Yes. ^C ho[^]ekeeper?" ^ ^ will leaving h< all I've -Crve explainedl it ^m[^] her any ^ Saves n,C ^ and then I don^{^ ^} „, eeps heP;

the mar[^], ^ a lot in current expen ^ ^ ai[^]

minute.[^]C,. ^o ^."^hat[^]

ther wa[^]i very ^-dl-d[^]w&^ a very small w

nothing;[^]1[^] a working P1[^]1"

BY n.Cgt[°] ^eberse[^];^^^ded ^ ^ Picking „,y now Miss Q168[^]11[^] ,1 in the iri[^]

"^i[^]s^^^^ ^r[^],

momert Vghe handed the pen w _' repulsion "nk"0""1.

asked t{[^]t. feeling atnunexp^{^ ^} ^ ^. to[^]P[^] W to do. Then. he ^y ^ ^ y_

least six requests. ^ TM^

GREENSHAW pg^y 75

Horace took the pen from him ^ ^ded his own minute signature.

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"That's done," said Miss Greenshaw. .

She moved across to the bookcase, looking at them uncertainly, then she opened the door, took out a book, and slipped the folded paper inside.

"I've my own places for keeping things," she said. ;:

"Lady Audley's Secret," Raymond West remarked, catching sight of the title as she reached for the book.

Miss Greenshaw gave another fit of laughter.

"Best-seller in its day," she replied. "But not like your books, eh?"

She gave Raymond a sudden friendly nudge in the ribs.

Raymond was rather surprised that she even knew he wrote books. Although Raymond was not a "big name" in

the literature, he could hardly be ascribed as a bestseller. Though softening a little with the advent of middle-age, his

he dealt bleakly with the sordid side of life

"Wonder," Horace demanded breathlessly, "if I might see a photograph of the clock,?"

"Sybil means," said Miss Greenshaw; "It came, I be-

"from the Paris Exhibition."

"Very probably," said Horace. He found his picture. A room has not been used much, grandfather's

»dM,ss Greenshaw. "This desk's full of old diaries"

m my tt^? tblnk.1 ^^"t ^ eyesl^ to ""

was?" d Iget them Published, but I sup

would have to work on th,, ., ., . ,,

could « ^m a good deal. wuia engage someone to ., ,, ,, ., ,, i do that, said Raymond

ld I really, n, an idea, y^ ^ ^ ^ ^:

° _ West glanced at his w^,,

^"t trespass on your fc?011- I - kindness any longer, he

[to have seen you" sai,

r0"^ you were the t} s Greenshaw gfs-.,- ,

|HM the corner of th-^^^ when I ^^1\$

^1'ceman?" demand house"

' luestions. a Horace, who never

AGATHA CHRISTIE

Miss Greenshaw responded unexpectedly.

"If you want to know the time, ask a policeman' carolled, and with this example of Victorian wit sh> nudged Horace in the ribs and roared with laughter.

"It's been a wonderful afternoon," sighed Horace

they walked home. "Really, that place has everything. The'

only thing the library needs is a body. Those old-fashioned

detective stories about murder in the library--that's just

the kitd of library I'm sure the authors had in mind."

"If you want to discuss murder," said Raymond, "you must talk to my Aunt Jane."

"Your Aunt Jane? Do you mean Miss Marple?" Horace felt a little at a loss.

The charming old-world lady to whom he had been introduced

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the night before seemed the last person to be mentioned in connection with murder.

"Oh, yes," said Raymond. "Murder is a specialty of hers." s

"But my dear, how intriguing! What do you really mean?"

"I mean just that," said Raymond. He paraphrased:

"Some commit murder, some get mixed up in murders, others have murder thrust upon them. My Aunt Jane

comes into the third category." 'H m

"You are joking." "

"Not in the least. I can refer you to the former Commissioner of Scotland Yard, several Chief Constables, and

one or two hard-working inspectors of the C.I.D."

Horace said happily that wonders would never cease.

Over the tea table they gave Joan West, Raymond's wife- Louise Oxley, her niece, and old Miss Marple, a resume ^ the afternoon's happenings, recounting in detail everytriiin?

that Miss Greenshaw had said to them.

"But I do think," said Horace, "that there is something a little sinister about the whole setup. That duchess-like creature,

the: housekeeper--arsensic, perhaps, in the teapot, "0< that she knows her mistress has made the will in her favor?"

"Tell us. Aunt Jane," said Raymond. "Will there beI murder or won't there?"

What do you think?" I

GREENSHAW'S FOLLY 77

„think," said Miss Marple, winding up her wool with a
severe air, "that you shouldn't joke about these
things as much as you do, Raymond. Arsenic is, of course, quite a possibility.
So easy to obtain. Probably present in
the tool shed already in the form of weed killer."

"Oh, really, darling," said Joan West, affectionately.

"Wouldn't that be rather too obvious?"

"It's all very well to make a will," said Raymond. "I don't suppose the poor
old thing has anything to leave except that awful white elephant of a house,
and who would

want that?" :

"A film company possibly," said Horace, "or a hotel or an institution?"

"They'd expect to buy it for a song," said Raymond, but Miss Marple was
shaking her head.

"You know, dear Raymond, I cannot agree with you

there. About the money, I mean. The grandfather was evidently one of those
lavish spenders who make money easily

but can't keep it. He may have gone broke, as you say,

but hardly bankrupt or else his son would not have had

the house. Now the son, as is so often the case, was of an

entirely different character from his father. A miser. A

man who saved every penny. I should say that in the

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course of his lifetime he probably put by a very good sum.

But Miss Greenshaw appears to have taken after him--to

like spending money, that is. Yes, I should think it quite likely that she has quite a substantial sum tucked away."

"In that case," said Joan West, "I wonder now--what about Louise?"

They looked at Louise as she sat, silent, by the fire.

Louise was Joan West's niece. Her marriage had recently, as she herself put it, come unstuck, leaving her with two

young children and bare sufficiency of money to keep them on.

"I mean," said Joan, "if this Miss Greenshaw really wants someone to go through diaries and get a book ready for publication ..."

"It's an idea," said Raymond.

Louise said in a low voice, "It's work I could do--and I think I'd enjoy it."

78 AGATHA CHRISTIE |

"I'll write to her," said Raymond. |

"I wonder," said Miss Marple thoughtfully, "what the

old lady meant by that remark about a policeman?"

"Oh, it was just a joke." |

"It reminded me," said Miss Marple, nodding her head vigorously, "yes, it reminded me very much of Mr. Naysmith." "Who was Mr. Naysmith?" asked Raymond, curiously. "He kept bees," said Miss Marple, "and was very good at doing the acrostics in the Sunday papers. And he liked giving people false impressions just for fun. But sometimes it led to trouble." "3» .

Everybody was silent for a moment, considering Mr Naysmith, but as there did not seem to be any points of resemblance between him and Miss Greenshaw, they decided that dear Aunt Jane was perhaps a little bit disconnected in her old age. Horace Bindler went back to London without having collected any more monstrosities and Raymond West wrote a letter to Miss Greenshaw telling her that he knew of Mrs. Louise Oxiey who would be competent to undertake work on the diaries. After a lapse of some days a letter arrived, written in spidery old-fashioned handwriting, in which Miss Greenshaw declared herself anxious to avail herself of the services of Mrs. Oxiey, and making an appointment for Mrs. Oxiey to come and see her. Louise duly kept the appointment, generous terms were arranged, and she started work the following day. "I'm awfully grateful to you," she said to Raymond. "It will fit in beautifully. I can take the children to school, go on to Greenshaw's Folly, and pick them up on my way back. How fantastic the whole setup is! That old woman has to be seen to be believed." On the evening of her first day at work she returned and described her day. "I've hardly seen the housekeeper," she said. "She came in with coffee and biscuits at half-past eleven with her mouth pursed up very prunes and prisms, and would barely speak to me. I think she disapproves deeply of my ha'

eaged." She went on, "It seems there's quite a thing been going on between the gardener, Alfred. He's a local boyfeud between the gardener and the house-and won't speak to each other."

Miss Greenshaw said in keeping a grand way. There have always been feuds as far as her grandfather's

remember between the garden and the housestaff. as as go in my grandfather's time. There were three men and a boy in the garden then, and eight maids in the house, but there was always friction."

On the next day Louise returned with another piece of news. "Just fancy," she said, "I was asked to ring up the nephew today." "Miss Greenshaw's nephew?" "Yes. It seems he's an actor playing in the stock company that's doing a summer season at Boreham-on-Sea. I rang up the theater and left a message asking him to lunch tomorrow. Rather fun, really. The old girl didn't want the housekeeper to know. I think Mrs. Cresswell has done something that's annoyed her." "Tomorrow another installment of this thrilling serial," murmured Raymond.

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"It's exactly like a serial, isn't it? Reconciliation with the nephew, blood is thicker than water--another will to be made and the old will be destroyed." "Aunt Jane, you're looking very serious." "Was I, my dear? Have you heard any more about the policeman?" Louise looked bewildered. "I don't know anything about a policeman." "That remark of hers, my dear," said Miss Marple, "must have meant something." Louise arrived at her work the following day in a cheerful mood. She passed through the open front door--the doors and windows of the house were always open. Miss Greenshaw appeared to have no fear of burglars, and was probably justified, as most things in the house weighed several tons and were of no marketable value.

Louise had passed Alfred in the drive. When she first noticed him he had been leaning against a tree smoking a

AGATHA CHRISTIE as soon as he had caught sight of her he had told young
^^^ go^gone ^s she passed through the tunnels and ^, ^y upstairs to the
library, she glanced at the hall on the ^

Nathaniel Greenshaw which presided over large parties, showing him in the
acme of Victorianism on the ^yp ^g^yie stomach to the face with its her glan
^g bushy eyebrows and its flourishing black heavy Jovvis^ thought occurred
to her that Nathaniel must have been handsome as a young man.
He Greenshaw perhaps, a little like Alfred . . . had looked, ^^ ^ library on the
second floor, shut the door, i her, opened her typewriter, and got out the di^m
be (be drawer at the side of her desk. Through the; ; anes °, w she caught a
glimpse of Miss Greenshaw be open with ^e-colored sprigged print, bending
over the low, in ^gding assiduously. They had had two wet days, rockery^ w ^^
^^ ^ advantage of which the ^wn-bred girl, decided that if she ever had
a Louis.' (which never contain a rockery which needed garden, band. Then
she settled down to her work. Weeding, (rs. Cresswell entered the library with
the coffee hot-P3®1 s^^f' s^e was clearly in a very bad temper-tta5r ^i. tinged the
tray down on the table and observed per. t>"6 c

.. "prsc.to Ae uni^ ^ ^^ _ ^y^^g -^ ^g house! What is °. used to do, I should
like to know? And no sign of a supi"tt w^ sweeping in the drive when I got
here," Louise °T Lay. A nice soft job." :

She swept out of the room, slamming the door behind her- Louise grinned to herself. She wondered how it would be like to have coffee and settled down to her work.

Time was so absorbing that time passed quickly. She began to keep a diary, but

GREENSHAW'S FOLLY 81 succumbed to the pleasures of frankness. Typing out a passage relating to the personal charms of a barmaid in the neighboring town, Louise reflected that a good deal of editing would be necessary. As she was thinking this, she was startled by a scream from the garden. Jumping up, she ran to the open window. Below her Miss Greenshaw was staggering away from the rockery toward the house. Her hands were clasped to her breast and between her hands there protruded a feathered shaft that Louise recognized with stupefaction to be the shaft of an arrow. Miss Greenshaw's head, in its battered straw hat, fell forward on her breast. She called up to Louise in a failing voice: "... shot ... he shot me ... with an arrow ... get help ... " Louise rushed to the door. She turned the handle, but the door would not open. It took a moment or two of futile endeavor to realize that she was locked in. She ran back to the window and called down. "I'm locked in!" Miss Greenshaw, her back toward Louise and swaying a little on her feet, was calling up to the housekeeper at a window farther along.

"Ring police ... telephone ..." Then, lurching from side to side like a drunkard, Miss Greenshaw disappeared from Louise's view through the window and staggered into the drawing-room on the ground floor. A moment later Louise heard a crash of broken china, a heavy fall, and then silence. Her imagination reconstructed the scene. Miss Greenshaw must have "tumbled blindly into a small table with a Sevres tea set on it. Desperately Louise pounded on the library door, calling and shouting. There was no creeper or drainpipe outside the window that could help her to get out that way. At last she gave up. She returned to the window. From the window of her sitting-room farther along, the housekeeper's head appeared. "Come and let me out, Mrs. Oxley. I'm locked in." "Oh, dear, isn't it awful? I've telephoned the police -- There's an extension in this room, but what I can't understand, Mrs. Oxley, is our being locked in. I've never heard of a key turn, did you?" "No. I didn't hear anything at all. Oh, dear, what shall we do?"

82 AGATHA CHRISTIE . "Oh, dear, isn't it awful? I've telephoned the police -- There's an extension in this room, but what I can't understand, Mrs. Oxley, is our being locked in. I've never heard of a key turn, did you?" "No. I didn't hear anything at all. Oh, dear, what shall we do?"

extension in this room, but what I can't understand, Mrs. Oxley, is our being locked in. I've never heard of a key turn, did you?" "No. I didn't hear anything at all. Oh, dear, what shall we do?"

Perhaps Alfred might hear us." Louise shouted at the top of her voice, "Alfred, Alfred." "Gone to his dinner as likely as not. What time is it?" Louise glanced at her watch. "Twenty-five past twelve." "He's not supposed to go until half-past, but he sneaks off earlier whenever he can." "Do you think--do you think--" Louise meant to ask "Do you think she's dead?"--but the words stuck in her throat.

There was nothing to do but wait. She sat down on the window sill. It seemed an eternity before the stolid helmeted figure of a police constable came round the corner of the house. She leaned out of the window and he looked up at her, shading his eyes with his hand. "What's going on here?" he demanded, "From their respective windows, Louise and Mrs. Cresswell poured a flood of excited information down on him. The constable produced a notebook and a pencil.

"You ladies ran upstairs and locked yourselves in? Can I have your names, please?"

"Somebody locked us in. Come and let us out." "H, The constable said reprovingly, "All in good time," and disappeared through the French window below. Once again time seemed infinite. Louise heard the sound of a car arriving, and, after what seemed an hour, but was actually only three minutes, first Mrs. Cresswell and then Louise were released by a police sergeant more alert than the original constable. "Miss Greenshaw?" Louise's voice faltered. "What--what's happened?" "The sergeant cleared his throat. "I'm sorry to have to tell you, madam," he said,

"was

GREENSHAW'S FOLLY 83 , "said Mrs. Cresswell here. Miss Greenshaw is five and a half murdered," said Mrs. Cresswell. "That's what it is--" "The sergeant said dubiously, "Could have been an accident--some country lads shooting arrows." "Again there was the sound of a car arriving. "The sergeant said, "That'll be the M.O." and he started downstairs, lift. "But it was not the M.O. As Louise and Mrs. Cresswell went down the stairs, a young man stepped hesitatingly through the front door and paused, looking round him with a somewhat bewildered air. "Then, speaking in a pleasant voice that in some way seemed familiar to Louise--perhaps it reminded her of Miss Greenshaw's--he asked, "Excuse me, does--er--does Miss Greenshaw live here?" "May I have your name if you please," said the sergeant, advancing upon him. "Fletcher," said the young man. "Nat Fletcher.

I'm Miss Greenshaw's nephew, as a matter of fact." "Indeed, sir, well--I'm sorry--" ;a* "Has anything happened?" asked Nat Fletcher. "There's been an-- accident. Your aunt was shot with an arrow--penetrated the jugular vein-- "Mrs. Cresswell spoke hysterically and without her usual refinement: "Your h'aunt's been murdered, that's what's appened. Your h'aunt's been murdered." Inspector Welch drew his chair a little nearer to the table and let his gaze wander from one to the other of the four people in the room. It was evening of the same day. "e had called at Wests' house to take Louise Oxiey °nce more over her statement. "You are sure of the exact words? Shot--he shot me-- w" an arrow--get help?"

^-ouise nodded. . - off-S? - ,

^And the time?" , ,

looked at my watch a minute or two later--it was ^n 12:25-' ... ^ :...^, 84
AGATm chf

"Your watch keeps good tinK11'1181^

"I looked at the clock as wel"®7"

her accuracy, ell." Louise left no doubt of

The Inspector turned to j^yc |

"It appears, sir, that about ay"10"11 west-

Horace Bindler were witnesses t a week ago you and a Mr"

Briefly, Raymond recounted f- to Miss Greenshaw's will?"

visit he and Horace Binder 3 Ae events of the afternoon

Page 44

Folly, r had paid to Greenshaw's

"This testimony of yo^rs

Welch. "Miss Greenshaw distin? " ^V be ""P01'1'1"1"" said her will was being made ^ f^i^tly told you, did she, that

housekeeper, and that she was favor of Mrs- cresswell> the any wages in view of the e^pec^ not P^^ Mrs' cresswe11

of profiting by her death?" pectations Mrs. Cresswell had

"That is what she told nig_} ' J

"Would you say that Mrs Cn—ves—"

of these facts?" ' Cresswell was definitely aware

^

"I should say undoubtedly j^ ',

erence in my presence to bene- Miss Greenshaw made a rewitness a will and Mrs. Cressw's"6601"168 not being

she meant by it. Moreover ^sswell clearly understood wna

me that she had come t^' th Miss Greenshaw hersellto

Cresswell." this arrangement with M •

"So Mrs. Cresswell had i-easo ,, in.

terested pany. Motive clear enoi^011 to believe she was an ^

say she'd be our chief susp^t nenough in her case' a i, ?act that she was securely locked in^ now if it wasn>t for Q^ei here, and also that Miss Green3 in her room like Mrs' .nan

shot her—"reenshaw definitely said a

"She definitely was looking in

"Oh, yes. Sergeant Cayley [gt 1 m "her room?"

ioned lock with a big old-fashioned key? let her out- It's a big key for the lock and there's not a chance of the key being

turned from inside or any chance that you could have

you can take it definitely that "wacky-panky of that kind _^

inside that room and couldn't catch Mrs. Cresswell's

bows and arrows in the room?" She said out- And there ^

couldn't in any case have been 'room and ^less. Arsw^

angle forbids it. No, Mrs. Cresswell" shot from her

Cresswell's out."

^ &- GREENSHAW'S FOLLY / 85

He paused, then went on: "Would you say that Miss

Greenshaw, in your opinion, was a practical joker?" fow^;: H Miss Marple looked up sharply from her corner.

"So the will wasn't in Mrs. Cresswell's favor after all?"

she said.

Inspector Welch looked over at her in a rather surprised

fashion.

"That's a very clever guess of yours, madam," he said.

"No. Mrs. Cresswell isn't named as beneficiary." "Just like Mr. Naysmith," said Miss Marple, nodding her head. "Miss Greenshaw told Mrs. Cresswell she was going to leave her everything and so got out of paying her wages; and

then she left her money to somebody else. No doubt she was vastly pleased with herself. No wonder she chortled when she put the will away in Lady Audley's Secret. "It was lucky Mrs. Oxley was able to tell us about the will and where it was put,"

said the Inspector. "We might have had a long hunt for it otherwise." A Victorian sense of **Page 45**

humor," murmured Raymond West. "So she left her money to her nephew after all," said Louise.

The Inspector shook his head. "No," he said, "she didn't leave it to Nat Fletcher. The story goes around here--of course I'm new to the place and I only get the gossip that's second-hand--but it seems that in the old days both Miss Greenshaw and her sister were set on the handsome young riding master, and the sister got him. No, she didn't leave the money to her nephew--" Inspector Welch paused, rubbing his chin. "She left it to Alfred," he said. Alfred--the gardener?" Joan spoke in a surprised voice. "Yes, Mrs. West. Alfred Pollock." "Why?" cried Louise. "Then the doctor coughed and murmured, 'I would imagine, I what?'" "No, I'm not wrong, that there may have been--I

we might call family reasons." "You could call them that in a way," agreed the Inspector. "Quite well-known in the village, it seems, that

86 AGATHA CHRISTIE "Thomas Pollock, Alfred's grandfather, was one of old Greenshaw's by-blows." "Of course," cried Louise, "the resemblance!" [She remembered how after passing Alfred she had entered the house and looked up at old Greenshaw's portrait.] "I daresay," said Miss Marple, "that she thought Alfred Pollock might have a pride in the house, might even wait to live in it, whereas her nephew would almost certainly have no use for it whatever and would sell it as soon as he could possibly do so. He's an actor, isn't he? What play is he acting in at present?" "Trust an old lady to wander from the point, thought Inspector Welch; but he replied civilly, "I believe madam they are doing a season of Sir James M. Barrie's plays." "Barrie,"

said Miss Marple thoughtfully. "What Every Woman Knows," said Inspector Welch and then blushed. "Name of a play," he said quickly. "I'm not much of a theater-goer myself," he added,

"but my wife went along and saw it last week. Quite well done, she said it was." "Barrie wrote some very charming plays," said Miss Marple, "though I must say

that when I went with an cfriend of mine. General Easterly, to see Barrie's LitMary—" she shook her head sadly "—neither of us kn

-where to look." The Inspector, unacquainted with the play Little Maseemed completely fogged. Miss Marple explained: "When I was a girl. Inspectnobody ever mentioned the word stomach." The Inspector looked even more at sea. Miss Marple vmurmuring titles under her breath. "The Admirable Chrichton. Very clever, Mary Rose charming play. I cried, I remember.

Quality Street I did care for so much. Then there was A Kiss for Cinderella. (.of course!"

Inspector Welch had no time to waste on theatrical ccussion. He returned to the matter at hand.

"The question is," he said, "did Alfred Pollock know iold lady had made a will in his favor? Did she tell binHe added, "You see—there's an Archery Club over at Be GREENSHAW'S FOLLY 87 "W Pollock's a member. He's a good shot in910~~^a.bow and arrow." d£ed wl n't your case quite clear?" asked Raymond""The" ^ould fit in with the doors being locked on the "vt men--he'd know justwhere they were in the'e Inspector looked at him.

He spoke with deepmelancholy. ^.} ?"He's got an alibi," said the Inspector."I always think alibis are definitely suspicious," Raymondremarked. "Maybe, sir," said Inspector Welch. "You're talking as awriter." "I don't write detective stories," said Raymond West, horrified at the mere idea. "Easy enough to say that alibis are suspicious," went onInspector Welch, "but unfortunately we've got to deal withfacts." He sighed. "We've got three good suspects," hewent on. "Three people who, as it happened, were veryclose upon the scene at the time. Yet the odd thing is thatit looks as though none of the three could have done it. The housekeeper I've already dealt with; the nephew, NatFletcher, at the moment Miss Greenshaw was shot, was acouple of miles away filling up his car at a garage and askinghis way; as for Alfred Pollock, six people will swearthat he entered the Dog and Duck at twenty past twelve andwas there for an hour having his usual bread and cheeseand beer." -^ ^it^ "Deliberately establishing an alibi," said Raymond Westhopefully."Maybe," said Inspector Welch, "but if so, he did establishit." ;; , :^There was a long silence. Then Raymond turned hisPead to where Miss Marple sat upright and thoughtful."It's up to you. Aunt Jane," he said. "The Inspector'spsffled, the Sergeant's baffled, I'm baffled, Joan's baffled, ^ouise is baffled. But to you. Aunt Jane, it is crystal clear. Am I right?" "I wouldn't say that," said Miss

Marple, "not crystal ear. And murder, dear Raymond, isn't a game. I don't suppose
00 AGATHA CHRISTIE ||j pose poor Miss Greenshaw wanted to die, **Page**
46

and it was a par.

particularly brutal murder. Very well-planned and quite cold||

blooded. It's not a thing to make jokes about."

"I'm sorry," said Raymond. "I'm not really as callous as I sound. One treats a thing lightly to take away from the- well, the horror of it." I

"That is, I believe, the modern tendency," said Miss Marple. "All these wars, and having to joke about funerals.

1 Yes, perhaps I was thoughtless when I implied that you I'll were callous." 1

"It isn't," said Joan, "as though we'd known her at all I wellL" I'll "That is very true," said Miss Marple. "You, dear Joan, did not know her at all. I did not know her at all. Ray,,

mond gathered an impression of her from one afternoon's

" conversation. Louise knew her for only two days."

"Come now. Aunt Jane," said Raymond, "tell us your views. You don't mind. Inspector?"

"Not at all," said the Inspector politely. ^ "Well, my dear, it would seem that we have three people

who had--or might have thought they had--a motive to

kill the old lady. And three quite simple reasons why none

of the three could have done so. The housekeeper could

not have killed Miss Greenshaw because she was locked in

her room and because her mistress definitely stated that a man shot her. The gardener was inside the Dog and Duck

at the time, the nephew at the garage." ^ |

"Very clearly put, madam," said the Inspector.

"And since it seems most unlikely that any outsider should have done it, where, then, are we?"

"That's what the Inspector wants to know," said Raymond West. "*||

A "

"One so often looks at a thing the wrong way round,

said Miss Marple apologetically. "If we can't alter the movements or the positions of those three people, then couldn't we perhaps alter the time of the murder?"

"You mean that both my watch and the clock were wrong?" asked Louise.

"No, dear," said Miss Marple, "I didn't mean that at all- ^

GREENSHAW'S FOLLY

] mean that the murder didn't occur when you thought it occurred."

"But I saw it," cried Louise.

"Well, what I have been wondering, my dear," was whether you weren't meant to see it. I've been asking myself,

you know, whether that wasn't the real reason you were engaged for this job."

"What do you mean. Aunt Jane?"

"Well, dear, it seems odd. Miss Greenshaw did not like spending money--yet she engaged you and agreed to willingly to the terms you asked. It seems to me that perhaps you were meant to be there in that library on the second floor, looking out of the window so that you could be the key witness--someone from outside of irreproachable good character--to fix a definite time and place for the murder."

"But you can't mean," said Louise, incredulously. "Miss Greenshaw intended to be murdered."

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"What I mean, dear," said Miss Marple, "is that you didn't really know Miss Greenshaw. There's no real reason

is there, why the Miss Greenshaw you saw when you went up to the house should be the same Miss Greenshaw that Ray

mond saw a few days earlier? Oh, yes, I know," she went on, to prevent Louise's reply, "she was wearing that pink

old-fashioned print dress and the strange hat and had unkempt hair. She corresponded exactly to the description Raymond gave us last weekend. But there were two women, you know, were much the same age, height and size. The housekeeper, I mean, and Miss Greenshaw." "But the housekeeper is fat!" Louise exclaimed. "She's got an enormous bosom." Miss Marple coughed. "But my dear, surely, nowadays I have seen--even myself in shops most indelicately displayed. It is very easy for anyone to have a--a bosom--of any size and dimension." "What are you trying to say?" demanded Raymond. "I was just thinking that during the two days Lou

was working there, one woman could have played both parts. You said yourself, Louise, that you hardly saw the housekeeper, except for the one minute in the morning when she brought you the tray with coffee. One sets those class artists on the stage coming in as different characters only a moment or two to spare, and I am sure she could have been effected quite easily. That queer dress could be just as easily slipped on and off." "Aunt Jane! Do you mean that Miss Greenshaw was dead before I started work there?" "Not dead. Kept under drugs, I should say. A very easy job for an unscrupulous woman like the housekeeper to do. Then she made the arrangements with you and got you to telephone to the nephew to ask him to lunch at a definite time. The only person who would have known that this Miss Greenshaw was not Miss Greenshaw would have been Alfred. And if you remember, the first two days you were working there it was wet, and Miss Greenshaw stayed in the house. Alfred never came into the house because of his feud with the housekeeper. And on the last morning Alfred was in the drive, while Miss Greenshaw was working on the rockery--I'd like to have a look at that rockery." "Do you mean it was Mrs. Cresswell who killed

Miss Greenshaw?" "I think that after bringing you your coffee, the housekeeper locked the door on you as she went out, then carried the unconscious Miss Greenshaw down to the drawing-room, then assumed her

'Miss Greenshaw' disguise and she went out to work on the rockery where you could see her! from the upstairs window. In due course she screamed and came staggering to the house clutching an arrow as though it had penetrated her throat. She called for help and was careful to say 'he shot me' so as to remove suspicion from the housekeeper--from herself. She also called up to the housekeeper's window as though she saw her there. Then, once inside the drawing-room, she threw over a table with porcelain on it, ran quickly upstairs, put on her marquis wig, and was able a few moments later to lean her head out of the window and tell you that she, too, was locked in." I?":.

"But she was locked in," said Louise. "I know. That is where the policeman comes in." , "What policeman?" ...,- w." _ |fc;| GREENSHAW'S FOLLY 91 ^""^v--what policeman? I wonder. Inspector, if you™ ^x a d telling me how and when you arrived on the ^linspector looked a little puzzled.B" At 12-29 we received a telephone call from Mrs. Presswell, housekeeper to Miss Greenshaw, stating that her mistress had been shot. Sergeant Cayley and myself went there at once in a car and arrived at the house at 1?-35. We found Miss Greenshaw dead and the two ladies locked in their rooms." "So, you see, my dear," said Miss Marple to Louise. "The police constable you saw wasn't a real police constable at all. You never thought of him again--one doesn't--one just accepts one more uniform as part of the Law.""But who--why?""As to who--well, if they are playing A Kiss for Cinderella, a policeman is the principal character. Nat Fletcher would only have to help himself to the costume he wears on the stage. He'd ask his way at a garage, being careful to call attention to the time--12:25; then he would drive on quickly, leave his car round a corner, slip on his police uniform, and do his 'act.' "

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"But why--why?" "Someone had to lock the housekeeper's door on the outside, and someone had to drive the arrow through Miss Greenshaw's throat. You can stab anyone with an arrow just as well as by shooting it--but it needs force." "You mean they were both in it?" "Oh, yes, I think so."

Mother and son as likely as not. "But Miss Greenshaw's sister died long ago." "Yes, but I've no doubt Mr. Fletcher married again--he sounds like the sort of man who would. I think it possible that the child died too, and that this so-called nephew was the second wife's child, and not really a relation at all. The woman got the post as housekeeper and spied out the land. Then he wrote to Miss Greenshaw as her nephew and proposed to call on her--he may have even made some joking reference to coming in his policeman's uniform--remember, she said she was expecting a policeman. But I think Miss Greenshaw suspected the truth and refused to see him. 92 AGATHA CHRISTIE 1
He would have been her heir if she had died without a will--but of course once she had made a will in the housekeeper's favor, as they thought, then it was clear sailing. "But why use an arrow?" objected Joan. "So very far. Etched." "Not far-fetched at all, dear. Alfred belonged to an archery Club--Alfred was meant to take the blame. That is that he was in the pub as early as 12:20 was most unusual. "tunate from their point of view. He always left a little before his proper time and that would have been just what she needed." She shook her head. "It really seems all wrong--really, I mean, that Alfred's laziness should have saved his life." The Inspector cleared his throat. "Well, madam, these suggestions of yours are very interesting. I shall, of course, have to investigate--" Miss Marple and Raymond West stood by the rocker and looked down at a gardening basket full of dying

relation. ,,,,,,,,,, ,,,

Miss Marple murmured: "SS 1

Alyssum, saxifrage, cystis, thimble campanula, etc., that's all the proof /

need. Whoever was weeding her

"Yesterday morning was no gardener--she pulled up plants as well as weeds. So now I know I'm right. Thank you, dear,

"Qiond, for bringing me here. I wanted to see the place for myself."

1 She and Raymond both looked up at the outrageous price

0 Greenshaw's Folly.

i A cough made them turn. A handsome young man with

iffle "so outrageous at the monstrous house. I've always big place," he said. "Too big for nowadays--

just so they say. I dunno about that. If I won a football pool

just built made a lot of money, that's the kind of house I'd like to build."

He smiled bashfully at them, then ruffled his hair.

I have 'Reckon I can say so now--that there house was built

I have only my grandfather," said Alfred Pollock. "And a fine house it is, for as they call it Greenshaw's Folly!"

THE CASE OF THE PERFECT MAID

"oh, if you please, Madam, could I speak to you a moment?"

It might be thought that this request was in the nature of an absurdity, since Edna, Miss Marple's little maid, was

actually speaking to her mistress at the moment.

Recognizing the idiom, however. Miss Marple said

promptly: "Certainly, Edna, come in and shut the door.

What is it?"

Obediently shutting the door, Edna advanced into the

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room, pleated the corner of her apron between her fingers and swallowed once or twice.

| "Yes, Edna?" said Miss Marple encouragingly.

| "Oh please, M'am, it's my cousin Gladdie. You see, she's lost her place."

"Dear me, I am sorry to hear that. She was at Old Hall, wasn't she, with the Miss--Misses--Skinners?"

| "Yes, M'am, that's right, M'am. And Gladdie's very upset about it--very upset indeed."

"Gladys has changed places rather often before, though, hasn't she?"

|_ "Oh yes, M'am. She's always one for a change. Gladdie 's. She never seems to get really settled, if you know what I

"^an. But she's always been the one to give the notice, you see!"

And this time it's the other way round?" asked Miss Marple drily.

"iar

o_

Yes, M'am, and it's upset Gladdie something awful."

Miss Marple looked slightly surprised. Her recollection "Gladys, who had occasionally come to drink tea in the

94 AGATHA CHRISTIE

kitchen on her 'days out,' was a stout, giggling girl of unshakably equal temperament.

Edna went on: "You see, M'am, it's the way it happened--the way Miss Skinner looked." "How,"

inquired Miss Marple patiently, "did Miss Sincin^{er} look?" This time Edna got well away with her news bulletin. "Oh M'am, it was ever such a shock to Gladdie. You see, one of Miss Emily's brooches was missing and such a hue and cry for it as never was, and of course, nobody likes a thing like that to happen; it's upsetting, M'am, if you know what I mean. And Gladdie's helped search everywhere and there was Miss Lavinia saying she was going; to the police about it, and then it turned up again, pushed 'right to the back of a drawer in the dressing table, and very thankful Gladdie was." And the very next day as ever was a plate got broken, and Miss Lavinia she bounced out right away and told Gladdie to take a month's notice. And what Gladdie feels is it couldn't have been the plate and that Miss Lavinia was just making an excuse of that, and that it must be because of the brooch and they think as she took it and put it back when the police was mentioned, and Gladdie wouldn't do such a thing, not never she wouldn't, and what she feels is as it will get around and tell against her and it's a very, serious thing for a girl as you know, M'am." Miss Marple nodded. Though having no particular liking for the bouncing, self-opinioned Gladys, she was quite sure of the girl's intrinsic honesty and could well imagine that the affair must have upset her. Edna said wistfully: "I suppose, M'am, there isn't anything you could do about it?"

Gladdie's in ever such a taking. "Tell her not to be silly," said Miss Marple crisply. "She didn't take the brooch--which I'm sure she didn't--" then she has no cause to be upset. "It'll get about," said Edna dismally. Miss Marple said. "I--er--am going up that way this W[^] ternoon. I'll have word with the Misses Skinners." "Oh, thank you. Madam," said Edna. 'f I THE CASE OF THE PERFECT MAID 95 Old Hall was a big Victorian house surrounded by woods and parkland. Since it had been proved unlettable and unsalable as it was, an enterprising speculator had divided it into four flats with a central hot water system, and the use of 'the grounds' to be held in common by the tenants. The experiment had been satisfactory. A rich and eccentric old lady and her maid occupied one flat. The old lady had a passion for birds and **Page 50**

entertained a feathered gathering to meals every day. A retired Indian judge and his wife rented a second. A very young couple, recently married, occupied the third, and the fourth had been taken only two months ago by two maiden ladies of the name of Skinner. The four sets of tenants were only on the most distant terms with each other, since none of them had anything in common.

The landlord had been heard to say that this was an excellent thing. What he dreaded were friendships followed by estrangements and subsequent complaints to him. Miss Marple was acquainted with all the tenants, though she knew none of them well. The elder Miss Skinner, Miss Lavinia, was what might be termed the working member of

*the firm. Miss Emily, the younger, spent most of her time

in bed suffering from various complaints which, in the opinion of St. Mary Mead, were largely imaginary. Only Miss

Lavinia believed devoutly in her sister's martyrdom and

patience under affliction, and willingly ran errands and trotted up and down to the village for things, that "my sister ,,

had suddenly fancied." ^.-. '181

| It was the view of St. Mary Mead that if Miss Emily'

suffered half as much as she said she did, she would have

sent for Doctor Haydock long ago. But Miss Emily, when it was hinted to her, shut her eyes in a superior way and murmured that her case was not a simple one-

-the best Socialists in London had been baffled by it--and that a wonderful new man had put her on a most revolutionary

course of treatment and that she really hoped her health

Would improve under it. No humdrum G.P. could possibly

I understand her case.

"And it's my opinion," said the outspoken Miss Hart- nel!, "that she's very wise not to send for him. Dear Doctor

AGATHA CHRIST!;

Haydock, in that breezy manner qfhis^

tbar^ "----^

* aiiing such arbitrary treatment, however. Miss EniBvcontinued to lie on sofas, to surroind herself with strangelittle pill boxes, and to reject nearty everything that hadbeen cooked for her and ask for something else-- usuallysomething difficult and inconvenient :o get.;en panitioned into a dining-- n aid h""^"1""""1' " --. -, .---, jy^vm, y^/uy JI a gruff voice and an abrupt manner.i to see you," she said. "Enily'slr»i» _»^~l- -----J~~~~~ ar, she's wonderfully patient." -!d_ nnlitAh?-- Cow"^*^ -----i-----'---- -- . v^^j »» ^a ^ n*^ iialuconversation in St. Mary Mead so it was notMiss Lavinia nodded. ' "Wednesday week. Broke things, you know. Can't havethat."..----- ..^oya.-n-was so dimcult to get girls to come toJtry. Did Miss Skinner really think it was wise topart with Gladys?"Know it's difficult to get servants," admitted Miss La-vmia.. "The Deaererm--k^,--2_^----- ider I Then the Larkins have just lost their maid.

THE CASE OF THE PERFECT MAID 97 Larkin always fussing, I don't wonder at that, eiMrsCarmichael's Janet is a fixture, of course--ther. y1 opinion she's the most disagreeable woman,y^^1^~ .."Then don't you think you might reconsider your deciahoutGladys. She really is a nice girl. I know all hersion <*"-- - . .)

family; very honest and superior. ^ ^ ^ Miss Lavinia shook her head. ^ ^^ . ^"I've got my reasons," she said importantly.Miss Marple murmured: "You missed a brooch, I un"derstand--""Now who has been talking? I suppose the girl has.Quite frankly, I'm almost certain she took it. And then got frightened and put it back--but of course one can't sayanything unless one is sure." She changed the subject. "Docome and see Miss Emily, Miss Marple. I'm **Page 51**

sure it woulddo her good." y^Miss Marple followed meekly to where Miss Laviniaknocked on a door; was bidden enter and ushered herguest into the best room in the flat, most of the light ofwhich was excluded by half-drawn blinds. Miss Emily waslying in bed, apparently enjoying the half gloom and herown indefinite sufferings.The dim light showed her to be a thin, indecisive lookingcreature, with a good deal of grayish yellow hair untidilywound around her head and erupting into curls, the wholething looking like a bird's nest of which no self-respectingbird could be proud. There was a smell in the room of eaude-cologne,stale biscuits and camphor.With half-closed eyes and in a thin, weak voice, Emily Skinner explained thatthis was

"one of her bad days."| "The worst of ill-health is," said Miss Emily in a melancholytone, "that one knows what burden one is to everyonearound one. 'Lavinia is very good to me. Lavvie dear, I do so hategiving trouble but if my

hot water bottle could only be "Used in the way I like it--too full it weighs on me so--on the other hand, if it is not sufficiently filled, it gets cold immediately!" ^mm, /< "I'm sorry, dear. Give it to me. I will empty a little out."

98 AGATHA CHRISTIE "Perhaps, if you're doing that, it might be refilled. The ' are no rusks in the house, I suppose--no, no, it doesn't matter. I can do without. Some weak tea and a slice of lemon--no lemons? No, really, I couldn't drink tea without lemon. I think the milk was slightly turned this morning. It has put me right against milk in my tea. It doesn't matter. I can do without my tea. Only I do feel so weak. Oysters, they say, are nourishing. I wonder if I could fancy a few.

No, no, too much bother to get hold of them so late in the day. I can fast until tomorrow."

^Lavinia left the room murmuring something incoherent about bicycling down to the village. Miss Emily smiled feebly at her guest and remarked that she did hate giving anyone any trouble. Miss Marple told Edna that evening that she was afraid her embassy had met with no success. She was rather troubled to find that rumors as to Gladys' dishonesty were already going around the village. In the Post Office, Miss Wetherby tackled her: "My dear Jane, they gave her a written reference saying she was willing and sober and respectable, but saying nothing about honesty. That seems to me most significant! I hear there was some trouble about, a brooch. I think there must be something in it, you know, because one doesn't let a servant go nowadays unless it's something rather grave. They'll find it most difficult to get anyone else. Girls simply will not go to Old Hall. They're nervous coming home on their days out. You'll see, the Skinners won't find anyone else, and then, perhaps that dreadful hypochondriac sister will have to get up and do something!" Great was the chagrin of the village when it was made known that the Misses Skinners had engaged, from an agency, a new maid who, by all accounts, was a perfect paragon. "A three years' reference recommending her most warmly, she prefers the country, and actually asks less wages than Gladys. I really feel we have been most fortunate."

"Well, really," said Miss Marple, to whom these details THE CASE OF THE PERFECT MAID 99 -narrated by Miss Lavinia in the fishmonger's shop.

s/efC imp*" i t t. ^ „It does seem too good to be true. It then became the opinion of St. Mary Mead that the one would cry off at the last minute and fail

to arrive. None of these prognostications came true however, and the village was able to observe the domestic treasure, by name, Mary Higgins, driving through the village in Reed's taxi to Old Hall. It had to be admitted that her appearance was good. A most respectable looking woman, very neatly dressed. -; ' ^H| When Miss Marple next visited Old Hall, on the occasion of recruiting stall-holders for the Vicarage Fete, Mary Higgins opened the door. She was certainly a most superior looking maid, at a guess forty years of age, with neat black hair, rosy cheeks, a plump figure discreetly arrayed in black with a white apron and cap--"quite the good, old-fashioned type of servant," as Miss Marple explained afterwards, and with the proper, inaudible, respectful voice, so different from the loud but adenoidal accents of Gladys. Miss Lavinia was looking far less harassed than usual and, although she regretted that she could not take a stallowing to her preoccupation with her sister, she nevertheless tendered a handsome monetary contribution, and promised to produce a consignment of penwipers and babies' socks. Miss Marple commented on her air of well-being. , ;;"I really feel I owe a great deal to Mary. I am so thankful **Page 52**

had the resolution to get rid of that other girl. Mary is really invaluable. Cooks nicely and waits beautifully and keeps our little flat scrupulously clean--mattresses turned over every day. And she is really wonderful with Emily!" Miss Marple hastily inquired after Emily. 'Oh, poor dear, she has been very much under the weather lately. She can't help it, of course, but it really makes things a little difficult, sometimes. Wanting certain things cooked and then, when they come, saying she can't eat now--and then wanting them again half an hour later and everything spoilt and having to be done again. It makes, of course, a lot of work--but fortunately Mary

100 AGATHA CHRISTIE

does not seem to mind at all. She's used to waiting o "

valids, she says, and understands them. It is such""

comfort." ^ a

"Dear me," said Miss Marple. "You are fortunate." |

"Yes, indeed. I really feel Mary has been sent to us in an answer to prayer."

"She sounds to me," said Miss Marple, "almost too good to be true. I should--

well, I should be a little careful if I were you."

Lavinia Skinner failed to perceive the point of this remark.

She said: "Oh! I assure you I do all I can to make her comfortable. I don't know what I should do if she . left."

"I don't expect she'll leave until she's ready to leave," said Miss Marple and stared very hard at her hostess.

Miss Lavinia said: "If one has no domestic worries, it takes such a load off one's mind, doesn't it? How is your little Edna shaping?"

"She's doing quite nicely. Not much ahead, of course.

Not like your Mary. Still I do know all about Edna, because she's a village girl."

As she went out into the hall she heard the invalid's

voice fretfully raised: "This compress has been allowed to get quite dry-- Doctor Allerton particularly said moisture

continually renewed. There, there, leave it. I want a cup of tea and a boiled egg--boiled only three minutes and a half,

remember, and send Miss Lavinia to me."

The efficient Mary emerged from the bedroom and, saying

to Lavinia, "Miss Emily is asking for you. Madam,"

proceeded to open the door for Miss Marple, helping her

into her coat and handing her her umbrella in the most irreproachable fashion.

Miss Marple took the umbrella, dropped it, tried to pick it up and dropped her bag which flew open. Mary politely retrieved various odds and ends--a handkerchief, an engagement book, an old-fashioned leather purse, two shillings, three pennies and a striped piece of peppermint rock.

Miss Marple received the last with some signs of confusion.

___ THE CASE OF THE PERFECT MAID 101 SB? dear that must have been Mrs. Clement's little boy.

Page 53

was sucking it, I remember, and he took my bag to
iv with. He must have put it inside. It's terribly sticky,
""""Shall I take it. Madam?"

"Oh, would you? Thank you so much."

Mary stooped to retrieve the last item, a small mirror
liioon recovering which Miss Marple exclaimed fervently:
"How lucky now that that isn't broken."

She thereupon departed, Mary standing politely by the
door holding a piece of striped rock with a completely
expressionless face. '

For ten days longer St. Mary Mead had to endure
hearing of the excellencies of Miss Lavinia's and Miss

Emily's treasure. On the eleventh day, the village awoke to its big thrill. Mary, the paragon, was missing! Her bed had not been slept in and the front door was found ajar. She had slipped out quietly during the night. And not Mary alone was missing! Two brooches and five rings of Miss Lavinia's; three rings, a pendant, a bracelet and four brooches of Miss Emily's were missing also! It was the beginning of a chapter of catastrophe. Young Mrs. Devereux had lost her diamonds which she kept in an unlocked drawer and also some valuable furs given to her as a wedding present. The judge and his wife also had had jewelry taken and a certain amount of money. Mrs. Carmichael was the greatest sufferer. Not only had she some very valuable jewels but she also kept a large sum of money in the flat which had gone. It had been Janet's evening out and her mistress was in the habit of walking round the gardens at dusk calling to the birds and scattering crumbs. It seemed clear that Mary, the perfect maid, had had keys to fit all the flats! There was, it must be confessed, a certain amount of ill-natured pleasure in St. Mary Mead.

Miss Lavinia had boasted so much of her marvelous Mary. "And all the time, my dear, just a common thief!" Interesting revelation followed. Not only had Mary dis-102 . f . AGATHA CHRISTIE appeared into the blue, but the agency who had provided her and vouched for her credentials was alarmed to find that the Mary Higgins who had applied to them and whose references they had taken up had, to all intents and purposes, never existed. It was the name of a bonafide servant who had lived with the bonafide sister of a clean, but the real Mary Higgins was existing peacefully in a place in Cornwall. ' ^ "Clever, the whole thing," Inspector Slack was forced to admit. "And, if you ask one, that woman works in with a gang. There was a case of much the same kind in Northumberland a year ago. Stuff was never traced and they 'never caught her. However, we'll do better than that in Much Benham!" a : Inspector Slack was always a confident man. . | Nevertheless, weeks passed and Mary Higgins remained triumphantly at large. In vain Inspector Slack redoubled that energy that so belied his name. Miss Lavinia remained tearful. Miss Emily was so upset, and felt so alarmed by her condition that she actually sent for Doctor Haydock. "The whole of the village was terribly anxious to know what he thought of Miss Emily's claims to ill health, but ^lallv could _ not ask ^ him. Satisfactory data came to Haydock had prescribed a mixture 01 assalucua u valerian which, according to Mr. Meek, was the stock remedy for malingerers in the Army! Soon afterwards it was learned that Miss Emily, not regaining the medical attention she had had, was declaring it & that in the state of her health she felt it her duty to be with the specialist in London who understood her case. It was said, only fair to Lavinia. ,, ,.

The flat was put up for subletting. -; ; s; 'It was a few days after that that Miss Marple, ratpink and flustered, called at the police station in mu(} Benham and asked for Inspector Slack. . ,J

THE CASE OF THE PERFECT MAID 103 Inspector Slack did not like Miss Marple. But he was aware that the Chief Constable, Colonel Melchett, did not share that opinion. Rather grudgingly, therefore, he received her. "Good afternoon. Miss Marple, what can I do for you?" "Oh dear," said Miss Marple, "I'm afraid you're in a hurry." "Lot of work on," said **Page 54**

Inspector Slack, "but I can spare a few moments." "Oh dear," said Miss Marple. "I hope I shall be able to put what I say properly. So difficult, you know, to explain oneself, don't you think? No, perhaps you don't. But you see, not having been educated in the modern style--just a governess, you know, who taught one the dates on the Kings of England and General Knowledge--

Doctor Brewer--three kinds of diseases of wheat--bright, mildew--now what was the third--was it smut?"

"Do you want to talk about smut?" asked Inspector Slack and then blushed. "Oh, no, no," Miss Marple hastily disclaimed any wish to talk about smut. "Just an illustration, you know. And how needles are made and all that. Discursive, you know, but not teaching one to keep to the point.

Which is what I want to do. It's about Miss Skinner's maid, Gladys, you know." "Mary Higgins,"

said Inspector Slack. "Oh yes, the second maid. But it's Gladys Holmes I mean--rather an impertinent girl and far too pleased with herself but really strictly honest, and it's so important that it should be recognized." "No charge against her so far as I know," said the "specter. No, I know there isn't a charge--but that makes it worse. Because, you see, people go on thinking things.

O hear--I just want to explain badly. What I really mean is that the important thing is to find Mary Higgins." "Certainly," said Inspector Slack. "Have you any ideas--the subject?" "Well, as a matter of fact, I have," said Miss Marple.

104 AGATHA CHRISTIE "May I ask you a question? Are fingerprints of no use to you?" "No, I'm afraid," said Inspector Slack, "that's where she was a bit too careful for us. Did most of her work in rubber gloves or housemaid's gloves, it seems. And she'd been careful--wiped off everything in her bedroom and on the sink. Couldn't find a single fingerprint in the place!" "If you could have her fingerprints, would it help?" "It ought, Madam. They may be known at the Yard. This isn't her first job, I'd say!"

Miss Marple nodded brightly. She opened her bag and extracted a small cardboard box. Inside it, wedged in cotton wool, was a small mirror. "From my handbag," said Miss Marple. "The maid's prints are on it. I think they should be satisfactory--she touched an extremely sticky substance a moment previously." Inspector Slack stared. "Did you get her fingerprints on purpose?" "Of course." "You suspected her then?" "Well, you know it did strike me that she was a little too good to be true. I practically told Miss Lavinia so. But she simply wouldn't take the hint! I'm afraid, you know, Inspector, that I don't believe in paragons. Most of us have our faults--and domestic service shows them up very quickly!" "Well," said Inspector Slack, recovering his balance, "I'm obliged to you, I'm sure. We'll send these up to the Yard and see what they have to say." He stopped. Miss Marple had put her head a little

on one side and was regarding him with a good deal of meaning. "You Wouldn't consider, I suppose. Inspector, looking a little near[^] home?" "What do you mean. Miss Marple?" "It's very difficult to explain, but when you come across a peculiar thing you notice it. Although, often, peculiar things may be the merest trifles. I've felt that all along, you know; I mean about Gladys and the brooch. She's an honest girl; she didn't take that brooch. Then why did Miss

THE CASE OF THE PERFECT MAID 105 Skinner think she did? Miss Skinner's not a fool; far from it. Why was she so anxious to let a girl go who was a good servant when servants are hard to get? It was peculiar, you know. So I wondered. I wondered a good deal. And I noticed another peculiar thing! Miss Emily's a hypochondriac but she's the first hypochondriac who hasn't sent for some doctor or other at once. Hypochondriacs love doctors. Miss Emily didn't! "What are you suggesting. Miss Marple?" "Well, I'm suggesting, you know, that Miss Lavinia and Miss Emily are peculiar people. Miss Emily spends nearly all her time in a dark room.

And if that hair of hers isn't a wig I--I'll eat my own back switch! And what I say is this--it's perfectly possible for a thin, pale, gray-haired, whining woman to be the same as a black-haired, rosy-cheeked, plump woman. And nobody that I can find ever saw Miss Emily and Mary Higgins at one and the same time. "Plenty of time to get impressions of all the keys, plenty of time to find out all about the other tenants, and then--get rid of the local girl. Miss Emily takes a brisk walk across country one night and arrives at the station as Mary Higgins next day. And then, at the right moment, Mary Higgins disappears, and off goes the hue and cry after her. I'll tell you **Page 55**

where you'll find her, Inspector. On Miss Emily Skinner's sofa! Get her fingerprints if you don't believe me, but you'll find I'm right! A couple of clever thieves, that's what the Skinners are--and no doubt in league with a

clever post and rails or fence or whatever you call it. But

they won't get away with it this time! I'm not going to have one of our village girl's character for honesty taken away

"he that! Gladys Holmes is as honest as the day and everybody's going to know it! Good afternoon!"

Miss Marple had stalked out before Inspector Slack had

recovered.

"Whew!" he muttered. "I wonder if she's right?"

He soon found out that Miss Marple was right again.

Colonel Melchett congratulated Slack on his efficiency "'d Miss Marple had Gladys come to tea with Edna and

P°ke to her seriously on settling down in a good situation

"°en she got one.

AT THE BELLS AND MOTLEY

mr. satterthwaite was annoyed. Altogether it hail been an unfortunate day. They had started late; they had

taken the wrong turning and lost themselves amid the wilds

of Salisbury Plain. Now it was close on eight o'clock; they

were still a matter of forty miles from Marswick Manor

whither they were bound, and a blowout had supervened to

1| render matters still more trying.

j Mr. Satterthwaite, looking like some small bird whose

I plumage had been ruffled, walked up and down in front of

the village garage while his chauffeur conversed in hoarse

undertones with the local expert.

"Half an hour at least," said that worthy, pronouncing judgment.

"And lucky at that," supplemented Masters, the

chauffeur. "More like three quarters if you ask me."

j | "What is that--place, anyway?" demanded Mr. Satterthwaite fretfully. Being

a little gentleman considerate of the |

|l| feelings of others, he substituted the word "place" for

| ("Godforsaken hole" which had first risen to his lips.

"Kirtlington Mallet." ;

j Mr. Satterthwaite was not much wiser, and yet a faint

j familiarity seemed to linger round the name. He looked

j about him disparagingly. Kirtlington Mallet seemed to

| consist of one straggling street, the garage and the po" |i| office on one side
of it balanced by three indetermin⁶ il I shops on the other side. Farther down
the road, however' | Mr. Satterthwaite perceived something that creaked a11"

1' j swung in the wind, and his spirits rose ever so slightly. I ; "There's an inn
here, I see," he remarked. :

IE ' te AT THE BELLS AND MOTLEY 107

i ~ iSa^^

"Bellsahd Motley," said the garage man. "That's it--

vends1"

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"If I might make a suggestion, sir," said Masters. "Why not try it? They would be able to give you some sort of meal no doubt--not of course, what you are accustomed to,—" He paused apologetically, for Mr. Satterthwaite was accustomed to the best cooking of continental chefs, and had in his own service a cordon bleu to whom he paid a fabulous salary. "We shan't be able to take the road again for another three quarters of an hour, sir. I'm sure of that. And it's already past eight o'clock. You could ring up Sir George Foster, sir, from the inn, and acquaint him with the cause of our delay." "You seem to think you can arrange everything, Masters," said Mr. Satterthwaite snappily. Masters, who did think so, maintained a respectful silence, and Mr.

Satterthwaite, in spite of his earnest wish to discountenance any suggestion that might possibly be made to him--he was in that mood--nevertheless looked down the road toward the creaking inn sign with faint inward approval. He was a man of birdlike appetite, an epicure; but even such men can be hungry. "The Bells and Motley," he said thoughtfully. "That's an odd name for an inn. I don't know that I ever heard it before." "There's odd folks come to it by all account," said the local man. --He was bending over the wheel, and his voice came muffled and indistinct. "Odd folks?" queried Mr. Satterthwaite. "Now what do you mean by that?" The other hardly seemed to know what he meant. "Folks that come and go. That kind," he said vaguely. Mr. Satterthwaite reflected that people who come to an inn are almost of necessity those who "come and go." The

definition seemed to him to lack precision. But nevertheless his curiosity was stimulated. Somehow or other he had got

AGATHA CHRISTIE TOO quarters of an hour. The Bells and Motley to put in three

anywhere else. As he went, with his small, mincing steps he walked away. With his usual grace a rumble of thunder down the road. Masters: "There's a storm coming (y rasters. "And forty miles to go." "Crikey, say other.

"There's no need to be hurrying" Ah!" said That little boss of yours doesn't look as over this job.

; < ^ ^ g ^ g ^ ^ thunder and lightning. "though he'd re ^ ^ y ^ ^ ^ ^ place,"
muttered the "Hope they ^ pushing along there for a bite myself chauffeur. "I
presently." ,5 all right," said the garage man. "Keeps a "Billy Jones gy ^ good
table." jg ^ 3 yg ^ ty man of fifty, and land-Mr. Williard ^ ^

Motley, was at this minute beaming lord of the bq ^ ^ ^ t Mr.
Satterthwaite. ingratiatingly ^ ^ ^ g

^ ^ sir--and fried potatoes, and Can do yiggg ^ g ^ y gentleman could wish for.
This as good a cl

^ gg ^ . ^ ^ ^ ^ g , ^ ^ ^ ^ g ^ y ^ ^ present, way, sir, in tl g ^ ^ g gentlemen just gone. A
little later the last of "gam for ^ e hunting. Only one gentleman we'll be full
name of Quin--" m here at preser ^ ^

^ ^ ^ | Mr- . ^ ^ "aid excitedly. "Did you say Quin?" ^ Quin? h ^ g ^ ^ F ^ g ^ j Of
yours, perhaps?"

^ That's the q ^ , y ^ ^ ^ ^ certainly." Twittering with

"Yes, ind(^ Satterthwaite hardly realized that the

excitement ^ ^ ^ . g ^ ^ ^ ^ ^ ^ ^ name. He

world might ^ ^ ^ ^ ^ ^ ^ y ^ ^ g information fitted

had no doubt ^ g ^ ^ ^ ^ g ^ gg ^ ^ ^ ^ . , p ^ ^ ^ ^

in with wha ^ yg ^ y ^ description of Mr. Quin. And

come and gg ^ n too seemed a peculiarly fitting and ap- the name of propriate
ot ^ ^ ^ , , ^ ^ ^ Satterthwaite. "What a

"Dear T' That we should meet like this! Mr. Harley very odd t n i i Quin, is it n ^
^ ^ , ^ ^ ^ ^ g ^ ^ gg g ^ ^ ^ ^ ^ , ^ g ^ g ; s

"That s n, the

gentlem |

H "" "- ^ i 09 "" AT THE BELLS AND MOTLEY)

Tall, dark, smiling, the familiar figure of Mr. Quin r(^ _

from the table at which he was sitting, and his numbered voice spoke, g^ &-

..;& .d

"Ah! Mr. Satterthwaite, we meet again. An unexpected meeting!" , **Page 57**

Mr. Satterthwaite was shaking him warmly by the hand. "Delighted. Delighted, I'm sure. A lucky breakdown 1

me. My car, you know. And you are staying here? F

loas?" , vie m :^^,

"One night only." . -^ -V^.^ ' |^,"Then I am indeed fortunate." .^ ^ ., Mr. Satterthwaite sat down opposite his friend with a little sigh of satisfaction, and regarded the dark, smiling in opposite him with a pleasurable expectancy. ^,, , ,,,

The other man shook his head gently, y^ W^ c

"I assure you," he said, "that I have not a bowl ^ goldfish or a rabbit to produce from my sleeve."

"Too bad," cried Mr. Satterthwaite, a little taken aback

"Yes, I must confess--I do rather adopt that attitude toward you. A man of magic. Ha, ha. That -is how I regard

I you. A man of magic."

"And yet," said Mr. Quin, "it is you who do the conjuring tricks, not I."

"Ah!" said Mr. Satterthwaite eagerly. "But I cannot do them without you. I lack--shall we say--inspiration?"

Mr. Quin smilingly shook his head. "That is too big /

word. I speak the cue, that is all."

The landlord came in at that minute with bread and/ slab of yellow butter. As he set the things on the table there was a vivid flash of lightning, and a clap of thunder almost overhead.

"A wild night, gentlemen." i

"Oh such a night--" began Mr. Satterthwaite, arT

Popped.

"Funny now," said the landlord, "if those weren't ju^
tte words I was going to use myself. It was just such ^
^ght as this when Captain Harwell brought his brid^
^nie, the very day before he disappeared forever."

"Ah!" cried Mr. Satterthwaite, suddenly. "Of course!"

He had got the clue. He knew now why the name Kirt'

110 AGATHA CHRISTIE |

lington Mallet was familiar. Three months before he k
read every detail of the astonishing disappearance of r
tain Richard Harwell. Like other newspaper readers I?

over Great Britain, he had puzzled over the details of »»> disappearance, and,
also like every other Briton ha'

evolved his own theories.

"Of course," he repeated. "It was at Kirtlington Mallet i happened."

"It was at this house he stayed for the hunting las

winter," said the landlord. "Oh! I knew him well. A mai; handsome young
gentleman and not one that you'd thin

had a care on his mind. He was done away with—that'

my belief. Many's the time I've seen them come ridin

home together—he and Miss Le Couteau, and all the vi'

lage saying there'd be a match come of it—and sur

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enough, so it did. A very beautiful young lady, and we thought of, for all she was a Canadian and a stranger. At there's some dark mystery there. We'll never know the rights of it. It broke her heart. It did, sure enough. You've heard as she's sold the place up and gone abroad; couldn't bear to go on here with everyone staring and pointing at her—through no fault of her own, poor young dear? black mystery, that's what it is."

He shook his head, then, suddenly recollecting his duties, hurried from the room.

"A black mystery," said Mr. Quin softly.

His voice was provocative in Mr. Satterthwaite's ears.

"Are you pretending that we can solve the mystery; where Scotland Yard failed?" he asked sharply.

The other made a characteristic gesture.

"Why not? Time has passed. Three months. That makes a difference."

"That is a curious idea of yours," said Mr. Satterthwaite slowly. "That one sees things better afterward than at the time."

"The longer the time that has elapsed, the more things fall into proportion. One sees them in their true relations."

ship to one another."

There was a silence which lasted for some minutes.

" y vss

AT THE BELLS AND MOTLEY Bl 111

not'sure," said Mr. Satterthwaite, in a hesitating

"I ""that I remember the facts clearly by now." ^ ;

"Tthink you do," said Mr. Quin quietly.

It was all the encouragement Mr. Satterthwaite needed.

., general role in life was that of listener and looker on.

_Jniv in the company of Mr. Quin was the position re- ""rsed. There Mr. Quin was the appreciative listener, and

Mr. Sattertbwaite took the center of the stage.

"It was just over a year ago," he said, "that Ashley Grange passed into the possession of Miss Eleanor Le Couteau. It is a beautiful old house, but it had been negtected

and allowed to remain empty for many years. It;

could not have found a better chatelaine. Miss Le Couteau ? was a French Canadian, her forebears were emigres from

the French Revolution, and had handed down to her a col- :.j lection of almost priceless French relics and antiques. She ,;;; was a buyer and a collector also, with a very fine and ?? discriminating taste, so much so that, when she decided to

sell Ashley Grange and everything it contained after the

tragedy, Mr. Cyrus G. Bradburn, the American millionaire, ; smade no bones about paying the fancy price of sixty thou- '& sand pounds for theGrange as it stood." ^|§; ;"Mr. Satterthwaite paused."I mention these things," he said apologetically, "not becausethey are relevant to the story--strictly speaking,

they are not--but to convey an atmosphere, the atmosphere of young Mrs.

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Harwell. "Mr. Quin nodded. "Atmosphere is always valuable," he said gravely. "So we get a picture of this girl," continued the other. Just twenty-three, dark, beautiful, accomplished, nothing [^]de and unfinished about her. And rich--we must not wget that. She was an orphan. A Mrs. St. Clair, a lady of ""npeachable breeding and social standing, lived with her las duenna. But Eleanor Le Couteau had complete control 01 her own fortune. And fortunehunters are never hard

o seek. At least a dozen impecunious young men were to be found dangling around her on all occasions, in the hunting- "d, in the ballroom, wherever she went. Young Lord Lec-112 AGATHA CH11""1^ ^, the most eligible party in the country is reported to have asked her to marry him, but she refused. That is, until the coming of Captain Richard Harwell, "Captain Harwell had put himself at the local run of the hunting. He was a dashing rider to hounds, a handsome laughing daredevil of a fellow. "You remember the old saying, Mr. Quin?

-Happy the ^woomS that s not long doing.-The adage was carried out at11
leastmpart- At theend of two months, RichardHarwe611 an(l Eleanor Le
Couteauere engaged, three months afterward. TheThe marriage followed tl ""
happy pair went abroad for a.B two weeks honeymoon,and then turned to take
up then"- residence at ^Y G^. The landlord has just told

^that t wason B111^! of ^n ^uch as this that they^^ to their hom^ ^ nn- , , , , , , , , ..ell. Be that asit may, the fol""en,I wonder? Who can " , , , , , . -
'owingmorning very ^y--^^^--^^tain iLwell was seen waiki^ n thegardenby
one of the (, , , , , , , , , , Tilewas bareheaded, and wasgardeners, John Mathias.
M . 'wh- , , , , i- , , * , ^ there, a picture of lightheart""isting. We have a picture .
, " , Tpri , , , i i . , , , , » And y^ from that minute, aseoness of careless happiness. /
. 'fa. ' , ...r set eyes on Captain Richard lar as we know, no one eve ' r~*arv?
(>11 af?ain '*» , , , , , a pleasantly conscious of a draMrSatterthwaite paused, " '
.m»f * ti, i, ^,ir,S glance of Mr. Quin gave him "^tic moment.

The adminnf ° < &the tribute he needed, and h6^"10"-The disappearance was remarka-ble-unaccoun^table It^s not till the following ^ that the dstracted w^called i" the police. As youkno/" ^ have not succeeded wwiving the mystery." - ,,,,,,, "There have, I suppose been theones?" ^ked Mr.

QU!Sh! theories, I grant yc"- J1160^ No- l,that ^P13111 Harwell had been murder ,done ^ ^- ^ rf .so. Wh^re was the body? It c1;" hardly have been spirited

aw^y. And besides, what r?^6^ there? As far as was

known. Captain Harwell h3"01 an enemv m t^ world. He paused abruptly, a.110"?11

uncertam; Mr, Q"10 leaned forward. "You wthlT±mSn he said softly, of Young Stephen Grant." |

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I am," admitted Mr. Satterthwaite. "Stephen Grant, if I remember rightly, had been in charge of Captain Harwell's

horses, and had been discharged by his master for some

trifling offence. On the morning after the homecoming,

very early, Stephen Grant was seen in the vicinity of Ash- ley Grange, and could

"give no good account of his presence

there. He was detained by the police as being concerned

in the disappearance of Captain Harwell, but

nothing could be proved against him, and he was eventually

discharged. It is true that he might be supposed to bear a

grudge against Captain Harwell for his summary dismissal,

but the motive was undeniably of the flimsiest. I suppose

the police felt they must do something. You see, as I said

just now. Captain Harwell had not an enemy in the

world."

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"As far as was known," said Mr. Quin reflectively.

Mr. Satterthwaite nodded appreciatively.

"We are coming to that. What, after all, was known of

Captain Harwell? When the police came to look into his antecedents they were confronted with a singular paucity of

material. Who was Richard Harwell? Where did he come

from? He had appeared literally out of the blue, as it seemed.

He was a magnificent rider, and apparently well off. Nobody

in Kirtlington Mallet had bothered to inquire further. Miss

Le Couteau had had no parents or guardians to make inquiries into the prospects and standing of her fiance. She

was her own mistress. The police theory at this point was

clear enough. A rich girl and an impudent impostor. The

—kl story!

J"But it was not quite that. True, Miss Le Couteau had

no parents or guardians, but she had an excellent firm of

solicitors in London who acted for her. Their evidence "lade the mystery deeper.

Eleanor Le Couteau had wished

to settle a sum outright upon her prospective husband, but

he had refused. He himself was well off, he declared. It ^as proved conclusively that Harwell never had a penny of his wife's money. Her fortune

was absolutely intact.

"He was, therefore, no common swindler; but was his

object a refinement of the art? Did he propose blackmail at some future date if Eleanor Harwell should wish to marry

1144 AGATHA CHRISTIE d; |j|

some other man? I will admit that something of that kind

seemed to me the most likely solution. It has always

seemed so to me--until tonight."

Mr. Quin leaned forward, prompting him.

"Tonight?"

"Tonight--I am not satisfied with that. How did he

manage to disappear so suddenly and completely--at that hour in the morning, with every laborer bestirring himself and tramping to work? Bareheaded, too." "There is no doubt about that latter point--since the gardener saw him?" "Yes--the gardener--John Mathias. Was there anything there, I wonder?" "The police would not overlook him," said Mr. Quin. "They questioned him closely. He never wavered in his statement. His wife bore him out. He left his cottage at seven to attend to the greenhouses; he returned at twenty minutes to eight. The servants in the house heard the front door slam at about a quarter after seven. That fixes the time when Captain Harwell left the house. Ah! yes, I know what you are thinking." "Do you, I wonder?" said Mr. Quin. "I fancy so. Time enough for Mathias to have made away with his master. But why, man, why? And if so, where did he hide the body?" "If Sir John Mathias came in bearing a tray. 'Sorry to have kept you so long, gentlemen.' The odor from the dishes was pleasant to Mr. Satterthwaite's nostrils. He felt gracious. 'This looks excellent,'

he said. 'Most excellent. We have been discussing the disappearance of Captain Harwell. What became of the garden, Mr. Mathias?' " "Took a place in Essex, I believe. Didn't care to stay hereabouts. There were some as looked askance at him, you understand. Not that I ever believed he had anything to do with it." Mr. Satterthwaite helped himself. Mr. Quin followed suit. The

landlord seemed disposed to linger and chat. Mr- Satterthwaite had **Page 61**

no objection; on the contrary. "Tb_Mlathias now," he said. "What kind of a man was he?" IB

once, but bent and crippled with rheumatism. He had that mortal, bad, was laid up many a time with it, unable to do any work. For my part, I think it was sheer kindness on Miss Eleanor's part to keep him on. He'd outgrown his usefulness as a gardener, though his wife managed to make herself useful up at the house. Been a cook, she had, and always willing to lend a hand. "What sort of a woman was she?" asked Mr. Satterthwaite, quickly, 'y- The landlord's answer disappointed him. "A plain body. Middle-aged, and dour-like in manner. Deaf, too. Not that I ever knew much of them. They'd only been here a month, you understand, when the thing happened. They say he'd been a rare good gardener in his time, though. Wonderful testimonials Miss Eleanor had with him." "Was she interested in gardening?" asked Mr. Quin softly. "No, sir, I couldn't say that she was, not like some of the ladies round here who pay good money to gardeners and spend the whole of their time grubbing about on their knees as well. Foolishness I call it. You see. Miss Le Couteau wasn't here very much except in the winter for the hunting. The rest of the time she was up in London and

away in those foreign seaside places where they say the French ladies don't so much as put a toe into the water for

fear of spoiling their costumes, or so I've heard."

Mr. Satterthwaite smiled. "There was no--er--woman

of any kind mixed up with Captain Harwell?" he asked.

Though his first theory was disposed of, he nevertheless

_ng to his idea.

jMr. William Jones shook his head. "Nothing of that ^rt. Never a whisper of it.

No, it's a dark mystery, that's

what it is."

"And your theory? What do you yourself think?" persisted Mr. Satterthwaite.

"What do I think?"

"Yes."

"Don't know what to think. It's my belief as how he was 116 AGATHA CHRISTIE

done in, but who by I can't say. I'll fetch you ppnn " the cheese." ^n 8entlen_

He stumped from the room bearing empty dishes TiP

storm, which had been quieting down, suddenly broke

with redoubled vigor. A flash of forked lightning and

great clap of thunder close upon each other made little M

Satterthwaite jump, and before the last echoes of the thun^ der had died away, a girl came into the room carrying the

advertised cheese.

She was tall and dark, and handsome in a sullen fashior

of her own. Her likeness to the landlord of the Bells and

Motley was apparent enough to proclaim her his daughter.

"Good evening, Mary," said Mr. Quin. "A stormy night."

She nodded. "I hate these stormy nights," she muttered.

"You are afraid of thunder, perhaps?" said Mr. Satterthwaite kindly.

"Afraid of thunder? Not me! There's little that I'm afraid of. No, but the storm sets them off. Talking, talking, the same thing over and over again, like a lot of parrots.

Father begins it: 'It reminds me, this does, of the night

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poor Captain Harwell--' And so on, and so on." She

turned on Mr. Quin. "You've heard how he goes on. What's the sense of it? Can't anyone let past things be?"

"A thing is only past when it is done with," said Mr.

Quin.

"Isn't this done with? Suppose he wanted to disappear?

These fine gentlemen do sometimes." w| 'fl

"You think he disappeared of his own free will?"

"Why not? It would make better sense than to suppose a

kindhearted creature like Stephen Grant murdered him.

What should he murder him for, I should like to know?

Stephen had had a drop too much one day and spoke to him s'wcy like, and got the sack for it. But what of it? He got

another place just as good. Is that a reason to murder a

man in cold blood?" |

"But surely," said Mr. Satterthwaite, "the police were quite satisfied of his innocence."

"The police! What do the police matter? When Stephen

comes into the bar of an evening, every man looks at him

^^| AT THE BELLS AND MOTLEY 117

l'ke They don't really believe he murdered Harwell, ^they're not sure, and so they look at him sideways and °? away. Nice life for a man, to see people

shrink away

you^ as though you were something different from the

t of the folks. Why won't Father hear of our getting

married, Stephen and I? 'You can take your pigs to a better

market, my girl. I've nothing against Stephen, but- well, we don't know, do we?'

"

She stopped, her breast heaving with the violence of her

resentment.

"It's cruel, cruel, that's what it is," she burst out. "Stephen, that wouldn't hurt a fly! And all through life there'll be

people who'll think he did it. It's turning him queer and

bitter like. I don't wonder, I'm sure. And the more he's like that, the more people think there must have been something

in it."

Again she stopped. Her eyes were fixed on Mr. Quin's

face, as though something in it was drawing this outburst

from her.

"Can nothing be done?" said Mr. Satterthwaite. ';

He was genuinely distressed. The thing was, he saw, inevitable.

The very vagueness and unsatisfactoriness of the

evidence against Stephen Grant made it the more difficult

for him to disprove the accusation.

The girl whirled round on him. "Nothing but the truth can help him," she cried. "If Captain Harwell were to be found, if he was to come back. If the true rights of it were only known--"

She broke off with something very like a sob, and hurried quickly from the room.

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"A fine-looking girl," said Mr. Satterthwaite. "A sad case altogether. I wish--I very much wish that something could be done about it."

His kind heart was troubled.

"We are doing what we can," said Mr. Quin. "There is still nearly half an hour before your car can be ready."

Mr. Satterthwaite stared at him. "You think we can come at the truth by--talking it over like this?"

"You have seen much of life," said Mr. Quin gravely. "More than most people."

"Mi

118 AGATHA CHRISTIE "Life has passed me by," said Mr. Satterthwaite bitterly. "But in so doing has sharpened your vision. Where others are blind you can see." "It is true," said Mr. Satterthwaite. "I am a great observer." He plumed himself complacently. The moment of bitterness was past. "I look at it like this," he said after a minute or two. "To get at the cause for a thing we must study the effect." "Very good," said Mr. Quin approvingly. "3 -- ;

"The effect in this case is that Miss Couteau--Mrs. Harwell, I mean--is a wife and yet not a wife.

She is not free--she cannot marry again. And look at it as we will, we see Richard Harwell as a sinister figure, a man from nowhere with a mysterious past."

"I agree," said Mr. Quin. "You see what all are bound to see, what cannot be missed, Captain Harwell in the

limelight, a suspicious figure."

Mr. Satterthwaite looked at him doubtfully. The words

seemed somehow to suggest a faintly different picture to

his mind. "We have studied the effect," e said. "Or call it the result. We can now pass--"

Mr. Quin interrupted him. "You ba} not touched on the result on the strictly material side."

" "You are right," said Mr. Satterthwaite after a moment or two for consideration. "One should <o the thing thoroughly.

Let us say then that the result of he tragedy is that

Mrs. Harwell is a wife and not a wife, unable to marry

again, that Mr. Cyrus Bradburn has beenable to buy Ashley

Grange and its contents for--sixty housand pounds,

was it?--and that somebody in Essex ha' been able to secure

John Mathias as a gardener! For al that, we do not

suspect 'somebody in Essex' or Mr. Cy-us Bradburn of

having engineered the disappearance of Cmtain Harwell."

"You are sarcastic," said Mr. Quin.

Mr. Satterthwaite looked sharply at rim. "But surely

you agree--"

"Oh! I agree," said Mr. Quin. "The idea is absurd. What next?"

"Let us imagine ourselves back on the fatal day. The dis-

. i '

AT THE BELLS AND MOTLEY 119

ance has taken place, let us say, this very morning."

^No, no," said Mr. Quin, smiling. "Since, in our imagination at least, we have

power over time, let us turn it the

ther way. Let us say the disappearance of Captain Harwell

ok place a hundred years ago. That we, in the twenty-

Page 64

-st century, are looking back."

"You are a strange man," said Mr. Satterthwaite slowly.

you believe in the past, not the present. Why?"

"You used, not long ago, the word atmosphere. There is no atmosphere in the present."

"That is true, perhaps," said Mr. Satterthwaite thoughtfully.

"Yes, it is true. The present is apt to be--parochial."

"A good word," said Mr. Quin.

Mr. Satterthwaite gave a funny little bow. "You are too kind," he said.

"Let us take--not this present year, that would be too

difficult, but say--last year," continued the other. "Sum it up for me, you, who have the gift of the neat phrase."

Mr. Satterthwaite thought for a minute. He was jealous of his reputation.

"A hundred years ago we have the age of powder and

patches," he said. "Shall we say that today is the age of crossword puzzles and cat burglars?"

"Very good," approved Mr. Quin. "You mean that nationally, not internationally, I presume?"|§§|

"As to crossword puzzles, I must confess that I do not know," said Mr.

Satterthwaite. "But the cat burglar had a great inning on the Continent. You remember that series of

famous thefts from French chateaux? It is surmised that

one man alone could not have done it. The most miraculous feats were performed to gain admission. There was a theory that a troupe of acrobats were concerned--the 'londinis. I once saw their performance---truly masterly. A mother, son, and daughter. They vanished from the stage in a rather mysterious fashion. But we are wandering from our subject." "Not very far," said Mr.

Quin. "Only across the channel." ; | . "Where the French ladies will not wet their toes accord- "ig to our worthy host," said Mr. Satterthwaite laughing.

tliti

I valuable objects (fart, and in consequence difficult to dispose of. She buys the house--for a mere song, probably--settles down there and pays a good sum to an irreproachable Englishwoman to chaperon her. Then he comes. The plot is laid beforehand. The marriage, the disappearance, and then nine days' wonder! What more natural than that a brokenhearted woman should want to sell everything that reminds her of past happiness? The American is a connoisseur, the things are genuine and beautiful, some of them beyond price. He makes an offer, she accepts. She leaves the neighborhood, a sad and tragic figure. The great coup has come off. The eye of the public has been deceived by the quickness of the hand and the spectacular nature of the trick." Mr.

Satterthwaite paused, flushed with triumph. "But for you, I should never have seen it," he said with sudden humility. "You have a most curious effect upon me. One says things so often without even seeing what they really mean. You have the knack of showing one. But it is still not quite clear to me. It must have been most difficult for Harwell to disappear as he did. After all, the police all over England were looking for him." "They were probably looking," said Mr. Quin, "all over England." "It would have been simplest to remain hidden at the Grange," mused Mr.

Satterthwaite. "If it could be managed." "He was, I think, very near the Grange," said Mr.

Quin. His look of significance was not lost on Mr. Satterthwaite. "Mathias's cottage?" he exclaimed. "But the police must have searched it?" "Repeatedly, I should imagine," said Mr.

Quin. "Mathias," said Mr. Satterthwaite, frowning. "'And Mrs. Mathias," said Mr. Quin.^r

Satterthwaite stared hard at him. "If that gang was really the Clondinis," he said dreamily, "there **Page 65**

are three of 'em in it. The two young ones were Harwell and Eleanor -e Couteau. The mother now, was she Mrs. Mathias? But in that case." Mathias suffered from rheumatism, did he not?"

said Mr. Quin innocently. 'm. '- ..:

122 AGATHA CHRISTIE "Oh!" cried Mr. Satterthwaite. "I have it. But could it be done? I believe it could. Listen. Mathias was there a month. During that time, Harwell and Eleanor were away for a fortnight on a honeymoon. For the fortnight before the wedding, they were supposedly in town. A clever man could have doubled the parts of Harwell and Mathias.

When Harwell was at Kirtlington Mallet, Mathias was conveniently laid up with rheumatism, with Mrs. Mathias to

sustain the fiction. Her part was very necessary. Without

her, someone might have suspected the truth. As you say,

Harwell was hidden in Mathias's cottage. He was Mathias.

When at last the plans matured, and Ashley Grange was

sold, he and his wife gave out that they were taking a place in Essex. Exit John Mathias and his wife--forever."

There was a knock at the coffee-room door, and Masters entered.

"The car is at the door, sir," he said.

Mr. Satterthwaite rose. So did Mr. Quin, who went

across to the window, pulling the curtains. A beam of

moonlight streamed into the room. 4. ; J

"The storm is over," he said. ' :: I

Mr. Satterthwaite was pulling on his gloves. "The Commissioner is dining with me next week," he said importantly.

"I shall put my theory--ah!--before him."

"It will be easily proved or disproved," said Mr. Quin.

"A comparison of the objects at Ashley Grange with a list supplied by the French police--!"

"Just so," said Mr. Satterthwaite. "Rather hard luck on Mr. Bradburn, but--well--" - -m

"He can, I believe, stand the loss," said Mr. Quin. 1

Mr. Satterthwaite held out his hand. "Good-by," he said.

"I cannot tell you how much I have appreciated this unexpected meeting. You are leaving here tomorrow, I think you said?"

"Possibly tonight. My business here is done. I come and go, you know."

Mr. Satterthwaite remembered hearing those same words earlier in the evening. Rather curious.

He went out to the car and the waiting Masters. Fro®

^ ' AT THE BELLS AND MOTLEY '-";' ' 123

the open door into the bar the landlord's voice floated out, rich and complacent.

"A dark mystery," he was saying. "A dark mystery, that's "hat it is."

But he did not use the word "dark." The word he used suggested quite a different color. Mr. William Jones was a

man of discrimination who suited his adjectives to his company.

The company in the bar liked their adjectives full

flavored.

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Mr. Satterthwaite reclined luxuriously in the comfortable limousine. His breast was swelled with triumph. He saw the girl Mary come out on the steps and stand under the creaking inn sign.

"She little knows," said Mr. Satterthwaite to himself.

"She little knows what / am going to do!"

The sign of the Bells and Motley swayed gently in the wind. _..

y^

THE CASE OF THE DISTRESSED LADY

the buzzer on Mr. Parker Pyne's desk purred discreetly. "Yes?" said the great man. ,. 1 "A young lady wishes to see you," announced his secretary. "She has no appointment." "You may send her in, Miss Lemon." A moment later he was shaking hands with his visitor. "Good morning,"

he said. "Do sit down."]The girl sat down and looked at Mr. Parker Pyne. She was a pretty girl and quite young. Her hair was dark and wavy with a row of curls at the nape of the neck. She was beautifully turned out from the white knitted cap on her head to the cobweb stockings and dainty shoes. Clearly she was nervous. "You are Mr. Parker Pyne?" she asked. "I am." "The one who--who--advertises?" "The one who advertises." "You say that if people aren't--aren't happy--to--to come to you." "Yes." She took the plunge. "Well, I'm frightfully unhappy. So I thought I'd come along and just--and just see." Mr. Parker Pyne waited. He felt there was more to come. "I--I'm in frightful trouble." She clenched her hands nervously. "So I see," said Mr.

Parker Pyne. "Do you think you could tell me about it?" /-^ fThat, it seemed, was what the girl was by no means sure

THE CASE OF THE DISTRESSED LADY 125 of. She stared at Mr. Parker Pyne with a desperate intentness. Suddenly she spoke with a rush. "Yes, I will tell you.--I've made up my mind now. I've been nearly crazy with worry. I didn't know what to do or whom to go to. And then I saw your advertisement. I thought it was probably just a rump, but it stayed in my mind. It sounded so comforting, somehow. And then I thought--well, it would do no harm to come and see. I could always make an excuse and get away again if I didn't--well, if I didn't--" "Quite so; quite so," said Mr. Pyne. "You see," said the girl, "it means--well, trusting somebody." "And you feel you can trust me?" he said, smiling. "It's odd," said the girl with unconscious rudeness, "but I do. Without knowing anything about you! I'm sure I can trust you." "I can assure you," said Mr.

Pyne, "that your trust will not be misplaced." "Then," said the girl, "I'll tell you about it. My name is Daphne St. John." ; ; ... "Yes, Miss St. John." "Mrs. I'm-- I'm married." "Pshaw!" muttered Mr.

Pyne, annoyed with himself as he noted the platinum circlet on the third finger of her left hand.

"Stupid of me."

"If I weren't married," said the girl, "I shouldn't mind so much. I mean, it wouldn't matter so much. It's the thought of Gerald-- Well, here--here's what all the trouble's about!" She dived in her bag, took something out, and flung it down on the desk where, gleaming and flashing, it rolled

over to Mr. Parker Pyne. It was a platinum ring with a large solitaire diamond. Mr. Pyne picked it up, took it to the window, tested it on the pane, applied a jeweler's lens to his eye and examined it closely. "An exceedingly fine diamond," he remarked, coming back to the table;

"worth, I should say, about two thousand [Pounds at least]."

126 ' AGATHA CHRISTIE « -? . "Yes. And it's stolen! I stole it! And I don't know what to do."

^ "Dear me!" said Mr. Parker Pyne. "This is very interesting." His client broke down and sobbed into an inadequate handkerchief. "Now, now," said Mr. Pyne. "Everything's going to be all right." The girl dried her eyes and sniffed. "Is it?" she said. "Oh, is it?" "Of course it is. Now, just tell me the whole story."

"Well, it began by my being hard up. You see, I'm frightfully extravagant. And Gerald gets so annoyed about it. Gerald's my husband. He's a lot older than I **Page 67**

am, and he's got very--well, very austere ideas. He thinks running into debt is dreadful. So I didn't tell him. And I went over to Le Touquet with some friends and I thought perhaps I might be lucky at chemin and get straight again. I did win at first. And then I lost, and then I thought I must go on. And I went on. And--and--" "Yes, yes," said Mr. Parker Pyne. "You need not go into details. You were in a worse plight than ever. That is right, is it not?" "Yes," Daphne St. John nodded. "And by then, you see, I simply couldn't tell Gerald. Because he hates gambling. Oh, I was in an awful mess. Well, we went down to stay with the Dorchesters near Cobham. He's frightfully rich, of course. His wife, Naomi, was at school with me. She's pretty and a dear. While we were there, the setting of this ring got loose. On the morning we were leaving, she asked me to take it up to town and drop it at her jeweler's in Bond Street." She paused. "And now we come to the difficult part," said Mr. Pyne helpfully. "Go on, Mrs. St. John." "You won't ever tell, will you?" demanded the girl pleadingly. "My clients' confidences are sacred. And anyway, Mrs. St. John, you have told me so much already that I could probably finish the story for myself."

"That's true. All right. But I hate saying it--it sounds so THE CASE OF THE DISTRESSED LADY 127 awful. I went to Bond Street. There's another shop there--Vero's. They--copy jewelry. Suddenly I lost my head. I took the ring in and said I wanted an exact copy; I said I was going abroad and didn't want to take real jewelry with me.

They seemed to think it quite natural. "Well I got the paste replica--it was so good you couldn't have told it from the original--and I sent it off by registered post to Lady Dorchester. I had a box with the jeweler's name on it, so that was all right, and I made a professional-looking parcel.

And then I--I--pawned the real one." She hid her face in her hands. "How could I? How could I? I was just a low, mean, common thief." "Mr. Parker Pyne coughed. "I do not think you have quite finished," he said. "No, I haven't. This, you understand, was about six weeks ago. I paid off all my debts and got square again, but of course I was miserable all the time. And then an old cousin of mine died and I came into some money. The first thing I did was to redeem the wretched ring. Well, that's all right; here it is. But something terribly difficult has happened." "<

, "Yes?" ----- - ' i' "" | "We've had a quarrel with the Dorthheimers. It's oversome shares that Sir Reuben persuaded Gerald to buy. Hewas terribly let in over them and he told Sir Reuben whathe thought of him--and oh, it's all dreadful! And now, yousee, I can't get the ring back." "Couldn't you send it to Lady Dorthheimeranonynously?" "That gives the whole thing away. She'll examine her°wn ring, find it's a fake, and guess at once what I'vedone." ,/"You say she is a friend of yours. What. about telling her the whole truth--throwing yourself on her mercy?" Mrs. St. John shook her head. "We're not such friends as that. Where money orjewelry is concerned, Naomi's ashard as nails. Perhaps she couldn't prosecute me if I gave ^e ring back, but shecould tell everyone what I've done 3nd I'd be ruined. Gerald would know and hewould never tforgive me. Oh, how awful everything is!" She began tor 128 ' A6MHA CHRISTIE cry again. "I've thought and I've thought, and I can't seewhat to dol Oh, Mr. Pyne, can't you do anything?" ;.., "Several things," said Mr. Parker Pyne. |;s; |B "You can? Really?" || "Certainly. I suggested the simplest way because in rnylong experience I have always found it fhe best. It avoidsunlooked-for complications. Still, I see the force of yourobjections. At present no one knows of this unfortunateoccurrence but yourself?" ^'^tt ;l

"And you," said Mrs. St. John." "Oh, I do not count. Well, then, your secret is safe atpresent. All that is needed is to exchange the rings in someunsuspicious manner." Igfe ^.-. ^ys'; "That's it,"

the girl said eagerly. "" "" ' ^M ' "That should not tedifficult. We must take a little time to consider the best method--" |She interrupted hid. "But there is no time! That's what's driving me nearly crazy. She's going to have the ring reset."

"How do you know?"

"Just by chance. I was lunching with a woman the other day and I admired i ring she had on--a big emerald. She said it was the newist thing--and that Naomi Dorthheimer

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was going to have her diamond reset that way."

"Which means that we shall have to act quickly," said

Mr. Pyne thoughtfully.

"Yes, yes." " ; ; . i. "It means gaining admission to the house--and if possible not in a menial capacity. Servants have little chance of handling valuable things.

Have you any ideas yourself,

St. John?" "Well, Naomi is giving a big party on Wednesday.

"This friend of mine mentioned that she had been looking for some exhibitum dancers.

I don't know if any

been settled--" Parker said "I think that can be managed," said Mr. Pyne

"If the matter is already settled it will be all right with

that is all. One thing more, do you happen to

' --> the light switch is situated?" , ^ ble*

--t because a t"

.J

B; " THE CASE OF THE DISTRESSED LADY 129

late one night when the servants had all gone to bed. It's a box at the back of the hall--inside a little cupboard."

At Mr. Parker Pyne's request she drew him a sketch.

"And now," said Mr. Parker Pyne, "everything is going to be all right, so don't worry, Mrs. St. John. What about

the ring? Shall I take it now, or would you rather keep it till Wednesday?"

"Well, perhaps I'd better keep it."

| "Now, no more worry, mind you," Mr. Parker Pyne admonished her.

"And your--fee?" she asked timidly.

"That can stand over for the moment. I will let you know on Wednesday what expenses have been necessary.

The fee will be nominal, I assure you."

He conducted her to the door, then rang the buzzer on his desk.

"Send Claude and Madeleine here."

Claude Luttrell was one of the handsomest specimens of lounge lizard to be found in England. Madeleine de Sara ^ the most seductive of vamps.

Mr. Parker Pyne surveyed them with approval. "My Children," he said, "I have a job for you. You are going to be internationally famous exhibition dancers. Now, attend to this carefully, Claude, and mind you get it right. . ."

Lady Dorthimer was fully satisfied with the arrangements for her ball. She surveyed the floral decorations and

Proved, gave a few last orders to the butler, and remarked

"to her husband that so far nothing had gone wrong!

the (as a ^S^ disappointment that Michael and Juanita, fulfil, ^cers ^om the Red Admiral, had been unable to

^t>rainine^kcontract at the last moment' owing to Juanita's

""S sent ^ ^Ln^e' but instead, two new dancers were W^ed a f ran the ^^y
over th® telephone) who had

The ;-"" in paris^"ed.

Th duly arrived and Lady Dorteimer ap

Page 69

"The turn of the night went splendidly. Jules and Sanchia King and most national it was. A wild Spanish The - Then a dance called the Degenerate's exquisite exhibition of modern dancing.

130 AGATHA CHRISTIE The "cabaret" over, normal dancing was resumed. The handsome Jules requested a dance with Lady Dortheimer. They floated away. Never had Lady Dortheimer had such a perfect partner. Sir Reuben was searching for the seductive Sanchia--in vain. She was not in the ballroom. She was, as a matter of fact, out in the deserted hall near a small box, with her eyes fixed on the jeweled watch which she wore round her wrist. "You are not English--you cannot be English--to dance as you do," murmured Jules into Lady Dortheimer's ear. "You are the sprite, the spirit of the wind. Droushkapetrovka navarouchi." ;;;?; iBA ; "What is that language?" . 'Atii. Sh I "Russian," said Jules mendaciously. "I say something in Russian that I dare not say in English." ;;;'.: } Lady Dortheimer closed her eyes. Jules pressed her close to him.

Suddenly the lights went out. In the darkness Jules bent and kissed the hand that lay on his shoulder. As she made to draw it away, he caught it, raised it to his lips again. Somehow, a ring slipped from her finger into his hand. To Lady Dortheimer it seemed only a second before the lights went on again. Jules was smiling at her. "Your ring," he said. "It slipped off. You permit?" Here placed it on her finger. His eyes said a number of things while he was doing it. Sir Reuben was talking about the main switch. "Some idiot. Practical joke, I suppose." Lady Dortheimer was not interested. Those few minutes of darkness had been very pleasant. »,- p? "Mr.

Parker Pyne arrived at his office on Thursday morning to find Mrs. St. John already awaiting him. "Show her in," said Mr. Pyne. "Well?" She was all eagerness. ^."You look pale," he said accusingly. She shook her head. "I couldn't sleep last night. I was wondering--" 3 "Now, here is the little bill for expenses. Train fares,

THE CASE OF THE DISTRESSED LADY 131 costumes, and fifty pounds to Michael and Juanita. Sixty-five pounds, seventeen shillings. ""Yes, yes! But about last night--was it all right? Did it happen?" .Mr. Parker Pyne looked at her in surprise. "My dear young lady, naturally it is all right.

I took it for granted that you understood that. "What a relief! I was afraid--" ":", :?ria&r?"

Mr. Parker Pyne shook his head reproachfully. "Failure ; a word not tolerated in this establishment. If I do not think I can succeed I refuse to undertake a case. If I do take a case, its success is practically a foregone conclusion." "She's really got her ring back and suspects nothing?" "Nothing whatever. The operation was most delicately conducted." Daphne St. John sighed. "You don't know the load off my mind. What were you saying about expenses?" "Sixty-five pounds, seventeen shillings." Mrs. St. John opened her bag and counted out the money. Mr. Parker Pyne thanked her and wrote out a receipt. "But your fee?" murmured Daphne. "This is only for expenses." S,^;^ "In this case there is no fee." ^bi"*' "iy^^S "Oh, Mr.

Pyne! I couldn't, really!" 'wy ""I>""--"My dear young lady, I insist. I will not touch a penny.

It would be against my principles. Here is your receipt. And now--" With the smile of a happy conjurer bringing off a successful trick, he drew a small box from his pocket and pushed it across the table. Daphne opened it. Inside, to all, appearances, lay the identical diamond ring. g "Brute!"

said Mrs. St. John, making a face at it. "How I hate you! I've a good mind to throw you out of the window." "I shouldn't do that," said Mr. Pyne. "It might surprise people." "You're quite sure it isn't the real one?" said Daphne. "No, no! The one you showed me the other day is safely on Lady Dorthimer's finger."

\par 132 AGATHA CHRISTIE "Then that's all right." Daphne rose with a laugh. ^Ppy "Curious your asking me that," said Mr. Parker Pyne, "Of course Claude, poor fellow, hasn't many brains ^"

might easily have got muddled. So, to make sure, I had an expert look at this thing this morning."

and Mrs. St. John sat down again rather suddenly "Oh! she said?" ' ' ~ (i "That it was an extraordinarily good imitation," said Mr. Parker Pyne, beaming. "First-class work. So that sets your mind at rest, doesn't it?" Mrs. St. John started to say something, then stopped. She was staring at Mr. Parker Pyne. The latter resumed his seat behind the desk and looked at her benevolently. "The cat who pulled the chestnuts out of the fire," he said dreamily. "Not a **Page 70**

pleasant role. Not a role I should care to have any of my staff undertake. Excuse me. Did you say anything?" "I--no, nothing." "Good. I want to tell you a little story, Mrs. St. John. It concerns a young lady. A fair-haired young lady, I think. She is not married. Her name is not St. John. Her Christian name is not Daphne. On the contrary, her name is Ernestine Richards, and until recently she was secretary to Lady Dorthheimer." "Well, one day the setting of Lady Dorthheimer's diamond

ring became loose and Miss Richards brought it up

to town to have it fixed. Quite like your story here, is it

not? The same idea occurred to Miss Richards that occurred

to you. She had the ring copied. But she was a farsighted

young lady. She saw a day coming when Lady Dorthheimer

would discover the substitution. When that happened,

she would remember who had taken the ring to

town and Miss Richards would be instantly suspected.

"So what happened? First, I fancy. Miss Richards invested in a La Merveilleuse transformation--Number Seven

side parting, I think"--his eyes rested innocently on his client's wavy locks--

"shade dark brown. Then she called on me. She showed me the ring, allowed me to satisfy myself

that it was genuine, thereby disarming suspicion on my

THE CASE OF THE DISTRESSED LADY 133

---- (Up) and a plan of substitution arranged, the

... took the ring to the jeweler, who in due course handed it to Lady Dorthheimer.

|| ?;

Yesterday evening the other ring, the false ring, was

ediv handed over at the last minute at Waterloo StaOuite

rightly, Miss Richards did not consider that Mr. " .yell was likely to be an authority on diamonds. But just

satisfy myself that everything was aboveboard I arraneed

for a friend of mine, a diamond merchant, to be on

the train. He looked at the ring and pronounced at once,

This is not a real diamond; it is an excellent paste replica.'

"You see the point, of course, Mrs. St. John? When

Lady Dortheimer discovered her loss, what would she remember?

The charming young dancer who slipped the ring

off her finger when the lights went out! She would make inquiries and find that the dancers originally engaged were

bribed not to come. If matters were traced back to my

office, my story of a Mrs. St. John would seem feeble in g§ the extreme. Lady Dortheimer never knew a Mrs. St. John. ' *

The story would sound a flimsy fabrication.

"Now you see, don't you, that I could not allow that? ::;'.

And so my friend Claude replaced on Lady Dortheimer's

finger the same ring that he took off." Mr. Parker Pyne's smile was less benevolent now.

"You see why I could not take a fee? I guarantee to give K?

happiness. Clearly I have not made you happy. I will say ';

just one thing more. You are young; possibly this is your "

first attempt at anything of the kind. Now I, on the con- '

trary, am comparatively advanced in years, and I have had

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a long experience in the compilation of statistics. From

that experience I can assure you that in eighty-seven percent of cases dishonesty does not pay. Eighty-seven percent.

Think of it!"

With a brusque movement the pseudo Mrs. St. John A rose. "You oily old brute!"

she said. "Leading me on!

Making me pay expenses! And all the time--" She choked, and rushed toward the door.

"Your ring," said Mr. Parker Pyne, holding it out to her. .l^,'-^' . > . . '

"brother!" said Pat. &A

With a deepening frown she rummaged wildly in the silken trifle she called an evening bag. Two young men and another girl watched her anxiously. They were all standing outside the closed door of Patricia Gamett's flat.

"It's no good," said Pat. "It's not there. And now what shall we do?" ' '

"What is life without a latchkey?" murmured Jimmy Faulkener.

He was a short, broad-shouldered young man, with good-tempered blue eyes.

Pat turned on him angrily. * ,

"Don't make jokes. Jimmy. This is serious."

"Look again. Pat," said Donovan Bailey. "It must be there somewhere."

He had a lazy, pleasant voice that matched his lean,
dark figure.

"If you ever brought it out," said the other girl, Mildred Hope.

"Of course I brought it out," said Pat. "I believe I gave it to one of you two."
She turned on the men accusingly. "I

had Donovan to take it for me." But she was not to find a scapegoat so easily.

Donovan

Put in a firm disclaimer, and Jimmy backed him up.

"I saw you put it in your bag, myself," said Jimmy. Well, then, one of you
dropped it out when you picked

up your bag. I've dropped it once or twice."

Once or twice!" said Donovan. "You've dropped it a

number of times at least, besides leaving it behind on every possible occasion."

136 AGATHA CHRISTIE

"I can't see why everything on earth doesn't drop out of the sky . . .

it the whole time," said Jimmy.

"The point is—how are we going to get in?" said Mildred. She was a
sensible girl, who kept to the point, but she was

not nearly so attractive as the impulsive and troubling,

Pat.

All four of them regarded the closed door blankly.

"Couldn't the porter help?" suggested Jimmy. "Hasn't he

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got a master key or something of that kind?"

Eat shook her head. There were only two keys. One was in the flat, hung up in the kitchen, and the other was in the bag, or should be—in the bag.

"If only the flat were on the ground floor," wailed Pat

"We could have broken open a window or something. Donovan, you wouldn't like to be a cat burglar, would you?"

Donovan declined firmly but politely to be a cat burglar.

"A flat on the fourth floor is a bit of an undertaking," said Jimmy.

"How about a fire escape?" suggested Donovan.

"There isn't one."

"There should be," said Jimmy. "A building five storeys high ought to have a fire escape."

"I daresay," said Pat. "But what should be doesn't help us. How am I ever to get into my flat?"

"Isn't there a sort of thingummybob?" said Donovan. "A thing the tradesmen send up chops and Brussels sprouts in?"

"The service lift," said Pat. "Oh, yes, but it's only a sort of wire-basket thing. Oh! wait—I know. What about the

coal lift?"

"Now that," said Donovan, "is an idea." '

Mildred made a discouraging suggestion.

"It'll be bolted," she said. "In Pat's kitchen, I mean, on the inside."

But the idea was instantly negatived. m

"Don't you believe it," said Donovan.

"Not in Pat's kitchen," said Jimmy. "Pat never locks and bolts things."

THE THIRD FLOOR FLAT 137 ^TM"think it's bolted," said Pat. "I took the dustbin ^^

morning, and I'm sure I never bolted it afterwards,

^Tdon't think I've been near it since."

""Well," <iaid D0110^"" "that fact's SO^g to be very use ys to-night, but, all the same, young Pat, let me point

you that these slack habits are leaving you at the ""e'rcy of burglars (non-feline) every night."

pat disregarded these admonitions.

"Come on," she cried, and began racing down the four flights of stairs. The others followed her. Pat led them

through a dark recess, apparently full to overflowing of

perambulators, and through another door into the well of Ac flats, and guided them to the right lift. There was, at flie moment, a dust-bin on it. Donovan lifted it off and

stepped gingerly onto the platform in its place. He wrinkled up his nose.

"A little noisome," he remarked. "But what of that? Do I go alone on this venture or is anyone coming with me?"

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"I'll come, too," said Jimmy.

He stepped on by Donovan's side.

"I suppose the lift will bear me," he added, doubtfully.

"You can't weigh much more than a ton of coal," said Pat, who had never been particularly strong on her

weights-and-measures table.

"And anyway, we shall soon find out," said Donovan

cheerfully, as he hauled on the rope.

With a grinding noise they disappeared from sight.

"This thing makes an awful noise," remarked Jimmy, as they passed up through blackness. "What will the people in the other flats think?"

"Ghosts or burglars, I expect," said Donovan. "Hauling this rope is quite heavy work. The porter of Friars Manors

does more work than I ever suspected. I say, Jimmy,

son, are you counting the floors?"

"Oh, Lord! no. I forgot about it."

"Well, I have, which is just as well. That's the third set's passing now. The next is ours."

"And now, I suppose," grumbled Jimmy, "we shall find that Pat did bolt the door after all."

"AGATHA Christie -s But these fears were unfounded out of the 1001 Arabian Nights" "dreadful"

out into inky blackness.

"We ought to have a torch for, ^ night work," explained Donovan. "If I know Pat^g^ the floor, and we shall smash endless crock ,Jfore I can get to the ^ht switch. Don't move about,

^ ^ lightf"6^^^ cautiously ^the floor, uttering one fervent Ouch!" as a corner of t^en table took him unawares in the ribs. He reached i . ^ ^d in another mw^ ano&er "ouchf" floated °of the darkness. ^ ;, ^ "What's the matter?" asked Jim, ""Light won't come on. Dud (; j p^e. Wait a, minute. I'll turn the sitting-room li. ,,,;.; ^T*!-. ' ~ Oil*y The sitting-room was immedia ^^ the passage. Jimmy heard Donovan go out of^ ^^ and presently fresh muffled cries reached him.

Myself edged his way cautiously across the kitchen. -"What's the matter?" "I don't know. Rooms get bewit. ^ ^ght I believe. Everything seems to be in a differe^ ^ . Chairs and tables where you least expected it. 01 ^, cere's another!" But at this moment Jimmy fort^^ connected with the electric-light switch and presse^ ^ ^^q In another minute two young men were looking, . g^ ^ei in silent horror. This room was not Pat's sitting-r r^ ^^e in the wrong flat. To begin with, the room was ^^ ^ times floors crowded than Pat's, which explain^ Donovan's pathetic bewilderment at repeatedly cannoni ^ chairs and tables. There was a large round tablig ^ ^g centre of the room covered with a baize cloth, ani^ ^g^ ^ an aspidi'1 train the window. It was, in fact, th^ ^^ ^ room whose owner, the young man felt sure, wc^y ^e difficult to explain to. With silent horror they gazed^ ^yn gt the table, off which lay a little pile of letters. "Mrs. Ernestine Grant," breathe^

Donovan, P" ^sH 3

"" THE THIRD FLOOR FLAT 139 them up and reading the name. "Oh! help. Do you think she's heard us?" "It's a miracle she hasn't heard you," said Jimmy. "What with the way you've been crashing into the furniture. Come on, let's get out' of here quickly." They hastily switched off the light and retraced their steps on tip-toe to the lift. Jimmy breathed a sigh of relief as they regained the fastness of its depths without further incident. "I do like a woman to be a good, sound sleeper," he said approvingly. "Mrs. Ernestine Grant has her points.""I see it now," said Donovan; "why we made the mistake in the floor, I mean. Out in that well we started up from the basement." He heaved on the rope, and the lift shot up. "We're right this time." , "I devoutly trust **Page 74**

we are," said Jimmy, as he stepped out into another inky void. "My nerves won't stand many more shocks of this kind."

But no further nerve strain was imposed. The first click of the light showed them Pat's kitchen, and in another minute they were opening the front door and admitting the two girls who were waiting outside.

"You have been a long time," grumbled Pat. "Mildred and I have been waiting here ages."

"We've had an adventure," said Donovan. "We might have been hauled off to the police station as dangerous

malefactors." ..,

Pat had passed on into the sitting-room, where she switched on the light and dropped her wrap on the sofa.

She listened with lively interest to Donovan's account of his adventures.

"I'm glad she didn't catch you," she commented. "I'm sure she's an old curmudgeon. I got a note from her this 'Qorning--wanted to see me sometime--something she had ^ complain about--my piano, I suppose. People who don't like pianos over their heads shouldn't come and live in

^ts. I say, Donovan, you've hurt your hand. It's all over _lood. Go and wash it under the tap."

B Donovan looked down at his hand in surprise. He went

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out of the room obed;ntly and presently his voice called to Jimmy.

"Hullo," said the otsr, "what's up? you haven't hurt yourself badly, have you?"

I?

"I haven't hurt myself at all." "

-There was something so queer in Donovan's voice that it was a surprise. Donovan held out his hand--and TimTM-----"11-----^'----- --i*jf am cut of any kind on it. ^--^-----"That's odd," he said, frowning. "There was quite a lot of blood. Where did it come from?" And then, suddenly he realised what his quicker-witted friend had already seen "By Jove," he said. It must have come from that flat." He stopped, thinking over the possibilities his words implied. "You're sure it was--er--blood?" he said. "Not paint?" Donovan shook his head. "It was blood, all right," he said, and shivered. "They looked at each other. The same thought was clearly in both of their minds. It was Jimmy who voiced it first. "I say," he said awkwardly. "Do you think we ought to--well--go down again--and have--a--a look around? See it's all right, you know?" ^"W^"^-

"What about the girl?" .; %s.^:..." »^ "We won't say anything to them. Pat's going to put on an apron and make us an omelet. We'll be back by the time they wonder where we are." s' "Oh, well, come on," said Donovan. "I suppose we've got to go through with it. I daresay there isn't anything really wrong." But his tone lacked conviction. They got into the lift and descended to the floor they wanted. They found their way across the kitchen without much difficulty and once more switched on the sitting-room light. "It must have been in here," said Donovan, "that--that I got the stuff on me. I never touched anything in the kitchen." He looked round him. Jimmy did the same, and they both frowned. Every third look--^---" ^ --" - - - - -' ----

g . THE THIRD FLOOR FLAT 141 ^" ...lies removed from any suggestion of violence or ^

Suddenly Jimmy started and caught his companion's arm. "Look!" Donovan followed the pointing finger, and in his turn uttered an exclamation. From beneath the heavy red curtains there **Page 75**

protruded a foot--a woman's foot in a gaping patent-leather shoe. Jimmy went to the curtains and drew them sharply apart. In the recess of the window a woman's huddled body lay on the floor, a sticky dark pool beside it. She was dead, there was no doubt of that. Jimmy was attempting to raise her up when Donovan stopped him. "You'd better not do that. She oughtn't to be touched till the police come." "The police. Oh! of course. I say, Donovan, what

aghastly business.

Who do you think she is? Mrs. Ernestine Grant?" "Looks like it. At any rate, if there's anyone else in the flat they're keeping jolly quiet." "What do we do next?" asked Jimmy. "Run out and get a policeman or ring up from Pat's flat?" "I should think ringing up would be best. Come on, we might as well go out the front door. We can't spend the whole night going up and down in that evil-smelling lift." Jimmy agreed. Just as they were passing through the door he hesitated. "Look here; do you think one of us ought to stay--just to keep an eye on things--till the police come?" "Yes, I think you're right. If you'll stay, I'll run up and phone." He ran quickly up the stairs and rang the bell of the flat above. Pat came to open it, a very pretty Pat with a flushed ace and a cooking apron on. Her eyes widened in surprise. "You? But how--Donovan, what is it? Is anything the matter?" He took both her hands in his.

i . . .

"It's all right. Pat--only we've made rather an unpleasant discovery in the flat below. A woman--dead." "Oh!" She gave a little gasp. "How horrible. Has she had a fit or something?" "No.

It looks--well--it looks rather as though she had been murdered." "Oh! Donovan." ;Axi: '

, « ' "I know. It's pretty beastly." ^ :- ^ --fter hands were still in his. She had left them there--was even clinging to him. Darling Pat--how he loved her. Did she care at all for him! Sometimes he thought she did. Sometimes he was afraid that Jimmy Faulkner--remember. traces of Jimmy waiting patiently below made him star) guiltily.

"Pat, dear, we must telephone to the police." "Monsieur is right," said a voice behind him. "And in the meantime, while we are waiting their arrival, perhaps can be of some slight assistance."

[They had been standing in the doorway of the flat, and now they peered out on to the landing. A figure was standing on the stairs a little way above them. It moved down and into their range of vision. 1|They stood staring at a little man with very fierce moiré tights and an egg-shaped head.

He wore a resplendent dressing-gown and embroidered slippers. He bowed gallantly to Patricia. "Ala demoiselle!" he said. "I am, as perhaps you know the

tenant of the flat above. I like to be up high--the air the view over London. I take the flat in the name of Mr. C. Connor. But I am not an Irishman. I have another name. That is why I venture to put myself at your service.

"Pardon me." With a flourish he pulled out a card and handed it to Poirot. She read it. "M. Hercule Poirot. Oh!" She caught her breath. "M. Poirot? The great detective? And you will really help me?" "That is my intention, Mademoiselle. I nearly offered my help earlier in the evening." Poirot looked puzzled. ?

THE THIRD FLOOR FLAT 143 "I heard you discussing how to gain admission to your apartment. I am at picking locks. I could without have opened your door for you, but I hesitated to do it. You would have had the grave suspicions of Pat," said Poirot to Donovan. "Go in, I pray of you, and telephone to the police. I will descend to the flat below." Pat came down the stairs with him. They found Jimmy on guard and Pat explained Poirot's presence. Jimmy, in his turn, explained to Poirot his and Donovan's adventures. The detective listened attentively. "The lift door was unbolted, you say? You emerged into the kitchen, but the light it would not turn on." ? He directed his footsteps to the kitchen as he spoke. His fingers pressed the switch. "Tiens! Voilà ce qui est curieux!" he said as the light flashed on. "It functions perfectly now, I wonder--" He held up a finger to ensure silence and listened. A faint sound broke the stillness--the sound of an unmistakable snore. "Ah!" said Poirot. "La chambre de domestique." He tiptoed across the kitchen into a little pantry, out of which led a door. He opened the door and switched on the light. The room was the kind of dog-kennel designed by the builders of flats to accommodate a human being. The floor space was **Page 76**

almost entirely occupied by the bed. In the bed was a rosy-cheeked girl lying on her back with her mouth wide open snoring placidly. Poirot switched off the light and beat a retreat, feeling that she will not wake," he said. "We will let her sleep till the police come." He went back to the sitting room.

Donovan had joined him. "I am not at all."

the police will be here almost immediately, they say," he said breathlessly. "We are to touch nothing." Poirot nodded.

"We will not touch," he said. "We will look, that is all."

He moved into the room. Mildred had come down with Donovan, and all four young people stood in the doorway and watched him with breathless interest.

"What I can't understand, sir, is this," said Donovan. "I never went near the window--how did the blood come on

my hand?"

"My young friend, the answer to that stares you in the face. Of what colour is the tablecloth? Red, is it not? and doubtless you did put your hand on the table." ;

"Yes, I did. Is that--" He stopped.

Poirot nodded. He was bending over the table. He indicated with his hand a dark patch on the red.

"It was here that the crime was committed," he said solemnly.

"The body was moved afterwards."

Then he stood upright and looked slowly round the room. He did not move, he handled nothing, but nevertheless the four watching felt as though every object in that rather frowsty place gave up its secret to his observant eye.

Hercule Poirot nodded his head as though satisfied. A little sigh escaped him. fl

"I see," he said. a

"You see what?" asked Donovan curiously.

"I see," said Poirot, "what you doubtless felt--that the room is overfull of furniture."

Donovan smiled ruefully.

"I did go barging about a bit," he confessed. "Of course, everything was in a different place to Pat's room, and I

couldn't make it out."

"Not everything," said Poirot. a

Donovan looked at him inquiringly, d

"I mean," said Poirot apologetically, "that certain things are always fixed. In a block of flats the door, the window,

the fireplace--they are in the same place in the rooms

which are below each other."

"Isn't that rather splitting hairs?" asked Mildred. She was looking at Poirot with faint disapproval.

"One should always speak with absolute accuracy. That is a little--how do you say?--fad of mine."

There was the noise of footsteps on the stairs, and three men came in. They were a police inspector, a constable.

THE THIRD FLOOR FLAT 145 rid the divisional surgeon. The Inspector recognised **Page 77**

poirot and greeted him in an almost reverential manner.

Then he turned to the others.

"I shall want statements from everyone," he began, "but in the first place--

" „_„„

Poirot interrupted, ^^'^jl '^., '^!: "I'

"A little suggestion. We will go back to the flat upstairs and Mademoiselle here shall do what she was planning to do--make us an omelet.

Me, I have a passion for the omelets.

Then, M. Inspector, when you have finished here,

you will mount to us and ask questions at your leisure."

It was arranged accordingly, and Poirot went up with them. "M. Poirot," said Pat, "I think you're a perfect dear. And you shall have a lovely omelet. I really make omelets frightfully well." "That is good. Once, Mademoiselle, I loved a beautiful young English girl, who resembled you greatly--but alas! she could not cook. So perhaps everything was for the best." There was a faint sadness in his voice, and Jimmy Paulkener looked at him curiously. Once in the flat, however, he exerted himself to please and amuse. The grim tragedy below was almost forgotten. The omelet had been consumed and duly praised by the time that Inspector Rice's footsteps were heard. He came in accompanied by the doctor, having left the constable below. "Well, Monsieur Poirot," he said. "It all seems clear and" above-board--not much in your line, though we may find it hard to catch the man. I'd just like to hear how the discovery came to be made." Donovan and Jimmy between them recounted the happenings of the evening. The Inspector turned reproachfully?., to Pat. "You shouldn't leave your lift door unbolted. Miss. You really shouldn't." "I shan't again," said Pat, with a shiver. "Somebody ought come in and murder me like that poor woman below." fcz,,:,'-^ -.-. S

146 "" AGATHA CHRISTIE H "Ah! but they didn't come in that way, though," said the Inspector. "You will recount to us what you have discovered, yes?" said Poirot. "I don't know as I ought to--but seeing it's you, ^ Poirot. ...""Precisement," said Poirot. "And these young people--they will be discreet." "The newspapers will get hold of it, anyway, soon enough," said the Inspector. "There's no real secret about the matter. Well, the dead woman's Mrs. Grant, all right.

I had the porter up to identify her. Woman of about thirty-five. She was sitting at the table, and she was shot with an automatic pistol of small calibre,

probably by someone sitting opposite her at table. She fell forward, and that's how the bloodstain came on the table." "But wouldn't someone have heard the shot?" asked Mildred. "The pistol was fitted with a silencer. No, you wouldn't hear anything. By the way, did you hear the screech the maid let out when we told her her mistress was dead? No. Well, that just shows how unlikely it was that anyone would hear the other." "Has the maid no story to tell?" asked Poirot. "It was her evening out. She's got her own key. She came in about ten o'clock. Everything was quiet. She thought her mistress had gone to bed." "She did not look in the sitting room, then?" "Yes, she took the letters in there which had come by the evening post, but she saw nothing unusual--any more

than Mr. Faulkener and Mr. Bailey did. You see, the murderer had concealed the body rather neatly behind the

curtains."

"But it was a curious thing to do, don't you think?"

Poirot's voice was very gentle, yet it held something that made the Inspector look up quickly.

"Didn't want the crime discovered till he'd had time to make his getaway."

"Perhaps--perhaps--but continue with what you were saying." "

THE THIRD FLOOR FLAT 147

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The maid went out at five o'clock. The doctor here puts the time of death as--roughly--about four to five hours ago. That's right, isn't it?" "';' ";

The doctor, who was a man of few words, contented himself with jerking his head affirmatively.

"It's a quarter to twelve now. The actual time can, I think, be narrowed down to a fairly definite hour." j';:"

He took out a crumpled sheet of paper.

"We found this in the pocket of the dead woman's dress. You needn't be afraid of handling it. There are no fingerprints on it."

Poirot smoothed out the sheet. Across it some words

were printed in small prim capitals. 1% "I will come to see you this evening at half-past seven.-- ; ";

j.f."^"|r" I ' ; ^ ^s*^'iSS

"A compromising document to leave behind," commented Poirot, as he handed it back.

"Well, he didn't know she'd got it in her pocket," said the Inspector. "He probably thought she'd destroyed it. We've evidence that he was a careful man, though. The pistol she

was shot with we found under the body--and there again ;ssi no fingerprints.

They'd been wiped off very carefully with a silk handkerchief."

"How do you know," said Poirot, "that" it was a silk ; ^;\$ handkerchief?" '%i'

"Because we found it," said the Inspector triumphantly.

"At the last, as he was drawing the curtains, he must have let it fall unnoticed." %

He handed across a big white silk handkerchief--a goodquality handkerchief. It did not need the Inspector's finger to

draw Poirot's attention to the mark on it in the centre. It

was neatly marked and quite legible. Poirot read the name

""t. .. , . iiy. "John Fraser." ':'" ' ':^ ' St

"That's it," said the Inspector. "John Fraser--J. F. in the note. We know the name of the man we have to look for, and I daresay when we find out a little about the dead ^man, and her relations come forward, we shall, spon get a line on him." ^""te;'-; ' ^fK "I wonder," said Poirot. "No, mon cher, somehow I do

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not think he will be easy to find, your John Fraser. He is ; strange man--careful, since he marks his handkerchief

and wipes the pistol with which he has committed th

crime--yet careless since he loses his handkerchief and does not search for a letter that might incriminate him."

"Flurried, that's what he was," said the Inspector.

"It is possible," said Poirot. "Yes, it is possible. And hi was not seen entering the building?"

"There are all Sorts of people going in and out at tha

time. These are big blocks. I suppose none of you"--he addressed the four collectively--"saw anyone coming out o **Page 79**

the flat?" ,

Pat shook her head. il

"We went out earlier--about seven o'clock."

"I see." The Inspector rose. Poirot accompanied him ti the door. ^;

"As a little favour, may I examine the flat below?" id

"Why, certainly, M. Poirot. I know what they think o
you at headquarters. I'll leave you a key. I've got two. I

will be empty. The maid cleared out to some relatives, t0(
scared to stay there alone."

"I thank you," said M. Poirot. He went back into the fla thoughtful. , |

"You're not satisfied, M. Poirot?" said Jimmy. "

"No," said Poirot. "I am not satisfied."

Donovan looked at him curiously. "What is it that- well, worries you?"

Poirot did not answer. He remained silent for a minuti
or two, frowning, as though in thought, then he made i
sudden impatient movement of shoulders.

"I will say good-night to you, Mademoiselle. You nius
be tired. You have had much cooking to do--eh?"

Pat laughed.

"Only the omelet. I didn't do dinner. Donovan art Jimmy came and called for
us, and we went out to a littl1 place in Soho."

"And then without doubt, you went to a theatre?"

"Yes. 'The Brown Eyes of Caroline.' "

"Ah!" said Poirot. "It should have been blue eyes--th1 blue eyes of Mademoiselle."

I H THE THIRD FLOOR FLAT 149

He made a sentimental gesture, and then once more

wished Pat good-night, also Mildred, who was staying the

night by special request, as Pat admitted frankly that she would get the horrors if left alone on this particular night.

The two young men accompanied Poirot. When the

door was shut, and they were preparing to say good-bye to

him on the landing, Poirot forestalled them.

"My young friends, you heard me say that I was not satisfied?

Eh bien, it is true--I am not. I go now to make

some little investigations of my own. You would like to accompany me--yes?" . ,

An eager assent greeted his proposal. Poirot led the way

to the flat below and inserted the key the Inspector had

given him in the lock. On entering, he did not, as the others had expected, enter the sitting-room. Instead he went

straight to the kitchen. In a little recess which served as a scullery a big iron bin was standing. Poirot uncovered this, and doubling himself up, began to rootle in it with the energy of a ferocious terrier.

| Both Jimmy and Donovan stared at him in amazement. * Suddenly with a cry of triumph he emerged. In his hand ^he held aloft a small stoppered bottle.

"Voila!" he said. "I find what I seek."

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He sniffed at it delicately.

"Alas! I am enrhumed--I have the cold in the head."

Donovan took the bottle from him and sniffed in his

turn, but could smell nothing. He took out the stopper and

held the bottle to his nose before Poirot's warning cry could stop him. (

Immediately he fell like a log. Poirot, by springing forward,

partly broke his fall.

"Imbecile!" he cried. "The idea. To remove the stopper in that foolhardy manner! Did he not observe how delicately I handled it? Monsieur--Faulkener--is it not? Will you be so good as to get me a little brandy? I observed a banter in the sitting-room."

He hurried off, but by the time he returned, Donovan

was sitting up and declaring himself quite all right again. He had to listen to a short lecture from Poirot on

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the necessity of caution in sniffing at possibly poisonous

substances.

"I think I'll be off home," said Donovan, rising shakily to his feet. "That is, if I can't be of any more use here. I feel a bit wonky still." - ? "||

. "Assuredly," said Poirot. "That is the best thing you can do. M. Faulkener, attend me here a little minute. I will return on the instant."

He accompanied Donovan to the door and beyond.

They remained outside on the landing talking for some

minutes. When Poirot at last re-entered the flat he found Jimmy standing in the sitting-room gazing round him with puzzled eyes. " ":

"Well, M. Poirot," he said, "what next?" "|

"There is nothing next. The case is finished."self .^f- "What?" _ ,,,,, xLJi-s

"I know everything--now." ::!, ""^|S :. pv. :

Jimmy stared at him. ; g^e; . .1 "That little bottle you found?" ::,)-? ^;^;,i

"Exactly. That little bottle," ^;d»;sl--.,--.,, Jimmy shook his head. 8^|i ^i^i;

"I can't make head or tail of it. For some reason or other I can see you are dissatisfied with the evidence against

this John Fraser, whoever he may be."

"Whoever he may be," repeated Poirot softly. "If be is anyone at all--well, I shall be surprised." ,

"I don't understand." ^""^ "He is a name--that is all--a name carefully marked on a handkerchief!" ,. |1 '|| "And the letter?" ,

"Did you notice that it was printed? Now why? I will tell you. Handwriting might be recognised, and a typewritten

letter is more easily traced than you would imagine--011 if a real John Fraser wrote that letter those two poio8 would not have appealed to him! No, it was written o

purpose, and put in the dead woman's pocket for us

find. There is no such person as John Fraser." ib ;

Jimmy looked at him inquiringly. .

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"And so," went on Poirot, "I went back to the point that first struck me. You heard me say that certain things 1°

THE THIRD FLOOR FLAT ' 151

room were always in the same place under given circumstances.

I gave three instances. I might have mentioned a

fourth--the electric-light switch, my friend."

Jimmy still stared uncomprehendingly. Poirot went on.

"Your friend Donovan did not go near the window--it

was by resting his hand on this table that he got it covered in blood! But I asked myself at once--why did he rest it there? What was he doing groping about this room in darkness? For remember, my friend, the electric-light switch is always in the same place by the door. Why, when he came to this room, did he not at once feel for the light and turn it on? That was the natural, the normal thing to do. According to him, he tried to turn on the light in the kitchen, but failed. Yet when I tried the switch it was in perfect working order. Did he, then, not wish the light to go on just then? If it had gone on you would both have seen at once that you were in the wrong flat.

There would have been no reason to come into this room." "What are you driving at, M. Poirot?

I don't understand. What do you mean?" | "I mean---this." Poirot held up a Yale door-key. "The key of this flat?" "No, wo/i ami, the key of the flat above. Mademoiselle Patricia's key, which M.

Donovan Bailey abstracted from her bag some time during the evening." "But why--why?" "Parbleu! so that he could do what he wanted to do-- gain admission to this flat in a perfectly unsuspecting man- Her . He made sure that the lift door was unbolted earlier in the evening." "Where did you get the key?" Poirot's smile broadened. "I found it just now--where I looked for it--in M. Donovan's pocket. See you, that little bottle I pretended to find ^as a ruse.

M. Donovan is taken in. He does what I knew he would do--unstoppers it and sniffs. And in that little bottle is Ethyl Chloride, a very powerful instant anaesthetic.gives me just the moment or two of unconsciousness I ^e^- I take from his pocket the two things that I knew AGATHA CHRISTIE would be there. This key was one of them--the other---" I He hopped and then went on: J 1 question ^ ^ the time the reason the Inspector gave OF t ebody

^ingconcealed behind the curtain. To gaintime. No, there was more than that. And so I thought of just one thmg^he post,my friend. The evening post thatcomes at half-p^st nine or thereabouts. Say the murderernoes not find something he expects to find, but that something mavhp^-,_,_,_,_,^,_,_- /,,---,-. ,-, , -viiv^n./u uy yus^ LOL^J.* i<wai.iyf u-it'.u, ju,c liiLiaLcome wc]s- N the crime must not be discovered by thewhen she comes in, or the police would take possessionor the flat, so he hides the body behind the curtain. And themaid suspects niothing and lays the letters on the table asusual."

-. --'f...';^! . '...-;-.' -. ;..; ^m" ^ "The letters?" " ..a, ^aial^-,',^^.^1^11- sfe '
.jjes, the lettters."

Poirot drew something from his pocket. fms is the second article I took from M. Donovan n e was Urnconscious." He showed the superscription--a typewritten^ envelope addressed to Mrs.

Ernestine Grant. "But tell me, ^ , , ^--_,----you not in love with Mademoiselle Patricia?"

I care for pg^t terribly--but I've never thought I had a; chance.", "You ^""glitt
that she cared for M. Donovan? It may beinat^she had beggun to care for
him--but it was only a be- gmnlag' my

^ieend. Itis for you to make her forget--tostand byheruii her trouble." ^
Trouble?" ^ j^y ^^

Myes, trouble.;, we will do all we can to keep her name out of it, but it t will be impossible to do so entirely. She was^ you see, theie motive.", He npped °Pe>en the envelope that he held. An enclosure leu out. The covering letter was brief, and was from a firm of solicitors. DEAR

MADAM,he ^"lifnent you enclose is quite in order, andthe ract of thetie marriage having taken place m a forTHE THIRD FLOOR FLAT 153 eign country does not invalidate it in any way.

• Yours truly, etc. Poirot spread out the enclosure. It was a certificate of marriage between **Page 82**

Donovan Bailey and Ernestine Grant, dated eight years ago. "Good grief!" said Jimmy. "Pat said she'd had a letter from the woman asking to see her, but she never dreamed it was anything important." Poirot nodded. "M. Donovan knew—he went to see his wife this evening before going to the flat above (a strange irony, by the way, that led the unfortunate woman to come to this building where her rival lived)—he murdered her in cold blood—and then went on to his evening's amusement. His wife must have told him that she had sent the marriage certificate to her [solicitors, and was expecting to hear from them. Doubtless he himself had tried to make her believe that there was a flaw in the marriage.] "He seemed in quite good spirits, too, all the evening. M. Poirot, you haven't let him escape?" Jimmy shuddered. "There is no escape for him,"

said Poirot gravely. "You need not fear." "It's Pat I'm thinking about mostly," said Jimmy.

"You don't think—she really cared." "Mon ami, that is your part," said Poirot gently. "To make her turn to you and forget. I do not think you will find it very difficult!"

THE PLYMOUTH EXPRESS ^i Alec Simpson, R.N., stepped from the platform at New?";!ton Abbot into a first-class compartment of the Plymouth Express. A porter followed him with a heavy suitcase. He, ^ was about to swing it up to the rack, but the young sailor, III stopped him. "No--leave it on the seat. I'll put it up later. Here you are." "Thank you, sir." The porter, generously tipped, withdrew. Doors banged; a stentorian voice shouted: "Plymouth only. Change for Torquay. Plymouth next stop." Then a whistle blew, and the train drew slowly out of the station. Lieutenant Simpson had the carriage to himself. The December air was chilly, and he pulled up the window. Then

he sniffed vaguely, and frowned. What a smell there was!

Reminded him of that time in hospital, and the operation

on his leg. Yes, chloroform; that was it! ;

He let the window down-again, changing his seat to one

with its back to the engine. He pulled a pipe out of his pocket and lit it. For a time he sat inactive, looking out into the night and smoking. ^'

At last he roused himself, and opening the suitcase, took out some papers and magazines, then closed the suitcase again and endeavored to shove it under the opposite seat--- without success. Some hidden obstacle resisted it. HE shoved harder with rising impatience, but it still stuck out halfway into the carriage.

"Why the devil won't it go in?" he muttered, and hauling it out completely, he stooped down and peered under the seat. . . . wy.

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nt later a cry rang out into the night, and the 1 D101D ggnie to an unwilling halt in obedience to the " tra^ jerking of the communication-cord.

I.^ ami," said Poirot, "you have, I know, been deeply ested in this mystery of the Plymouth Express. Read

.. „

I nicked up the note he flicked across the table to me. It was brief and t^the point, .^y^.^, _ ^:<. '

Dear Sirfe: ?;" mi^ &%®^

I shall be obliged if you wil^ call upon me, at your

riest convenience.

Yours faithfully,

(,;;;. EBENEZER HALLIDAY.

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II^ ••^:

The connection was not clear to my mind, and I looked inquiringly at Poirot. ;": |g||.;

For answer he took up the newspaper and read aloud: •t*'

" 'A sensational discovery was made last night. A young naval officer returning to Plymouth found under the seat of

his compartment the body of a woman, stabbed through

the heart. The officer at once pulled the communicationcord, and the train was brought to a standstill. The woman,

who was about thirty years of age, and richly dressed, has

not yet been identified.' |

"And later we have this: The woman found dead in 'K

the Plymouth Express has been identified as the Honorable .

Mrs. Rupert Carrington.' You see now, my friend? Or if

you do not, I will add this—Mrs. Rupert Carrington was,

before her marriage, Flossie Halliday, daughter of old man -

Halliday, the steel king of America."

"And he has sent for you? Splendid!" ;

"I did him a little service in the past—an affair of bearer ;

^nds. And also, when I was in Paris for a royal visit, I

lad Mademoiselle Flossie pointed out to me. La jolie petite

oensionnaire! She had the jolie dot too! It caused trouble.

?he nearly made a bad affair." . s^^

"How was that?"

"A certain Count de la Rochefour. Un bien mauvais

156 AGATHA CHRISTIE sujet! A bad hat, as you would say. A adventurer pur, and simple, who knew howto appeal to romantic yourit girl. Luckily her father got wind of it in me. Hetook hei back to America in haste. I heard of h<- marriage someyears later, but I know nothing of her husttnd.""H'm," I said. "The Honorable Rupert^arrington is nobeauty, by all accounts. He'd pretty wellrun through hisown money on the turf, and I should imagie old man Halliday'sdollars came along in the nick of the. I should saythat for a good-looking, well-mannered, tterly unscrupulousyoung scoundrel, it would be hfd to find hismatch!" "Ah, the poor little lady! Elle n'est pas bie tombee!" "I fancy he made itpretty obvious at nee that it washer money, and not she, that had attractd him. I believethy drifted apart almost at once. I have herd rumors latelythat there was to be a definite legal separdon.""Old man Halliday is no fool. He would ie up her moneypretty tight.""I dare say. Anyway, I know as a fact hat the HonorableRupert is said to be extremely hard up. |"Ah-ha! I wonder--" I "You wonder what?" ' "My good friend, do not jump down my hroat like that.You are interested, I see. Supposing you accompany meto see Mr.

Halliday. There is a taxi stand at tie corner."A few minutes sufficed to whirl us to the siperb house inPark Lane rented by the American magrate. We wereshown into the library, and almost immedately we werejoined by a large, stout man, with piercing e/es and an aggressivechin. "M.

Poirot?" said Mr. Halliday. "I guess 1 don't need totell you what I want you for. You've read tie papers, andI'm never one to let the grass grow under my feet. I happenedto hear you were in London, and I remembered thegood work you did over those bonds. Never forget a name.I've got the pick of Scotland Yard, but I'll have my ow0man as well. Money no object. All the dollars were madefor my little girl--and now she's gone, I'll spend my 13s1

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^^^""?ch the scoundrel that did it! See? So it's up to ^deliver the goods." ^ _

—

poirot bowed.

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"I accept, monsieur, all the more willingly that I saw

daughter in Paris several times. And now I will ask ' to tell me the circumstances, of her journey to Plymouth and any other details that seem to you to bear upon

the case." ' "

"Well, to begin with," responded Halliday, "she wasn't going to Plymouth. She was going to join a house-party at

Avonmead Court, the Duchess of Swansea's place. She left

London by the twelve-fourteen from Paddington, arriving

at Bristol (where she had to change) at two-fifty. The principal Plymouth expresses, of course, run via Westbury, and

do not go near Bristol at all. The twelve-fourteen does a nonstop run to Bristol, afterward stopping at Weston, Taunton, Exeter and Newton Abbot. My daughter traveled alone in her carriage, which was reserved as far as Bristol, her maid being in a third-class carriage in the next coach." Poirot nodded, and Mr. Halliday went on: "The party at Avonmead Court was to be a very gay one, with several balls, and in consequence my daughter had with her nearly all her jewels--amounting in value, perhaps, to about a hundred thousand dollars." "Un moment,"

interrupted Poirot. "Who had charge of the jewels? Your daughter, or the maid?" "My daughter always took charge of them herself, carrying them in a small blue morocco case." ; "Continue, monsieur." "At Bristol the maid, Jane Mason, collected her mistress' dressing-bag and wraps, which were with her, and came to the door of Flossie's compartment. To her intense surprise, ^ daughter told her that she was not getting out at Bristol, but was going on farther. She directed Mason to get the luggage and put it in the cloak-room. She could have tea, in the refreshment-room, but she was to wait at the station for her mistress, who would return to Bristol by an Up-train in the course of the afternoon. The maid, although very much astonished, did as she was told. She put the luggage in the cloak-room and had some tea. But up train after up-

train came in, and her mistress did not appear. After the arrival of the last train, she left the luggage where it was, and went to a hotel near the station for the night. This morning she read of the tragedy, and returned to town by the first available train. "Is there nothing to account for your daughter's sudden change of plan?" "Well, there is this: According to Jane Mason, at Bristol, Flossie was no longer alone in her carriage. There was a man in it who stood looking out of the farther window so that she could not see his face." "The train was a corridor one, of course?" ". Yes." "Which side was the corridor?" "On the platform side. My daughter was standing in the corridor as she talked to Mason." "And there is no doubt in your mind--excuse me!" He got up, and carefully straightened the inkstand which was a little askew.

"Je vous demande pardon," he continued, reseating himself. "It affects my nerves to see anything so crooked. Strange, is it not? I was saying, monsieur, that there is no doubt in your mind, as to this probably unexpected meeting being the cause of your daughter's sudden change of plan?" "It seems the only reasonable supposition." "You have no idea as to who the gentleman in question might be?" The millionaire hesitated for a moment, and then replied: "No--I do not know at all." "Now--as to the discovery of the body?" "It was discovered by a young naval officer who at once gave the alarm. There was a doctor on the train. He examined the body. She had been first chloroformed, and then

stabbed. He gave it as his opinion that she had been dead

about four hours, so it must have been done not long after

leaving Bristol--probably between there and Weston, probably between Weston and Taunton." -4

u '3

"And the jewel-case?"

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"The jewel-case, M. Poirot, was missing." " «SS

"One thing more, monsieur. Your daughter's fortune-- "to whom does it pass at her death?"

"Flossie made a will soon after her marriage, leaving everything to her husband." He hesitated for a minute, and

then went-on: "I may as well tell you. Monsieur Poirot, that I regard my son-in-law as an unprincipled scoundrel, ^ and that, by my advice, my daughter was on the eve of??^ freeing herself from him by legal means--no difficult mat';'.

ter. I settled her money upon her in such a way that he

could not touch it during her lifetime, but although they

have lived entirely apart for some years, she has frequently,,;,! acceded to his demands for money, rather than face an'?% open scandal. However, I was determined to put an end to ;?:

this. At last Flossie agreed, and my lawyers were instructed to take proceedings."

"And where is Monsieur Carrington?" "'- ;

"In town. I believe he was away in the country yesterday, but he returned last night." ;

Poirot considered a little while. Then he said: "I think that is all, monsieur."

"You would like to see the maid, Jane Mason?"

[F "If you please." ^^i!;,,-':^^ l.i;l ^i,' W^&SI, ' '

||jHalliday rang the bell, and gave a short order to the footman.

A few minutes later Jane Mason entered the room, a respectable, hard-featured woman, as emotionless in the face '

of tragedy as only a good servant can be.

"You will permit me to put a few questions? Your mis- ~

tress, she was quite as usual before starting yesterday rooming? Not excited or flurried?" , ; , ; , "

- "Oh, no sir!" ":KS : ^N , ^ "But at Bristol she was quite different?" / ; / ^ "Yes sir, regular upset--so nervous she didn't seem to know what she was saying." "-- "What did she say exactly?" ' '

w'- "Well, sir, as near as I can remember, she said: 'Mason, ^e got to alter my plans. Something has happened--I

I 160 AGATHA CHRISTIE mean, I'm not getting out here after all. I must go o ' out the luggage and put it in the cloak-room; then ^h some tea, and wait for me in the station.' ' ' ave " 'Wait for you here, ma'am?' I asked. | " 'Yes, yes. Don't leave the station. I shall return by later train. I don't know when. It mayn't be until dilate.'

" 'Very well, ma'am,' I says. It wasn't my place to ask questions, but I thought it very strange."

., ^ "It was unlike your mistress, eh?"

"Very unlike her, sir."

"What do you think?"

"Well, sir, I thought it was to do with the gentleman in the carriage. She didn't speak to him, but she turned round

once or twice as though to ask him if she was doing right."

"But you didn't see the gentleman's face?"

"No sir; he stood with his back to me all the time."

"Can you describe him at all?"

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"He had on a light fawn overcoat, and a traveling-cap. He was tall and slender, like, and the back of his head was

dark." ,,,1 |

"You didn't know him?" , , ,

"Oh, no, I don't think so, sir."

"It was not your master, Mr. Carrington, by any chance?"

Mason looked rather startled.

"Oh! I don't think so, sir!"

"But you are not sure?"

"It was about the master's build, sir--but I never thought of it being him. We so seldom saw him. . I couldn't say it wasn't him!"

I Poirot picked up a pin from the carpet, and frowned at

it severely; then he continued: "Would it be possible for the man to have entered the train at Bristol before you

I reached the carriage?" | ' Mason considered.

"Yes sir, I think it would. My compartment was very

crowded, and it was some minutes before I could get out-- and then there was a very large crowd on the platform,

B

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telayed me too. But he'd only have had a minute

speak to the mistress, that way. I took it for
at he'd come along the corridor."

i more probable, certainly."

sed, still frowning.

low how the mistress was dressed, sir?"

ipers give a few details, but I would like you to

"She was wearing a white fox fur toque, sir, with a white spotted veil, and a blue frieze coat and skirt--the shade of blue they call electric." ^"ffin, rather striking."

^B"Yes," remarked Mr. Halliday. "Inspector Japp is in hopes that that may help us to fix the spot where the crime

took place. Anyone who saw her would remember her." ^--"Precisement!-- Thank you, mademoiselle." ^The maid left the room.

B"Well!" Poirot got up briskly. "That is all I can do here

--except, monsieur, that I would ask you to tell me everything--but everything!" "I have done so."

"You are sure?"

"Absolutely."

"Then there is nothing more to be said. I must decline
the case."

"Why?";

"Because you have not been frank with me."

"I assure you--"

"No, you're keeping something back."

There was a moment's pause, and then Halliday drew a

paper from his pocket and handed it to my friend. "I guess that's what you're after, Monsieur Poirot--though how you know about it fairly gets my goat!" Poirot smiled, and unfolded the **Page 87**

paper. It was a letter bitten in thin sloping handwriting. Poirot read it aloud. "Chère Madame: "

'It is with infinite pleasure that I look forward to the felicity of meeting you again. After your so amiable reply to my letter, I can hardly restrain my impa-
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tience. I have never forgotten those days in Paris. It is most cruel that you should be leaving London tomorrow. However, before very long, and perhaps sooner than you think, I shall have the joy of beholding once more the lady whose image has ever reigned supreme in my heart."

'Believe, chère madame, all the assurances of my most devoted and unaltered sentiments-- a

-" 'Armand de la Rochefour.'" ^H Poirot handed the letter back to Halliday with a bow. "I fancy, monsieur, that you did not know that your daughter intended renewing her acquaintance with the Count de la Rochefour?" "It came as a thunderbolt to me! I found this letter in my daughter's handbag. As you probably know, Monsieur Poirot, this so-called count is an adventurer of the worst type." ^y ----. ^p- ., , , Poirot nodded. ,8.'ah"'-'la :;': .;""; a "But I want to know how you knew of the existence of this letter?" My friend smiled. "Monsieur, I did not. But to track footmarks, and recognize cigarette-ash is not sufficient for a detective. He must also be a good psychologist! I knew that you disliked and mistrusted your son-in-law. He benefits by your daughter's death; the maid's description of the mysterious man bears a sufficient resemblance to him. Yet you are not keen on his track! Why? Surely because your suspicions lie in another direction. Therefore you were keeping something back." "You're right, Monsieur Poirot. I was sure of Rupert's guilt until I found this letter. It unsettled me horribly." "Yes. The Count says:

'Before very long, and perhaps sooner than you think.' Obviously he would not want to wait until you should get wind of his reappearance. Was it he who traveled down from London by the twelve-fourteen, and came along the corridor to your daughter's coffin-partment? The Count de la Rochefour is

also, if I reine®! her rightly, tall and dark!"The millionaire nodded.

THE PLYMOUTH EXPRESS 163 "Well, monsieur, I will wish you good day. ScotlandYard, has, I presume, a list of the jewels?" "Yes. I believe Inspector Japp is here now if you wouldlike to see him."

Japp was an old friend of ours, and greeted Poirot with a sort of affectionate contempt.

"And how are you, monsieur? No bad feeling between us, though we have our different ways of looking at things.

How are the 'little gray cells,' eh? Going strong?"

Poirot beamed upon him. "They function, my good

Japp; assuredly they do!"

"Then that's all right. Think it was the Honorable Rupert, or a crook? We're keeping" an eye on all the regular

places, of course. We shall know if the shiners are disposed of, and of course whoever did it isn't going to keep them to admire their sparkle. Not likely! I'm trying to find out

where Rupert Carrington was yesterday. Seems a bit of a mystery about it. I've got a man watching him."

k"A great precaution, but perhaps a day late," suggested oiroi gently.

"You always will have your joke. Monsieur Poirot. Well, I'm off to Paddington. Bristol, Weston, Taunton, that's my

beat. So long."

"You will come round and see me this evening, and tell me the result?" .

"Sure thing, if I'm back."

"That good Inspector believes in matter in motion,"
 murmured Poirot as our friend departed. "He travels; he **Page 88**
 measures footprints; he collects mud and cigarette-ash! He
 B extremely busy! He is zealous beyond words! And if I
 Mentioned psychology to him, do you know what he would
 "o, my friend? He would smile! He would say to himself:
 ^oor old Poirot! He ages! He grows senile!' Japp is the
 younger generation knocking on the door.' And ma foil
 J^y are so busy knocking that they do not notice that the
 I-0^ is open!"

"And what are you going to do?"
 . As we have carte blanche, I shall expend threepence in
 ^Sing up the Ritz—where you may have noticed our Count
 I--- "-.,,..... ^ --^

164 ^%^ AGATtUiSTIE " ^';
 is staying. After that, as met are a little damp, and I
 have sneezed twice, I shall m to my rooms and make
 myself a tisane over the spump;" y,3

^j
 I did not see Poirot agamy the following morning. I
 found him placidly finishing breakfast. P5"
 "Well?" I inquired eagerly/bat has happened?" ^ "Nothing."

"But Japp?"

"I have not seen him."

"The Count?"

"He left the Ritz the day before yesterday." ^ "The day of the murder?"

-"Yes."

"Then that settles it! Rupert Arrington is cleared."

"Because the Count de laochefour has left the Ritz?"

"You go too fast, my friend."

"Anyway, he must be followed arrested! But what could

be his motive?"

' ? "One hundred thousand dollars' worth of jewelry is a

very good motive for anyone. So, the question to my mind

is: why kill her? Why not simply steal the jewels? She would not prosecute."
is^a^s":- i9B "Why not?" "^^^ stM _ "Because she is a woman, yes, my friend. She
once loved this man. Therefore she would suffer her loss in silence. And the
Count, who is an extremely good psychologist where women are concerned,--
hence his successes,--would know that perfectly well! On the other hand, if Rupert
Arrington killed her, why take the jewels, which would incriminate him
fatally?" ' - v y "As a blind." ^ .v:,:^ "Perhaps you are right, my friend. Ah,
here is Japp! I recognize his knock."

-"The Inspector was beaming good-humoredly. ^ "Morning, Poirot. Only just
got back. I've done some

good work! And you?" _ 1 _ "Me, I have arranged my identity, as," replied Poirot
placidly-"

Japp laughed heartily. .

"Old chap's getting on in years," he observed benea^

THE PLYMOUTH EXPRESS 165 his breath to me. "That won't do for us young folk," he said aloud. "Quel dommage?" Poirot inquired. "Well, do you want to hear what I've done?" "You permit me to make a guess? You have found the knife with which the crime was committed, by **Page 89**

the side of the line between Weston and Taunton, and you have interviewed the paper-boy who spoke to Mrs. Carrington at Weston!" Japp's jaw fell. "How on earth did you know? Don't tell me it was those almighty 'little gray cells' of yours!" "I am glad you admit for once that they are all mighty! Tell me, did she give the paper-boy a shilling for himself?" "No, it was half a crown!"

Japp had recovered his temper, and grinned. "Pretty extravagant, these rich Americans!" "And in consequence the boy did not forget her?" "Not he. Half-crowns don't come his way every day.

She hailed him and bought two magazines. One had a picture of a girl in blue on the cover.

"That'll match me," she said. Oh! He remembered her perfectly. Well, that was enough for me. By the doctor's evidence, the crime must have been committed before Taunton. I guessed they'd throw the knife away at once, and I walked down the line looking for it; and sure enough, there it was. I made inquiries at Taunton about our man, but of course it's a big station, and it wasn't likely they'd notice him. He probably got back to London by a later train." Poirot nodded. "Very likely." "But I found another bit of news when I got back. They're passing the jewels, all right!

That large emerald was pawned last night--by one of the regular lot. Who do you think it was?" "I don't know--except that he was a short man." Japp stared. "Well, you're right there. He's short enough. It was Red Narky." "Who is Red Narky?" I asked. "A particularly sharp jewel-thief, sir. And not one to stick at murder. Usually works with a woman--Gracie Kidd; but she doesn't seem to be in it this time--unless

she's got off to Holland with the rest of the swag." 166 AGATHA CHRISTIE

"You've arrested Narky?" "Sure thing. But mind you, it's the other man we want--the man who went down with Mrs. Carrington in the train. He was the one who planned the job, right enough.

But Narky won't squeal on a pal," y.» I noticed that Poirot's eyes had become

very green. "I think," he said gently, "that I can find Narky's pal for you, all right." "One of your little ideas, eh?"

Japp eyed Poirot sharply. "Wonderful how you manage to deliver the goods sometimes, at your age and all. Devil's own luck, of course." "Perhaps, perhaps," murmured my friend.

"Hastings, my hat. And the brush. So! My galoshes, if it still rains! We must not undo the good work of that tisan. Au revoir, Japp!" "Good luck to you, Poirot." Poirot hailed the first taxi we met, and directed the driver to Park Lane. When we drew up before Halliday's house, he skipped out nimbly, paid the driver and rang the bell. To the footman who opened the door he made a request in a low voice, and we were immediately taken upstairs. We went up to the top of the house, and were shown into a small neat bedroom. Poirot's eyes roved round the room and fastened themselves on a small black trunk. He knelt in front of it, scrutinized the labels on it, and took a small twist of wire from his pocket. "Ask Mr. Halliday if he will be so kind as to mount me here," he said over his shoulder to the footman. (It is suggested that the reader pause in his perusal of the story at this point, make his own solution of the mystery--and then see how close he comes to that of the author's. The Editors.) The man departed, and Poirot gently coaxed the lock of the trunk with a practiced hand. In a few minutes the lock gave, and he raised the lid of the trunk. Swiftly he began

He threw the Plymouth Express 167 Bi among the clothes it contained, flinging them out on the floor. There was a heavy step on the stairs, and Halliday entered the room. "What in hell are you doing here?" he demanded, staring. "I was looking, monsieur, for this." Poirot withdrew from the trunk a coat and skirt of bright blue frieze, and a small toque of white fox fur. "What are you doing with my trunk?" I turned to see that the maid, Jane Mason, had entered the room. "If you will just shut the door, Hastings. Thank you. Yes, and stand with your back against it. Now, Mr. Halliday, let me introduce you to Gracie Kidd, otherwise Jane Mason, who will shortly rejoin her accomplice. Red Narky, under the kind escort of Inspector Japp." Poirot waved a deprecating hand. "It was of the most

simple!" He helped himself to more caviar.

"It was the maid's insistence on the clothes that her mistress was wearing that first struck me. Why was she so anxious

that our attention should be directed to them? I

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reflected that we had only the maid's word for the mysterious man in the carriage at Bristol. As far as the doctor's

evidence went, Mrs. Carrington might easily have been murdered before reaching Bristol. But if so, then the maid must be an accomplice. And if she were an accomplice, she

would not wish this point to rest on her evidence alone.

The clothes Mrs. Carrington was wearing were of a striking nature. A maid usually has a good deal of choice as to what

her mistress shall wear. Now if, after Bristol, anyone saw a lady in a bright blue coat and skirt, and a fur toque, he will be quite ready to swear he has seen Mrs. Carrington.

"I began to reconstruct. The maid would provide herself with duplicate clothes.

She and her accomplice chloroformed and stabbed Mrs. Carrington between London and Bristol,

Probably taking advantage of a tunnel. Her body is rolled

under the seat; and the maid takes her place. At Weston she must make herself noticed. How? In all probability, a newspaperboy will be selected. She will insure his remembrance-168 AGATHA 1

boring her by giving him a large

attention to the color of her dress

the magazines After leaving

out of the window to mark the

sumably occurred, and changed, buttons a

long mackintosh over them. Taunton she leaves the

tram and returns to Bristol as ,^,;Mo TMkBro h»
 ,. , ,,,,,, i soon as possible, where her
 accomplice has duly left the Iv . , , , - rj
 . , •• , . ' , ,. igaage m the cloak-room. He
 hands over the ticket and hm- B°6 , _ . - r ,.-a^ ci,»
 , , - . aself returns to London. She
 waits on the platform, carrymi . , «, ,,, , i,,
 . , - ,, . - . , , , g out her role, goes to a ho-
 ^saT Emd returns to tow11 in the morDi^ exact"When
 Japp returned from ^^ ^ confined
 aU my deductions He also ^ ^ ^ weU-known
 crook was passing the)ewels. ^ ^ ^^ ,t ^
 wou^ ^Q ^ct o^slt6• "of the man Jane Mason de.
 scribed When I heard that it ^ ^ ^o always
 worked with Gracie Kidd-w^ ^ ^ ^here to find
 her- .aypsa^ . - _
 "And the Count?" ^-:^ -<?;t |
 "The more I thought of it ^ more I was convinced
 that he had nothing to do wit!, ^^ gentleman is much
 too careful of his own skin to ^ murder. It would be o_
 of keeping with his character.' , , •
 "Well, Monsieur Poirot," s1' . , uoUiday "I owe y0"

big debt. And the check I wrote would not go near
to settling it" "

Poirot smiled modestly, and murmured to me; "•

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good Japp, he shall get the ^ ^^ credit, all rigiA

though he has got his Gracie . v^a I think that l>i

Americans say, have got his go; ^i»

^^ ,,. ».,,.,, W»«:. V.l^lli' 1»S.;^MR.eastwood looked at the ceiling. Then he lookeddown at the floor. From the floor his gaze traveled slowlyup the right-hand wall. Then, with a sudden stem effort, be^,focused his gaze once more upon the typewriter before^: a him.The virgin white of the sheet of paper was defaced by atitle written in capital letters."THE MYSTERY OF THE

SECOND CUCUMBER," SO it ran. A ;pleasing title. Anthony Eastwood felt that anyone reading_at title would be at once intrigued and arrested by it.

"Thetystery of the Second Cucumber," they would say. "Whatm that be about? A cucumber? The second cucumber? I "ist certainly read that story."

And they would be thrilled"a.charmed by the consummate ease with which this masterelective fiction had woven an exciting plot round this ff^

vegetable.^That was all very well. Anthony Eastwood knew as well asL_6.what ^e story ought to be like--the bother was TOenow or other he couldn'tget on with it. The two ^.- tor a story were a title and a plot--the rest wasP^work; sometimes the title led to a plot all by it- ig tiu^0' aDd then ^

wasplain sailing--but in thisvesti0 continued to adorn the top of the page, and in ^ of a Plot wasforthcoming. ^iling, th01^ Esstwood's gaze sought inspiration from ^S»lize<i oor' and tte wallpaper, and still nothing ban ^1 the i, .L00- "Son- me soma)" said ^thony, to urge----iy pay.

or Possibly Dolores--she shall have aTM ^^"--the kind that's not due to ill-health, 170 AGATHA CHRISTIE ____ and eyes like fathomless pools. The hero shall I," George, or possibly John--something short and R^!1^ Then the gardener--I suppose there will have to hptBh" denar, we've got to drag that beastly cucumber in so a 8ar'or other--the gardener might be Scottish, and amusing?simistic about the early frosts." ^ P^This method sometimes worked, but it didn't seem h. going to this morning.Although Anthony could see S°and George and the comic gardener quite clearly ih"" didn't show any willingness to be active and do things""I could make it a banana, of course," thought Anthony desperately. "Or alettuce, or a Brussels sprout--

Brusselssprout, now, how about that? Really a cryptogram for Brussels--stolen bearer bonds--sinister Belgian baron." For a moment a gleam of light seemed to show, but it died down again. The Belgian baron wouldn't materialize, and Anthony suddenly remembered that early frosts and cucumbers were incompatible, which seemed to put the lid on the amusing remarks of the Scottish gardener. ^^ "Blast it!" said Mr. Eastwood. J He rose and seized the Daily Mail. It was just possible that someone or other had been done to death in such a way as to lend inspiration to a perspiring author. But the news this morning was mainly political and foreign.

Mr. Eastwood cast down the paper in disgust. Next seizing a novel from the table, he closed his eyes

and dabbed his finger down on one of the pages. The word

thus indicated by fate was "sheep." Immediately, with startling brilliance, a whole story unrolled itself in Mr. Eastwood's

brain. Lovely girl--lover killed in the war, her

brain unhinged--tends sheep on the Scottish mountains- mystic meeting with dead lover, final effect of sheep and

moonlight like Academy picture, with girl lying dead in the

snow, and two trails of footsteps. . . .

It was a beautiful story. Anthony came out of its conception with a sigh and a sad shake of the head. He knew

only too well that the editor in question did not want that

kind of story--beautiful though it might be. The kind of

story he wanted, and insisted on having (and incidentally

paid handsomely for getting), was all about mystenoi"

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THE MYSTERY OF THE SPANISH SHAWL 171 men stabbed to the heart, a young hero unjustly we ^ the sudden unraveling of the mystery and scte Ag guft on the least likely person, by means of so inadequate clues--in fact, "the mystery of

["^OND CUCUMBER." «@- ,;

Ltbough," reflected Anthony, "ten to one he'll alter ^ritle and call it something rotten, like 'Murder Most the r without so much as asking me! Oh, curse that telephone." s- %|a

He strode angrily to it, and took down the receiver.

Twice already in the last hour he had been summoned to it

El--once for a wrong number, and once to be roped in for

I dinner by a skittish society dame whom he hated bitterly, but ffho had been too pertinacious to defeat. ||||

"Hallo!" he growled into the receiver. >m"

A woman's voice answered him, a soft, caressing voice irith a trace of foreign accent.

"Is that you, beloved?" it said.

"Well--er--I don't know," said Mr. Eastwood cau,;

tiously. "Who's speaking?" "It

is I. Carmen. Listen, beloved. I am pursued--in clan-

ger--you must come at once. It is life or death now."

"I beg your pardon," said Mr. Eastwood politely. "I'm afraid you've got the wrong--" B She broke in before he could complete the sentence.

"They are coming. If they find out what I am doing, they will kill me. Do not fail me. Come at once. It is death for me if you don't come.

You know, 320 Kirk Street. The

word is cucumber. . . . Hush. ..."

He heard the faint click as she hung up the receiver at; the other end. Mr.

Eastwood, very much astonished, moved over to his tobacco jar, and filled his pipe carefully.

"I suppose," he mused, "that that was some curious effect of my subconscious self. She can't have said cucum- "sr. The whole thing is very extraordinary. Did she say cu- ^Mlber, or didn't she?"

He strolled up and down irresolutely.

"320 Kirk Street. I wonder what it's all about? She'll be ^Peering the other man to mm up. I wish I could have

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explained. 320 Kirk Street. The word is cucumbel-" impossible, absurd--

hallucination of a busy brain." "<1^

He glanced malevolently at the typewriter.

"What good are you, I should like to know? P've been looking at you all the morning, and a lot of good it's done me. An author should get his plots from life--from life a) you hear? I'm going out to get one now."

He clapped a hat on his head, gazed affectionately at his priceless collection of old enamels, and left the flat.

Kirk Street, as most Londoners know, is a long, strae* gling thoroughfare, chiefly devoted to antique shops, where

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all kinds of spurious goods are offered at fancy prices.

There are also old brass shops, glass shops, decayed secondhand shops, and second-hand clothes dealers.

No. 320 was devoted to the sale of old glass. Glassware

of all kinds filled it to overflowing. It was necessary for Anthony to move gingerly as he advanced up a center aisle

flanked by wine glasses and with lusters and chandeliers

swaying and twinkling over his head.

A very old lady was sitting at the back of the shop. She

had a budding mustache that many an undergraduate

might have envied, and a truculent manner.

She looked at Anthony and said, "Well?" in a forbidding voice.

Anthony was a young man somewhat easily discomposed. He immediately inquired the price of some hock

glasses.

"Forty-five shillings for half a dozen." .

"Oh, really," said Anthony. "Rather nice, aren't the?"

How much are these things?" .

"Beautiful they are, old Waterford. Let you have tt

pair for eighteen guineas." .

Mr. Eastwood felt that he was laying up trouble for W"" self. In another minute he would be buying sometbiW hypnotized by this fierce old woman's

eye. And ye

could not bring himself to leave the shop. g

"What about that?" he asked, and pointed to
chandelier.

"Thirty-five guineas."

1

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"Ah!" said Mr. Eastwood regretfully. "That's rather more
^an I can afford."

"What do you want?" asked the old lady. "Something for a wedding present?"

"That's it," said Anthony, snatching at the explanation. "But they're very
difficult to suit."

"Ah, well," said the lady, rising with an air of determination.

"A nice piece of old glass comes amiss to nobody.

I've got a couple of old decanters here--and there's a nice "tittle liqueur set,
just the thing for a bride--"

For the next ten minutes Anthony endured agonies. The
dy had him firmly in hand. Every conceivable specimen
I the glass maker's art was paraded before his eyes. He
icame desperate.

"Beautiful, beautiful," he exclaimed in a perfunctory manner, as he put down
a large goblet that was being

forced on his attention. Then blurted out hurriedly, "I say, are you on the
telephone here?"

"No, we're not. There's a call office at the post office just opposite. Now, what do you say, the goblet--or these fine

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old rummers?" "ay ' "

Not being a woman, Anthony was quite unversed in the gentle art of getting out of a shop without buying anything.

I "I'd better have the liqueur set," he said gloomily.

It seemed the smallest thing. He was terrified of being landed with the chandelier.

With bitterness in his heart he paid for his purchase. And "n, as the old lady was wrapping up the parcel, courage suddenly returned to him. After all, she would only think "a eccentric, and, anyway, what the devil did it matter ^t she thought? 1 "Cucumber," he said, clearly and firmly.

The old crone paused abruptly in her wrapping operations.

"Bh? What did you say?"

"Nothing," lied Anthony hastily.

Oh! I thought you said cucumber."

"So I did," said Anthony defiantly.

"Well," said the old lady. "Why ever didn't you say that 174 AGATHA CHRISTIE

before? Wasting my time. Through that door there and upstairs.

She's waiting for you."

As though in a dream, Anthony passed through the door indicated, and climbed some extremely dirty stairs. At the

top of them a door stood ajar displaying a tiny sittingroom.

Sitting

on a chair, her eyes fixed on the door, and an

expression of eager expectancy on her face, was a girl.

Such a girl! She really had the ivory pallor that Anthony had so often written about. And her eyes! Such eyes! She was not English, that could be seen at a glance. She had a foreign exotic quality which showed itself even in the costly simplicity of her dress.

Anthony paused in the doorway, somewhat abashed.

The moment of explanations seemed to have arrived. But with a cry of delight the girl rose and flew into his arms.

"You have come," she cried. "You have come. Oh, the saints be praised."

Anthony, never one to miss opportunities, echoed her fervently. She drew away at last, and looked up in his face with a charming shyness.

"I should never have known you," she declared. "Indeed I should not."

"Wouldn't you?" said Anthony feebly.

"No, even your eyes seem different--and you are ten times handsomer than I ever thought you would be."

"Am I?"

To himself Anthony was saying, "Keep calm, my boy,

keep calm. The situation is developing very nicely, bjrt
don't lose your head." .'J|

"I may kiss you again, yes?"

"Of course you can," said Anthony heartily. "As often as you like." ^,j

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There was a very pleasant interlude. ^ s »

"I wonder who the devil I am?" thought Anthony. * hope to goodness the real fellow won't turn up. What a

p&rfect darling she is."

Suddenly the girl drew away from him, and terror

showed in her face. "You were not followed here?"

p THE MYSTERY OF THE SPANISH SHAWL ,; 175

"TTo." '

"Ah, but they are very cunning. You do not know them

as I do. Boris, he is a fiend."

'Til soon settle Boris for you."

"You are a lion--yes, but a lion. As for them, they are canaille--all of them.

Listen, I have it! They would have

killed me had they known. I was afraid--I did not know what to do, and then I thought of you. . . . Hush, what was that?"

It was a sound in the shop below. Motioning to him to

remain where he was, she tiptoed out on to the stairs. She

returned with a white face and staring eyes.

"It is the police. They are coming up here. You have a

knife? A revolver? Which?"

"My dear girl, you don't seriously expect me to murder

a policeman?"

"Oh, but you are mad--mad! They will take you away

and hang you by the neck until you're dead."

"They'll what?" said Mr. Eastwood, with a very unpleasant feeling going up and down his spine. His steps sounded on the stair.

"Here they come," whispered the girl. "Deny everything.

It is the only hope."

"That's easy enough," muttered Mr. Eastwood, sotto voce. "Well, 1%

In another minute two men had entered the room. They were in plain clothes, but they had an official bearing

that spoke of long training. The smaller of the two, a little dark man with quiet gray eyes, was the spokesman.

"I arrest you, Conrad Fleckman," he said, "for the murder of Anna Rosenborg. Anything you say will be used in

evidence against you. Here is my warrant and you will do well to come quietly."

,

A half-strangled scream burst from the girl's lips. Anthony stepped forward with a composed smile.

"You are making a mistake, officer," he said pleasantly. "My name is Anthony Eastwood."

The two detectives seemed completely unimpressed by his element.

"We'll see about that later," said one of them, the one AGATHA CHRISTIE who had not spoken before. "In the meantime, along with us." "Conrad," wailed the girl. "Conrad, do not let them . . . ly you."

"Anthony looked at the detectives. "You will permit me, I am sure, to say good-bye to my young lady?" - ~

tn^With more decency of feeling than he had expected, thtwo men moved towards the door.

Anthony drew the e^ into the corner by thewindow, and spoke to her in a raoidundertone.

"Listen to me. What I said was true. I am not Conrad Fleckman. When you rang up this **Page 96**

morning, they musthave given you the wrong number. My name is AnthonyEastwood. I came in answer to your appeal because--well,

1 came." .^ _ She stared at him incredulously. : ,a ^1

"You are not Conrad Pleckman?" H

"No." '

"Oh!" she cried, with a deep accent of distress. "And I kissed you!"

^ "That's aH right," Mr. Eastwood assured her. "The early Christians made a practice of that sort of thing. Jolly sensible.

Now, look here. I'U tool off these people. I shall soon

prove my identity. In the meantime, they won't worry you, and you can warn this precious Conrad of yours. Afterwards--"

"Yes?"

"Well--just this. My telephone number is Northwestern

1743--and mind they don't give you the wrong one."

She gave him an enchanting glance, half-tears, ball a smile.

"I shall not forget--indeed, I shall not forget."

"That's all right then. Good-bye. I say--" "Yes?" . Talking of the early Christians--once more would"

matter, would it?" .^ She flung her arms round his neck. Her lips just toucne"

his. a

.1»

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L ,- like you—yes, I do like you. You will remember
-whatever happens, won't you?"

a tbonny disengaged himself reluctantly and approached
his capt^^"

"I am ready to come with you. You don't want to detain
this young lady, I suppose?"

"No, sir, that will be quite all right," said the small man civilly-

"Decent fellows, these Scotland Yard men," thought Anthony to himself, as
he followed them down the narrow
stairway.

There was no sign of the old woman in the shop, but
Anthony caught a heavy breathing from a door at the rear,
and guessed that she stood behind it, cautiously observing
events.

Once out in the dinginess of Kirk Street, Anthony drew
a long breath, and addressed the smaller of the two men.

a mu

^^q)pi

C4ow, then. Inspector—you are an inspector, I

ose?"

"Yes, sir. Detective-Inspector Verrall. This is Detective Sergeant Carter."

"Well, Inspector Verrall, the time has come to talk

sense—and to listen to it, too. I'm not Conrad What's-hisname.

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My name is Anthony Eastwood, as I told you, and I am a writer by profession. If you will accompany me to my flat, I think that I shall be able to satisfy you of my identity."

Something in the matter-of-fact way Anthony spoke seemed to impress the detectives. For the first time an expression of doubt passed over Verrall's face.

•Carter, apparently, was harder to convince.

"I dare say," he sneered. "But you'll remember the Young lady was calling you 'Conrad' all right."

"Ah! that's another matter. I don't mind admitting to

You both that for—er—reasons of my own, I was passing myself off upon that lady as a person called Conrad. A private matter, you understand." ^ '

"Likely story, isn't it?" observed Carter; "'No, sir, you come along with us. Hail that taxi, Joe."

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passing taxi was stopped, and the three men got inside.

Anthony made a last attempt, addressing himself to Verrall as the more easily convinced of the two.

"Look here, my dear Inspector, what harm is it going to do you to come along to my flat and see if I'm speaking

the truth? You can keep the taxi if you like--there's a generous offer! It won't make five minutes difference either

way." ^ ^a

Verrall looked at him searchingly. ^ '*

"I'll do it," he said suddenly. "Strange as it appears, I believe you're speaking the truth. We don't want to make

fools of ourselves at the station by arresting the wrong

man. What's the address?" ^ ,

"Forty-eight Brandenburg Mansions." :i ? / 4

Verrall leaned out and shouted the address to the taxi

driver. All three sat in silence until they arrived at their destination, when Carter sprang out, and Verrall motioned

to Anthony to follow him.

"No need for any unpleasantness," he explained, as he too descended. "We'll go in friendly like, as though Mr.

Eastwood was bringing a couple of pals home."

Anthony felt extremely grateful for the suggestion and

his opinion of the Criminal Investigation Department rose

every minute.

In the hallway they were fortunate enough to meet Rogers,

the porter. Anthony stopped.

"Ah! Good evening, Rogers," he remarked casually.

"Good evening, Mr. Eastwood," replied the porter

respectfully.

He was attached to Anthony, who set an example of liberality not always followed by his neighbors.

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Anthony paused with his foot on the bottom step on the stairs.

"By the way, Rogers," he said casually, "how long have I been living here? I was just having a little discussion about it with these friends of mine."

"Let me see, sir, it must be getting on for close on forty years now."

"Just what I thought."

Anthony flung a glance of triumph at the two detectives

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Carter grunted, but Verrall was smiling broadly.

"Good, but not good enough, sir," he remarked. "Shall we go up?"

Anthony opened the door of the flat with his latchkey.

He was thankful to remember that Seamark, his man, was out. The fewer witnesses of this catastrophe the better.

The typewriter was as he had left it. Carter strode across to the table and read the headline on the paper.

"THE MYSTERY OF THE SECOND CUCUMBER?" he announced in a gloomy voice.

"A story of mine," exclaimed Anthony nonchalantly.

"That's another good point, sir," said Verrall nodding his head, his eyes twinkling. "By the way, sir, what was it about? What was the mystery of the second cucumber?"

"Ah, there you have me," said Anthony. "It's that second cucumber that's at

the bottom of this trouble."

Carter was looking at him intently. Suddenly he shook his head and tapped his forehead significantly.

"Balmy, poor young fellow," he murmured in an audible aside.

"Now, gentlemen," said Mr. Eastwood briskly, "to business. Here are letters addressed to me, my bankbook,

communications from editors. What more do you want?"

Verrall examined the papers that Anthony thrust upon him.

"Speaking for myself, sir," he said respectfully, "I want nothing more. I'm quite convinced. But I can't take

the responsibility of releasing you upon myself. You see, although it seems positive that you have been residing here as Mr. Eastwood for some years, yet it is possible that

Conrad Pleckman and Anthony Eastwood are one and the same person. I must make a thorough search of the flat, take your fingerprints, and telephone to headquarters,"

"That seems a comprehensive program," remarked Anthony.

"I can assure you that you're welcome to any guilty ^rets of mine you may lay your hands on."

The inspector grinned. For a detective he was a singularly human person.

"Will you go into the little end room, sir, with Carter, ^hile I'm getting busy?"

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"All right," said Anthony unwillingly. "I suppose it couldn't be the other way about, could it?"

"Meaning?"

"That you and I and a couple of whiskies and sodas should occupy the end room while our friend, the sergeant does the heavy searching." jiaff-'

"If you prefer it, sir?" - fe, -- ,.

"I do prefer it." i-^ ^ .

They left Carter investigating the contents of the desk with business-like dexterity. As they passed out of the room, they heard him take down the telephone and call up Scotland Yard.

"This isn't so bad," said Anthony, settling himself with a whisky and soda by his side, having hospitably attended to

the wants of Inspector Verrall. "Shall I drink first, just to show you that the whisky isn't poisoned?" ,. . .

The inspector smiled. ^ "^\| ;

"Very irregular, all this," he remarked. "But we know a thing or two in our profession. I realized right from the

start that we'd made a mistake. But of course one had to

observe all the usual forms. You can't get away from red

tape, can you, sir?"

"I suppose not," said Anthony regretfully. "The sergeant doesn't seem very matey yet, though, does he?" "Ah, he's a fine man, Detective-Sergeant Carter.

You wouldn't find it easy to put anything over on him." "I have noticed that," said Anthony. "By the way, Inspector," he added, "is there any objection to my hearing something about myself?"

"In what way, sir?" "Come, now, don't you realize that I'm devoured by curiosity? Who was Anna Rosenberg, and why did I murder her?" "You'll read all about it in the newspapers tomorrow, sir." "Tomorrow I may be myself with yesterday's ten thousand years," quoted Anthony. "I really think you might satisfy my perfectly legitimate curiosity, Inspector. Cast aside your official reticence, and tell me all." "Very irregular, sir." "I have friends?" "Well, sir, Anna Rosenberg was a German who lived at Hampstead. With no visible means of livelihood, she grew yearly richer and richer." "I'm just the opposite," commented Anthony. "I have a visible means of livelihood and I get yearly poorer and poorer. Perhaps I should do better if I lived in Hampstead. I've always heard Hampstead is very bracing." "At one time," continued Verrall, "she was a second-hand clothes dealer--" "That explains it," interrupted Anthony. "I remember selling my uniform after the war--not khaki, the other stuff. The whole flat was full of red trousers and gold lace, spread out to best advantage. A fat man in a check suit arrived in a Rolls Royce with a factotum complete with bag. He bid one pound ten for the lot. In the end I threw in a hunting coat and some Zeiss glasses and at a given signal the factotum opened the bag and shoveled the goods inside, and the fat man tendered me a ten-pound note and asked me for change." "About ten years ago," continued the inspector, "there were several Spanish political refugees in London--among them a certain Don Fernando Ferrarez with his young wife and child. They were very poor, and the wife was ill. Anna Rosenberg visited the place where they were lodging and asked if they had anything to sell. Don Fernando was out, and his wife decided to part with a very wonderful Spanish shawl, embroidered in a marvelous manner, which had been one of her husband's late presents to her before flying from Spain. When Don Fernando returned, he flew into a terrible rage on hearing the shawl had been sold, and tried vainly to recover it. When he at last succeeded in finding the second-hand clothes woman in question, she **Page 100**

declared that she had resold the shawl to a woman whose name she did not know. Don Fernando was in despair. Two months later he was stabbed in the

street and died as a result of his wounds.

From that time onward, Anna Rosenberg seemed suspiciously flush of money. In the ten years that followed,

182 "THA CHRISTIE her house at Hampstea. ^ burgled no less than eighttunes. Four of the atte, ^ ^re frustrated and nothing was taken; on the other; ^ occasions, an embroidered shawl of some kind was ^g ^ booty." The inspector paused, ^ ^en ^ ^ ^ obedience to an urgent gesture from Ai ^ "A week ago, Carmen ^ez, the young daughter of Don Fernando, arrived u ^ ^ ^ ^

^vent in France. Her first action ^ ^ ^ ^ ^3 Rosenborg at Hampstead. There she;, ^ed to have had a violent scene with the old woma ^ ^ ^ ^, ^ at leaving were overheard by one of the Sgrvantg" 'You have it still,' she ^ ^ } ^ these years you have grown rich on it--but I ssy ^ solemnly that in the end it will bring you bad luck y ^ have no moral right to it, and the day will come wh ^ ^

^ ;, ad never seen the Shawl of the Tho, ^ p ^ ^, Three days after that, Carmen Ferrarez disappeared mysteriously from the hoty ^ ^ ^e was staying. In her room was found a name ai ^

address--the name of Conrad Fleckman, and also a note ^ ^ ^ purporting to be an antique dealer, asking if s ^ ^ ^ to part with a certain embroidered shawl ^ ^ ^ believed she had in her possession. The addres ^ ^ ^ pn the note was a false one.

-"It is clear that the shaw ^ ,, ^e center of the whole mystery. Yesterday morning (^ad Fleckman called upon Anna Rosenberg. She was ^ ^ him for an hour or more, and when he left sh(g ^

^ligned to go to bed, so white and shaken was she ^ ^e interview. But she gave orders that if he came to se ^ ^r again, he was always to be s adnuted- Last D18ht she ^t up and went out about nine fi oclock, and did not return. ^ was found this morning in j the house occupied by Com.

packman, stabbed through I inrnk?0'^ floor b<eside her ^-^ do you" The shawl?" breathed A ^ ^

^ shawl of a Thousand Flowers. "Something far more go, ^ ^ than that. Something which explained the whole, mysterious business of the

fancy that's the chief--"

There had indeed been a ring at the bell. Anthony contained his impatience as best he could, and waited for the inspector to return. He was pretty well at ease about his own position now. As soon as they took his fingerprints they would realize their mistake.

And then, perhaps Carmen would ring up. . . .

He thought of the Shawl of a Thousand Flowers! What a strange story --just the kind of story to make an appropriate setting for the girl's exquisite dark beauty.

Carmen Ferrarez. ...

He jerked himself back from day dreaming. What a time that inspector fellow was. He rose and pulled the door open. The flat was strangely silent. Could they have gone?

Surely not without a word to him.

He strode out into the next room. It was empty--so was the sitting-room. Strangely empty! It had a bare, dishevelled appearance. Good heavens! His enameled--the silver!

He rushed wildly through the flat. It was the same tale everywhere. The place had been denuded.

Every single thing of value, and Anthony had a very pretty collector's taste in small things, had been taken. --With a groan Anthony staggered to a chair, his head in his hands. He was aroused by the ringing of the front doorbell. He opened it to confront Rogers. "You'll excuse me, sir,"

said Rogers. "But the gentlemen fancied you might be wanting something." "The gentlemen?" "Those two friends of yours, sir. I helped them

with the packing as best I could. Very fortunately I happened to have them two good cases in the basement." His eyes dropped to the **Page 101**

floor. "I've swept up the straw as best I could, sir." "You packed the things in here?" groaned Anthony. "Yes, sir. Was that not your wish, sir? It was the tall gentleman told me to do so, sir, and seeing as you were [^]sy talking to the other gentleman in the little end room, I didn't like to disturb you."

„ - " , » 184 AGATHA CHRISTIE "I wasn't talking to him," said Anthony. "He was talking to me--curse him." ,y., , m ;. Rogers coughed. giVi -rfe "I'm sure I'm very sorry for the necessity, sir," he murmured, sa;::;- '%|',-' feel "Necessity?" ^ S^" ^a :s "Of parting with your little treasures, sir." SS la "Eh? Oh, yes. Ha, Hi!" He gave a mirthless laugh. "They're driven off by now, I suppose. Those--those friends of mine, I mean?" "Oh, yes, sir, some time ago. I put the cases on the taxi and the tall gentleman waited upstairs again, and then they both came running down and drove off at once. . . . Excuse me, sir, but is anything wrong, sir?" r^ Rogers might well ask, The hollow groan which Anthony emitted would have aroused surmise anywhere. "Everything is wrong, thank you, Rogers. But I see clearly that you were not to blame. Leave me, I would commune a while with my telephone." Five minutes later saw Anthony pouring his tale into the ears of Inspector Driver, who sat opposite to him, notebook in hand. An unsympathetic man.

Inspector Driver, and not (Anthony reflected) nearly so like a real inspector! Distinctly stagey, in fact. Another striking example of the superiority of Art over Nature. Anthony reached the end of his tale. The inspector shut up his notebook. ,^ "Well?" said Anthony anxiously. ":-. ' ^ ^ "M" Clear as paint," said the inspector. "It's the Patterson gang. They've done a lot of smart work lately. Big fair man; small dark man, and the girl." ;:w "The girl?" . i@'^ il "Yes, dark and mighty good-looking. Acts as decoy usually." :i<|"A--a Spanish girl?" "M" She might call herself that. She was born in Hainpstead." "I said it was a bracing place," murmured Anthony. "Yes, it's clear enough," said the inspector, rising to depart. "She got you on the phone and pitched you a tale^

she guessed you'd come along all right. Then she goes along to old Mother Gibson's, who isn't above accepting a rip for the use of her room for them as finds it awkward to meet in public--lovers, you understand, nothing criminal. You fall for it all right, they get you back here, and while one of them pitches you a tale, the other gets away with the swag. It's the Pattersons all right--just their touch." ^B "And my things?" asked Anthony anxiously. "We'll do what we can, sir.

But the Pattersons are uncommon sharp." ;;;, "They seem to be," said Anthony bitterly. *""""i>is The inspector departed, and scarcely had he gone before there came a ring at the door. Anthony opened it. A small boy stood there, holding a package. "Parcel for you, sir." Anthony took it with some surprise. He was not expecting a parcel of any kind. Returning to the sitting-room with it, he cut the string. ;<| ^'y®^' , : ' It was a liqueur setl y!;- kill'"-" " He noticed that at the bottom of one of the glasses there was a tiny artificial rose. His mind flew back to the upper room in Kirk Street. S,;j; "I do like you--yes, I do like you. You will remember that whatever happens, won't you?" That was what she had said. Whatever happens.. . . Did she mean-- ^1% '^:Anthony took hold of himself sternly; ^ ^ "This won't do," he admonished himself. ' l His eye fell on the typewriter, and he sat down with a resolute face. K" THE MYSTERY OF THE SECOND

CUCUMBER His face grew dreamy again. The Shawl of a Thousand Flowers. What was it that was found on the floor beside ^e dead body? The gruesome thing that explained the ""hole mystery? " ^ Nothing, of course, since it was only a trumped-up tale to ^old his attention, and the teller had used the old Arabian -"ghsts' trick of breaking off at the most interesting point.

186 AGATHA CHRISTIE ^ But couldn't there be a gruesome thing that explained the whole mystery? Couldn't there? If one gave one's mind to it? Anthony tore the sheet of paper from his typewriter and substituted another. He typed a headline: THE MYSTERY OF THE SPANISH

SHAWL He surveyed it for a moment or two in silence. Then he began to type rapidly. ... q a: ? SiiA-i

THE CORNISH MYSTERY "mks. pengelley," announced our landlady, and withdrew discreetly. Many unlikely people came to consult Poirot, but to my mind, the woman who stood nervously just inside the door, fingering her feather neck-piece, was the most unlikely of all. She was so extraordinarily commonplace--a thin, faded woman of about fifty dressed in a **Page 102**

braided coat and skirt, some gold jewelry at her neck, and with her gray hair surmounted by a singularly unbecoming hat. In a country town, you pass a hundred Mrs. Pengelleys in the street everyday. Poirot came forward and greeted her pleasantly, perceiving her obvious embarrassment. "Madame! Take a chair, I beg of you. My colleague, Captain Hastings."

^The lady sat down, murmuring uncertainly: "You are

M. Poirot, the detective?"

H "At your service, madame."

But our guest was still tongue-tied. She sighed, twisted

her fingers, and grew steadily redder and redder. "There is something I can do for you, eh, madame?" "Well, I thought--that is--you see--" ^, "Proceed, madame, I beg of you--proceed." %- Mrs. Pengelley, thus encouraged, took a grip on herself. "It's this way, M. Poirot--I don't want to have anything to do with the police. No, I wouldn't go to the police for allything! But all the same, I'm sorely troubled about ""Olethmg. And yet I don't know if I ought--"

jSie stopped abruptly.

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"Me, I have nothing to do with the police. My investiea tions are strictly private." ' ' 1

Mrs. Pengelley caught at the word.

"Private--that's what I want. I don't want any talk or fuss, or things in the papers. Wicked it is, the way they write things, until the family could never hold up then- heads again. And it isn't as though I was even sure_it's just a dreadful idea that's come to me, and put it out of my head I can't" She paused for breath. "And all the time I may be wickedly wronging poor Edward. It's a terrible

thought for any wife to have. But you do read of such

dreadful things nowadays."

"Permit me--it is of your husband you speak?" ||

"Yes." :,,,

"And you suspect him of--what?"

"I don't like even to say it, M. Poirot. But you do read of such things happening--and the poor souls suspecting

Nothing-

I was beginning to despair of the lady's ever coming to the point, but Poirot's patience was equal to the demand made upon it

"Speak without fear, madame. Think what joy will be yours if we are able to prove your suspicions unfounded."

"That's true--anything's better than this wearing uncertainty.

Oh, M. Poirot, I'm dreadfully afraid I'm being poisoned."

"What makes you think so?"

Mrs. Pengelley, her reticence leaving her, plunged into a full recital more suited to the ears of her medical attendant.

"Pain and sickness after food, eh?" said Poirot thoughtfully.

"You have a doctor attending you, madame? What does he say?"

"He says it's acute gastritis, M. Poirot. But I can see that he's puzzled and uneasy, and he's always altering the vs6a- cine, but nothing **Page 103** does any good."

"You have spoken of your--fears, to him?"

"No, indeed, M. Poirot It might get about in the town" And perhaps it is gastritis. All the same, it's very odd that

THE CORNISH MYSTERY 189 whenever Edward is away for the week-end, I'm quite all right again. Even Freda noticed that--my niece, M. Poirot. And then there's that bottle of weed-killer, never used, the gardener says, and yet

it's half empty."

She looked appealingly at Poirot. He smiled reassuringly at her, and reached for a pencil and notebook.

"Let us be businesslike, madame. Now, then, you and your husband reside--where?" ; '

"Polgarwith, a small market town in Cornwall." "?"

"You have lived there long?" .,, ,,,,.

[T "Fourteen years." ^"S'?", ft :

"And your household consists 01 you and your husband.

Any children?" ,,,,;..'; ; tj,1:-," ;

"No." ^j®^ ,^' ^yil^ ^.y?

"But a niece, I think you said?" ^©^N Sl

"Yes, Freda Stanton, the child of my husband's only sister.

She has lived with us for the last eight years--that is, until a week ago."

"Oho, and what happened a week ago?" ^/

"Things hadn't been very pleasant for some time; I don't Hi know what had come over Freda. She was so rude and im- '*' pertinent, and her temper something shocking, and in the

.end she flared up one day, and out she walked and took

rooms of her own in the town. I've not seen her since. Better leave her to come to her senses, so Mr. Radnor says."

"Who is Mr. Radnor?"

| Some of Mrs. Pengelley's initial embarrassment

"returned. :^ .""

"Oh, he's--he's just a friend. Very pleasant young fellow."

f "Anything between him and your niece?" ^w ^a .

" "Nothing whatever," said Mrs. Pengelley emphatically.

Poirot shifted his ground. l; ""You

and your husband are, I presume, in comfortable yi | circumstances?"

"Yes, we're very nicely off."

"The money, is it yours or your husband's?"

"Oh, it's all Edward's. I've nothing of my own."

"You see, madame, to be businesslike, we must be bru-

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tal. We must seek for a motive. Your husband, he would

not poison you just pour passer le temps! Do you know of

any reason why he should wish you out of the way?"

"There's the yellow-haired hussy who works for him,"

said Mrs. Pengelley, with a flash of temper. "My husband's a dentist, M. Poirot, and nothing would do but he must

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have a smart girl, as he said, with bobbed hair and a white overall, to make his appointments and mix his fillings for him."

"This bottle of weed-killer, madame, who ordered it?"

"My husband--about a year ago."

"Your niece, now, has she any money of her own?"

"About fifty pounds a year, I should say. She'd be glad enough to come back and keep house for Edward if I left him." i

"You have contemplated leaving him, then?" a

"I don't intend to let him have it all his own way. Women aren't the downtrodden slaves they were in old days, M. Poirot." "I congratulate you on your independent spirit, madame; but let us be practical. You return to Polgar with today?" "Yes, I came up by an excursion. Six this morning the train started, and the train back goes at five this afternoon." "Bien! I have nothing of great moment on hand. I can devote myself to your little affair. Tomorrow I shall be in Polgar with."

Shall we say that Hastings, here, is a distant relative of yours, the son of your second cousin? Me, I am his eccentric foreign friend. In the meantime, eat only what is prepared by your own hands, or under your eye. You have a maid whom you trust?" "Jessie is a very good girl, I am sure."

i| "Till tomorrow then, madame, and be of good courage. Poirot bowed the lady out, and returned thoughtfully to his chair. His absorption was not so great, however, that he failed to see two minute strands of feather scarf wrenched off by the lady's agitated fingers. He collected them carefully and consigned them to the wastepaper basket.

at do you make of the case, Hastings?" ^A nasty business, I should say. "Yes, if what the lady suspects be true. But is it? Woebedde any husband who

orders a bottle of weed-killer nowadays? If his wife suffers from gastritis, and is inclined to be of a hysterical temperament, the fat is in the fire." "You think that is all there is to it?" "Ah--no, I do not know, Hastings.

But the case interests me--it interests me enormously. For, see you, it has positively no new features. Hence the hysterical woman. Yes, if I mistake not, we have here a very poignant human drama. Tell me, Hastings, what do you consider Mrs. Pengelley's feelings toward her husband to be?" "Loyalty struggling with fear," I suggested. "Yes, ordinarily, a woman will accuse anyone in the world--but not her husband. She will stick to her belief in him through thick and thin." "The 'other woman' complicates the matter." "Yes, affection may turn to hate, under the stimulus of jealousy. But hate would take her to the police--not to me. She would want an outcry--a scandal. No, no, let us exercise our little gray cells. Why did she come to me? To have her suspicions proved wrong? Or--to have them proved right? Ah, we have here something I do not understand--an unknown factor. Is she a superb actress, our Mrs.

Pengelley? No, she was genuine, I swear that she was genuine, and therefore I am interested.

Look up the train to Polgarwith, I pray you." "The best train of the day was the one-fifty from Paddington which reached Polgarwith just after seven o'clock. The journey was uneventful, and I had to rouse myself from a pleasant nap to alight upon the platform of the bleak little station. We took our bags to the Duchy Hotel, and after a short meal, Poirot suggested our stepping round to pay an after-dinner call on my so-called cousin.

The Pengelleys' house stood a little way back from the road with an old-fashioned cottage garden in front. The smell of stocks and mignonette came sweetly wafted on the evening breeze. It seemed impossible to associate thoughts

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of violence with this Old World charm. Poirot rang and knocked. As the summons was not answered, he rang again. This time, after a little pause, the door was opened by a disheveled-looking servant. Her eyes were red, and she was sniffing violently. "We wish to see Mrs. Pengelley," explained Poirot. "May we enter?" The maid stared. Then, with unusual directness, she answered: "Haven't you heard, then? She's dead. Died this evening--about half

hour ago."We stood staring at her, stunned."What did she die of?" I asked at last. "There's some as could tell." She gave a quick glance over her shoulder. "If it wasn't that somebody ought to be in the house with the missus, I'd pack my box and go tonight. But I'll not leave her dead with no one to watch by her. It's not my place to say anything, and I'm not going to say anything--but everybody knows. It's all over the town. And if Mr. Radnor don't write to the

'Ome Secretary, some one else will. The doctor may say what he likes. Didn't I see the master with my own eyes a-lifting down of the weed-killer from the shelf this very evening? And didn't he jump when he turned round and saw me watching of him? And the missus' gruel there on the table, all ready to take to her? Not another bit of food passes my lips while I am in this house!

Not if I dies for it." "Where does the doctor live who attended your mistress?" "Dr. Adams.

Round the corner there in High Street. The second house." Poirot turned away abruptly. He was very pale. "For a girl who was not going to say anything, that girl lied a lot," I remarked dryly. Poirot struck his clenched hand into his palm. "An imbecile, a criminal imbecile, that is what I have been, Hastings. I have boasted of my little gray cells, and now I have lost a human life, a life that came to me to be saved. Never did I dream that anything would happen so soon. May the good God forgive me, but I never believ-

THE CORNISH MYSTERY 193 anything would happen at all. Her story seemed to me artificial. Here we are at the doctor's. Let us see what he can tell us." "Dr. Adams was the typical genial red-faced country doctor of fiction. He received us politely enough, but at a hint of our errand, his red face became purple. "Nonsense! Nonsense, every word of it! Wasn't I in attendance on the case? Gastritis--gastritis pure and simple. This town's a hotbed of gossip--a lot of scandal mongering old women get together and invent Heaven knows what. They read these scurrilous rags of newspapers, and nothing will suit them but that some one in their town shall get poisoned too. They see a bottle of weed-killer on a shelf--and hey presto!--away goes their imagination with

the bit between its teeth. I know Edward Pengelley--he

wouldn't poison his grandmother's dog. And why should

he poison his wife? Tell me that?"

"There is one thing, M. le Docteur, that perhaps you do not know."

And, very briefly, Poirot outlined the main facts of Mrs.

Pengelley's visit to him. No one could have been more astonished than Dr. Adams. His eyes almost started out of

his head,

"God bless my soul!" he ejaculated. "The poor woman must have been mad. Why didn't she speak to me? That

was the proper thing to do."

"And have her fears ridiculed?"

"Not at all, not at all. I hope I've got an open mind."

Poirot looked at him and smiled. The physician was evidently more perturbed than he cared to admit. As we left

the house, Poirot broke into a laugh.

"He is as obstinate as a pig, that one. He has said it is gastritis; therefore it is gastritis! All the same, he has the 'Bind uneasy."

"What's our next step?"

"I return to the Inn, and a night of horror upon one of Your English provincial beds, mon ami. It is a thing to 'ave pity, the cheap English bed!"

194 AGATHA CHRISTIE "And tomorrow?"

"Rien a faire. We must return to (own

developments." 'nd await

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"That's very tame," I said, disappointed "Sun are none?" ' px)se ^e

"There wSl be! I ^;an_Dromisp^oii^i>"* ^.

, , , , "- ~ -" f^^. .tie cEnnot stop

several hundred tongues from wagging. And the) will w

to some purpose, I can tell you that!" 8

Our train for town left at eleven the roUowingmornme

Before we started for the station, Poirot express<d a wish to see Miss Freda Stanton, the niece mentioned to us by

the dead woman. We found the house where she was lodging

easily enough. With her was a tall, dark yqmg man

whom she, introduced in some confusion as l^r. Jacob

Radnor. |gti

Miss Freda Stanton was an extremely pretty gr] of the_

nid J^om^ch ta>«^-_ J--1- i^^^

per that it would not be wise to provoke. -----

"Poor Auntie," she said, when Poirot had in:roduced himself, and explained his business. "It's terribly sad. I've been wishing all the morning that I'd been kinder and

more patient."

"You stood a great deal, Preda," interrupted Radior.

"Yes, Jacob, but I've got a sharp temper, I knoy. After all, it was only silliness on Auntie's part. I ought to have just laughed and not minded. Of course, it's

all nonsense

her thinking that Uncle was poisoning her. She was worse

often. "What was the actual cause of your disagreement,

mademoiselle?"

Miss Stanton hesitated, looking at Radnor. That young

gentleman was quick to take the hint.

"I must be getting along, Freda. See you this evening.

Good-by, gentlemen; you're on your way to the station, I

suppose?"

Poirot replied that we were, and Radnor departed.

THE CORNISH MYSTERY 195

"You are affianced, is it not so?" demanded Poirot, with a sly smile.

Freda Stanton blushed and admitted that such was the

case.

"And that was really the whole trouble with Auntie,"

she added.

"She did not approve of the match for you?"

"Oh, it wasn't that so much. But you see—"

The girl came to a stop.

"Yes?" encouraged Poirot gently.

"It seems rather a horrid thing to say about her—now

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she's dead. But you'll never understand unless I tell you.

Auntie was absolutely infatuated with Jacob."

"Indeed?"

"Yes, wasn't it absurd? She was over fifty, and he's not quite thirty! But there it was. She was silly about him! I

had to tell her at last that it was me he was after—and she carried on dreadfully. She wouldn't believe a word of it, and was so rude and insulting that it's no wonder I lost my temper. I talked it over with Jacob, and we agreed that the

best thing to do was for me to clear out for a bit till she came to her senses. Poor Auntie—I suppose she was in a queer

state altogether."

"It would certainly seem so. Thank you, mademoiselle, for making thing so clear to me."

^ba little to my surprise, Radnor was wating for us in the street below.

"I can guess pretty well what Freda has been telling you," he remarked. "It was a most unfortunate thing to happen, and very awkward for me, as you can imagine. I

need hardly say that it was none of my doing. I was pleased at first, because I imagined the old woman was helping on things with Freda. The whole thing was absurd

but extremely unpleasant."

"When are you and Miss Stanton going to be married?"

"Soon, I hope. Now, M. Poirot, I'm going to be candid

with you. I know a bit more than Freda does. She believes

, her uncle to be innocent. I'm not so sure. But I can tell you

| one thing: I'm going to keep my mouth shut about what I

"al

THE CORNISH MYSTERY 197 a husband she has lived with for twenty years, and sometimes a whole family of children as well, in order to link her life with that of a young man considerably her junior. You admire *les femmes*, Hastings; you prostrate yourself before all of them who are good-looking and have the good taste to smile upon you; but psychologically you know nothing whatever about them. In the autumn of a woman's life, there comes always one mad moment when she longs for romance, for adventure--before it is too late. It comes none the less surely to a woman because she is the wife of a respectable dentist in a country town!" ;_ "And you think--"|

"That a clever man might take advantage of such a moment." "I shouldn't call Pengelley so clever," I mused. "He's got the whole town by the ears. And yet I suppose you're right. The only two men who know anything, Radnor and the doctor, both want to hush it up. He's managed that somehow. I wish we'd seen the fellow." "You can indulge your wish. Return by the next train and invent an aching molar." "H I looked at him keenly. "I wish I knew what you considered so interesting about the case." "My interest is very aptly summed up by a remark of yours, Hastings. After interviewing the maid, you observed that for anyone who was not going to say a word, she had said a good deal." "Oh!" I said doubtfully; then I harped back to my original criticism: "I wonder why you made no attempt to see Pengelley?" "Man ami, I give him just three months. Then I shall see him for as long as I please--in the dock." "i-For once I thought Poirot's prognostications were going to be proved wrong. The time went by, and nothing **Page 108**

transpired as to our Cornish case. Other matters occupied us, and I had nearly forgotten the Pengelley tragedy when it »as suddenly recalled to me by a short

paragraph in the paper which stated that an order Mrs. Pengelley had been obtained. A few days later, and

"The contents of every paper. It seemed thoroughly died down, and when the envelope Miss Marks, his secretary, was burst out again louder than ever. sent to the Home Secretary; the bottles (quantities of arsenic were discovered) was arrested and charged with the murder. Poirot and I attended the preliminary evidence was much as might have been admitted that the symptoms (might easily be mistaken for those of an Office expert gave his evidence; the flood of voluminous information, most of which certainly strengthened the case. Freda Stanton gave evidence worse whenever she ate food prepared by Radnor told how he had dropped the day of Mrs. Pengelley's death, placing the bottle of weed-killer or Pengelley's gruel being on the table. Marks, the fair-haired secretary, went into hysterics and admitted she promised to marry her in the event to his wife. Pengelley reserved his trial. «-^.

'A.,-1 Jacob Radnor walked back with him; "You see, M. Radnor," said Poirot voice of the people spoke--and there was to be no hushing up of this. "You were quite right," sighed Radnor. "Chance of his getting off?" "Well, he has reserved his defence--up the sleeve, as you English will say, will you not?" Radnor accepted the invitation.

THE CORNISH MYSTERY 199 "And sodas and a cup of chocolate. The last order caused consternation, and I much doubted whether it would ever put in an appearance." "Of course," continued Poirot, "I have a good deal of experience in matters of this kind. And I see only one loophole of escape for our friend." "What is that?" "I think that you should sign this paper." With the suddenness of a conjuror, he produced a sheet of paper covered with writing. "What is it?" "A confession that you murdered Mrs. Pengelley." "I There was a moment's pause; then Radnor laughed. "You must be mad!" "No, no, my friend, I am not mad. You came here; you started a little business; you were short of money. Mr. Pengelley was a man very well to do. You met his niece; she was inclined to smile upon you. But the small allowance that Pengelley might have given her upon her marriage was not enough for you. You must get rid of both the uncle and the aunt; then the money would come to her, since she was the only relative. How cleverly you set about it! You made love to the plain middle-aged woman until she was your slave.

You implanted in her doubts of her husband. She discovered first that he was deceiving her--then, under your guidance, that he was trying to poison her. You were often at the house; you had opportunities to introduce the arsenic into

her food. But you were careful never to do so when her husband was away. Being a woman, she did not keep her suspicions to herself. She talked to her niece; doubtless she talked to other women friends. Your only difficulty was keeping up separate relations with the two women, and even that was not so difficult as it looked. You explained to the aunt that, to allay the suspicions of her husband, you had to pretend to pay court to the niece. And the younger lady needed little convincing--she would never seriously consider her aunt as a rival. "But then Mrs. Pengelley made up her mind, without saying anything to you, to consult me. If she could be really cured, beyond any possible doubt, that her husband was trying to poison her, slinking her life away as you wanted her to all. You did not expect a minute to occur when she is getting some fatal dose. The matter up, you without Hercule Poirot was dead off matters with a "Very interesting this?" "Because, monsieur Pengelley. For he signed this paper, and twenty-four hours of police." "Radnor hesitate?" "You can't prove?" "Can't I? I am, monsieur. There are no signs not to lose sight of; Radnor strode a blind, then shrank." "You see, monsieur: "What guarantee?" "That I shall know. You will sign? My left-hand blind him. Radnor may leave White, muttered and nodded gently." "A coward! I am!" "It seems to me a manner," I cried impatiently. And here came out of sheer THE CORNISH MYSTERY 201 "That was not sentiment--that was business," replied Poirot.

"Do you not see, my friend, that we have no shadow of proof against him? Shall I get up and say to twelve stolid Cornishmen that I, Hercule Poirot, know? They would laugh at me. The only chance was to frighten him and get a confession that way. Those two loafers that I noticed outside came in very useful. Pull down the blind again, will you, Hastings? Not that there was any reason for raising it. It was part of the mise en scene." "Well, well, we must keep our word. Twenty-four" **Page 109**

hours, Sid I say? So much longer for poor Mr. Pengelley--and it is no more than he deserves; for mark you, he deceived his wife. I am very strong on the family life, as you know. Ah, well, twenty-four hours--and then? I have great faith in Scotland Yard. They will get him, mon ami; they will get

THE WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION 3|. - '1 . ^-- sa Mr. Mayhew adjusted his pince-nez and cleared his

throat with a little dry-as-dust cough that was wholly typical of him. Then he looked again at the man opposite him, the man charged with willful murder.

Mr. Mayhew was a small man, precise in manner,

neatly, not to say foppishly dressed, with a pair of very shrewd and piercing gray eyes. By no means a fool. Indeed, as a solicitor, Mr. Mayherne's reputation stood very high. His voice, when he spoke to his client, was dry but not unsympathetic.

"I must impress upon you again that you are in very grave danger, and that the utmost frankness is necessary."

Leonard Vole, who had been staring in a dazed fashion at the blank wall in front of him, transferred his glance to the solicitor.

"I know," he said hopelessly. "You keep telling me so.

But I can't seem to realize yet that I'm charged with murder --murder. And such a dastardly crime, too."

Mr. Mayherne was practical, not emotional. He coughed again, took off his pincenez, polished them carefully,

and replaced them on his nose. Then he said, "Ves, yes, yes. Now, my dear Mr.

Vole, we're going to make a

determined effort to get you off--and we shall succeed--

we shall succeed. But I must have all the facts. I know just how damaging the case against you is likely to be. Then we can fix upon the best line of defense."

Still the young man looked at him in the same dazed* hopeless fashion. To Mr.

Mayherne the case had seemed black enough, and the guilt of the prisoner assured.

No^'

for the first time, he felt a doubt.

THE WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION 203

"You think I'm guilty," said Leonard Vole, in a low voice. "But I swear I'm not! It looks pretty black against me, I know that. I'm like a man caught in a net--the meshes of it all round me, entangling me whichever way I

turn. But I didn't do it, Mr. Mayherne, I didn't do it!"

- ' In such a position a man was bound to protest his innocence.

Mr. Mayherne knew that. Yet, in spite of himself,

he was impressed. It might be, after all, that Leonard Vole

was innocent.

; "You are right, Mr. Vole," he said gravely. "The case does look very black against you. Nevertheless, I accept

your assurance. Now, let us get to facts. I want you to tell me in your own words exactly how you came to make the

acquaintance of Miss Emily French."

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"It was one day in Oxford Street. I saw an elderly lady crossing the road. She was carrying a lot of parcels. In the middle of the street she dropped them, tried to recover

them, found a bus was almost on top of her, and just managed to reach the curb safely, dazed and bewildered by

people having shouted at her. I recovered her parcels,

wiped the mud off them as best I could, relieved the string of one, and returned them to her."

"There was no question of your having saved her life?"

"Oh, dear me, no! All I did was to perform a common

act of courtesy. She was extremely grateful, thanked me

warmly, and said something about my manners not being

those of most of the younger generation--I can't remember the exact words.

Then I lifted my hat and went on. I never expected to see her again. But life is full of coincidences. That very evening I came across her at a party at a friend's house. She recognized me at once and asked that I should be introduced to her.

I then found out that she ^ a Miss Emily French and that she lived

at Cricklewood. I talked to her for some time. She was, I imagine, an old lady who took sudden and violent fancies to people. "-he took one to me on the strength of a perfectly simple ^ on which anyone might have performed.

On leaving, ^ shook me warmly by the hand and asked me to come ^ d see her. I replied, of course, that I should be very Phased to do so, and she then urged me to name a day. I

did not want particichurlish to refuse, so she had gone, I Iefriends. That she wi maid, and owned no "I see," said Mr. well off came up as "If you mean thi hotly, but Mr. Mayhi "I have to look at other side. An ordin Miss French to be a humbly. Unless yoi would in all probabie circumstances—at ai actly who told you tt "My friend, Geor took place." "Is he likely to ren "I really don't kinow."

"Quite so, Mr. Vocution will be to esta cially—that is true, iLeonard Vole flusi

"Yes," he said, in a low voice, "Quite so," said Noy, in a low voice, "Which is the cast I dare say. I am ;it from the outside pthe memory of Mr. ;conversation or is he into believing that itLeonard Vole refl steadily enough, but •

8|, THE WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION :: - 205that that line would be successful, Mr.

Mayhew. Several of those present heard his remark, and one or two of them.. chaffed me about my conquest of a rich old lady.", The solicitor endeavored to hide his disappointmentwith a wave of the hand. "Unfortunate," he said. "But I congratulate you uponyour plain speaking, Mr.

Vole. It is to you I look to guide me. Your judgment is quite right. To persist in the line I spoke of would have been disastrous. We must leave that point. You made the acquaintance of Miss French, you called upon her, the acquaintanceship progressed. We want a clear reason for all this.

Why did you, a young man of thirty-three, good-looking, fond of sport, popular with your friends, devote so much of your time to an elderly woman with whom you could hardly have anything in common?"_, Leonard Vole flung out his hands in a nervous gesture. "I can't tell you--I really can't tell you. After the first visit, she pressed me to come again, spoke of being lonely and unhappy. She made it difficult for me to refuse. She showed so plainly her fondness and affection for me that I, was placed in an awkward position. You see, Mr. Mayhew, I've got a weak nature--I drift--I'm one of those^ people who can't say no. And believe me or not, as you like, after the third or fourth visit I paid her I found myself1 ^ getting genuinely fond of the old thing. My mother died when I was young, an aunt brought me up, and she, too, died before I was fifteen. If I told you that I genuinely enjoyed being mothered and pampered, I dare say you'd only laugh." Mr. Mayhew did not laugh. Instead he took off his pince-nez again and polished them, a sign with him that he was thinking deeply. "I accept your explanation, Mr. Vole," he said at last. "I believe it to be psychologically probable. Whether a jury' would take that view of it is **Page 111**

another matter. Please continue your narrative. When was it that Miss French first Asked you to look into her business affairs?" "After my third or fourth visit to her. She understood very little of money matters, and was worried about some 'investments.'"

206 AGATHA CHRISTIE Mr. Mayhew looked up sharply. "Be careful, Mr. Vole. The maid, Janet Mackenzie, declares that her mistress was a good woman of business and transacted all her own affairs, and this is borne out by the testimony of her bankers." "I can't help that," said Vole earnestly. "That's what she said to me." Mr. Mayhew looked at him for a moment or two in silence. Though he had no intention of saying so, his belief in Leonard Vole's innocence was at the moment strengthened. He knew something of the mentality of elderly ladies. He saw Miss French, infatuated with the good-looking young man, hunting about for pretexts that would bring him to the house. What more likely than that she would plead ignorance of business, and beg him to help her with her money affairs? She was enough of a woman of the world to realize that any man is slightly flattered by such an admission of his superiority. Leonard Vole had been flattered.

Perhaps, too, she had not been averse to letting this young man know that she was wealthy. Emily French had been a strong-willed old woman, willing to pay her price for what she wanted. All this passed rapidly through Mr. Mayhew's mind, but he gave no indication of it, and asked instead a further question. "And did you handle her affairs for her at her request?" "I did." "Mr. Vole," said the solicitor, "I am going to ask you a very serious question, and one to which it is vital I should have a truthful answer. You were in low water financially. You had the handling of an old lady's affairs--an old lady who, according to her own statement, knew little or nothing of business.

Did you at any time, or in any manner, convert to your own use the securities which you handled?

Did you engage in any transaction for your own pecuniary advantage which will not bear the light of day?" He quelled the other's response. "Wait a minute before you answer. There are two courses open to us. Either we can make a feature of your probity and honesty in conducting her affairs while pointing out how unlikely it is that you would THE WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION commit murder to obtain money which you might have obtained by such infinitely easier means. If, on the other hand, there is anything in your dealings which the prosecution will get hold of--if, to put it badly, it can be proved that you swindled the old lady in any way, we must take the line that you had no motive for the murder, since she was already a profitable source of income to you. You perceive the distinction. Now, I beg of you, take your time before you reply." ". . . , But Leonard Vole took no time at all. (I

"My dealings with Miss French's affairs were all perfectly fair and above board. I acted for her interests to the very best of my ability, as anyone will find who looks into the matter." "Thank you," said Mr. Mayhew. "You relieve my mind very much. I pay you the compliment of believing that you are far too clever to lie to me over such an important matter." "Surely," said Vole eagerly, "the strongest point in my favor is the lack of motive. Granted that I cultivated the acquaintanceship of a rich old lady in the hopes of getting money out of her--that, I gather, is the substance of what you have been saying--surely her death frustrates all my hopes?"

The solicitor looked at him steadily. Then, very deliberately, he repeated his unconscious trick with his pincenez. It was not until they were firmly replaced on his nose that he spoke. , :

"Are you not aware, Mr. Vole, that Miss French left a will under which you are the principal beneficiary?" "What?" The prisoner sprang to his feet. His dismay was obvious and unforced. "What are you saying? She left her money to me?"

Mr. Mayhew nodded slowly. Vole sank down again, his head in his hands.

"You pretend you know nothing of this will?" }

"Pretend? There's no pretense about it. I knew nothing about it."

"What would you say if I told you that the maid, Janet

Page 112

Mackenzie, swears that you did know? That her mistress told her distinctly that she had consulted you in the matter, and told you of her intentions?"

"Say? That she's lying! No, I go too fast. Janet is an elderly woman. She was a faithful watchdog to her mistress

and she didn't like me. She was jealous and suspicious. I

should say that Miss French confided her intentions to Janet, and that Janet either mistook something she said, or

else was convinced in her own mind that I had persuaded

the old lady into doing it. I dare say that she herself believes now that Miss French actually told her so."

"You don't think she dislikes you enough to lie deliberately about the matter?"

Leonard Vole looked shocked and startled.

"No, indeed! Why should she?"

"I don't know," said Mr. Mayherne thoughtfully. "But she's very bitter against you." said

The wretched young man groaned again.

"I'm beginning to see," he muttered. "It's frightful. I made up to her, that's what they'll say, I got her to make a will leaving her money to me, and then I go there that night, and there's nobody in the house--they find her the next day--oh, it's awful!"

"You are wrong about there being nobody in the house,"

said Mr. Mayherne. "Janet, as you remember, was to go

out for the evening. She went, but about half past nine she returned to fetch the pattern of a blouse sleeve which she had promised to a friend. She let herself in by the back door, went upstairs and fetched it, and went out again. She heard voices in the sitting-room, though she could not distinguish what they said, but she will swear that one of them was Miss French's and one was a man's."

"At half past nine," said Leonard Vole. "At half past nine--" He sprang to his feet. "But then I'm saved--saved _» ^ j|

"What do you mean, saved?" cried Mr. Mayherne, astonished.

"By half past nine I was at home again! My wife can prove that. I left Miss French about five minutes to nine. I arrived home about twenty past nine. My wife was there

THE WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION 209

waiting for me. Oh, thank God--thank God! And bless Janet Mackenzie's sleeve pattern."

In his exuberance, he hardly noticed that the grave expression on the solicitor's face had not altered. But the latter's words brought him down to earth with a bump.

"Who, then, in your opinion, murdered Miss French?"

"Why, a burglar, of course, as was thought at first. The window was forced, you remember. She was killed with a

heavy blow from a crowbar, and the crowbar was found lying on the floor beside the body. And **Page 113**

several articles were missing. But for Janet's absurd suspicions and dislike of

me, the police would never have swerved from the right track." "That will hardly do, Mr. Vole," said the solicitor.

"The things that were missing were mere trifles of no value, taken as a blind. And the marks on the window were not at all conclusive. Besides, think for yourself. You say you were no longer in the house by half past nine. Who, then, was the man Janet heard talking to Miss French in the sitting room? She would hardly be having an amicable conversation with a burglar." "No," said Vole. "No--" He looked puzzled and discouraged. "But, anyway" he added with reviving spirit, "it lets me out. I've got an alibi. You must see Romaine--my wife--at once."

"Certainly," acquiesced the lawyer. "I should already have seen Mrs. Vole but for her being absent when you were arrested. I wired to Scotland at once, and I understand that she arrives back tonight. I am going to call upon her immediately I leave here." Vole nodded, a great expression of satisfaction settling down over his face. "Yes, Romaine will tell you. It's a lucky chance that." "Excuse me, Mr. Vole, but you are very fond of your wife?" "Of course." "And she of you?" "Romaine is devoted to me. She'd do anything in the world for me." ' . He spoke enthusiastically, but the solicitor's heart sank a

210 AGATHA CHRISTIE little lower. The testimony of a devoted wife-- would it gain credence? "Was there anyone else who saw you return at nine-twenty. A maid, for instance?" "We have no maid." "Did you meet anyone in the street on the way back?" "Nobody I knew. I rode part of the way in a bus. The conductor might remember." "Si Mr. Mayhew shook his head doubtfully, 's"; "There is no one, then, who can confirm your wife's

-testimony?" "No. But it isn't necessary, surely?" "I dare say not. I dare say not," said Mr.

Mayhew hastily. "Now there's just one thing more. Did Miss French know that you were a married man?" "Oh, yes." "Yet you never took your wife to see her. Why was that?" For the first time, Leonard Vole's answer came halting and uncertain. .;,-,,"Well--I don't know." ^EW "Are you aware that Janet Mackenzie says her mistress believed you to be single, and contemplated marrying you

in the future?"

Vole laughed. "Absurd! There was forty years' ^difference in age between us."

"It has been done," said the solicitor dryly. "The fact remains.

Your wife never met Miss French?"

"No--" Again the constraint.

"You will permit me to say," said the lawyer, "that I hardly understand your attitude in the matter." '

Vole flushed, hesitated, and then spoke.

"I'll make a clean breast of it. I was hard up, as you

know. I hoped that Miss French might lend me some money.

She was fond of me, but she wasn't at all interested in

the struggles of a young couple. Early on, I found that she

had taken it for granted that my wife and I didn't get on--- were living apart.

Mr. Mayheme--I wanted the money--

for, Romaine's sake. I said nothing, and allowed the old

lady to think what she chose. She spoke of my being an

THE WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION 211

adopted son to her. There was never any question of marriage--that must be just Janet's imagination."

"And that is all?"

"Yes--that is all."

Was there just a shade of hesitation in the words? The

lawyer fancied so. He rose and held out his hand.

"Good-by, Mr. Vole." He looked into the haggard young **Page 114**

face and spoke with an unusual impulse. "I believe in your innocence in spite

of the multitude of facts arrayed against you. I hope to prove it and vindicate you completely."

Vole smiled back at him.

"You'll find the alibi is all right," he said cheerfully.

Again he hardly noticed that the other did not respond.

"The whole thing hinges a good deal on the testimony of Janet Mackenzie," said Mr. Mayherne. "She hates you.

That much is clear."

"She can hardly hate me," protested the young man.

The solicitor shook his head as he went out. Now for Mrs. Vole, he said to himself. He was seriously disturbed by the way the thing was shaping.

The Voles lived in a small shabby house near Paddington Green. It was to this house that Mr. Mayheme went.

In answer to his ring, a big slatternly woman, obviously a charwoman, answered the door.

"Mrs. Vole? Has she returned yet?"

"Got back an hour ago. But I dunno if you can see her."

"If you will take my card to her," said Mr. Mayheme quietly. "I am quite sure that she will do so."

The woman looked at him doubtfully, wiped her hand on her apron, and took the card. Then she closed the door

in his face and left him on the step outside.

In a few minutes, however, she returned with a slightly altered manner.

"Come inside, please."

She ushered him into a tiny drawing-room. Mr. Mayheme, examining a drawing on the wall, started up suddenly to face a tall, pale woman who had entered so quietly that he had not heard her.

"Mr. Mayherne? You are my husband's solicitor, are you not? You have come down?"

Until she spoke he had n
glish. Now, observing her e
cheekbones, the dense blui
casional very slight moverc
tinctly foreign. A strange w
make one uneasy. From tt
conscious that he was up a,
understand.

"Now, my dear Mrs. V
give way—"

He stopped. It was so v

had not the slightest intent

fectly calm and composed.

"Will you please tell m

Page 115

know everything. Do not know the worst." She hesitated, with a curious emphasis, "I want to know Mr. Mayherne went over Vole. She listened attentively then.

"I see," she said, when he said that he came in at midnight?"

"He did come in at midnight sharply.

"That is not the point," insisted so acquit him? Will they believe Mr. Mayherne was taken to the core of the matter?

"That is what I want to know enough? Is there any evidence?"

There was a suppressed

made him vaguely uneasy.

"So far there is no one el;

"I see," said Romaine V

THE WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION 213

She sat for a minute or two perfectly still. A little smile played over her lips.

The lawyer's feeling of alarm grew stronger and stronger. „-:

"Mrs. Vole--" he began. "I know what you must feel--"

"Do you?" she asked. "I wonder."

"In the circumstances--"

"In the circumstances--I intend to play a lone hand." .

He looked at her in dismay.

"But, my dear Mrs. Vole--you are overwrought. Being so devoted to your husband--"

"I beg your pardon?"

The sharpness of her voice made him start. He repeated in a hesitating manner, "Being so devoted to your husband--"

Romaine Vole nodded slowly, the same strange smile on her lips. "Did he tell you that I was devoted to him?" she asked softly. "Ah! yes, I can see he did. How stupid men are! Stupid--stupid--stupid--" She rose suddenly to her feet. All the intense emotion that the lawyer had been conscious of in the atmosphere was now concentrated in her tone. "I hate him, I tell you! I hate him. I hate him. I hate him! I would like to see him hanged by the neck till he is dead."

The lawyer recoiled before her and the smoldering passion in her eyes, - 'She advanced a step nearer and continued vehemently. "Perhaps I shall see it. Supposing I tell you that he did not come in that night at twenty past nine, but at twenty past ten? You say that he tells you he knew nothing about the money coming to him. Supposing I tell you he knew all about it, and counted on it, and committed murder to get it? Supposing I tell you that he admitted to me that night when he came in what he had done? That there was blood on his coat? What then?

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Supposing that I stand up in court and say all these things?" Her eyes seemed to challenge him.

With an effort he

214 AGATHA CHRISTIE concealed his growing dismay, and endeavored to speak in a rational tone. "You cannot be asked to give evidence against your husband--" "I should like you to tell me one thing," said Mr. Mayherne. He contrived to appear as cool and unemotional as ever. "Why are you so bitter against Leonard Vole?" She shook her head, smiling a little. "Yes, you would like to know. But I shall not tell you. I ^will keep my secret."" Mr. Mayherne gave his dry little cough and rose. "There seems no point in prolonging this interview," he remarked. "You will hear from me again after I have communicated with my client." She came closer to him, looking into his eyes with her own wonderful dark ones. "Tell me," she said, "did you believe-- honestly--that he was innocent when you came here today?" "I did," said Mr. Mayherne. . ' "You poor little man." She laughed. "And I believe so still," finished the lawyer. "Good evening, madam." He went out of the room, taking with him the memory of her startled face. This is going to be the devil of a business, said Mr. Mayherne to himself as he strode along the street. Extraordinary, the whole thing. An extraordinary woman. A very dangerous woman. Women were the devil when they got their knife into you. What was to be done? That wretched young man hadn't a leg to stand upon. Of course, possibly he did commit

the crime. |

No, said Mr. Mayherne to himself. No--there's almost* too much evidence against him. I don't believe this woman.

She was trumping up the whole story. But she'll never

bring it into court. <<

He wished he felt more conviction on the point.

The police court proceedings were brief and dramatic.

The principal witnesses for the prosecution were Janet

THE WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION 215 Mackenzie, maid to the dead woman, and Romaine

Heilger.

Mr. Mayhew sat in court and listened to the damning story that the latter told.

It was on the lines she had indicated to him in their interview.

The prisoner reserved his defense and was committed for trial.

Mr. Mayhew was at his wits' end. The case against Leonard Vole was black beyond words. Even the famous K.C. who was engaged for the defense held out little hope.

"If we can shake that woman's testimony, we might do something," he said dubiously. "But it's a bad business."

Mr. Mayhew had concentrated his energies on one single point. Assuming Leonard Vole to be speaking the truth, and to have left the murdered woman's house at nine o'clock, who was the man Janet heard talking to Miss French at half past nine? ,_

The only ray of light was in the shape of a scapegrace nephew who had in bygone days cajoled and threatened his

aunt out of various sums of money. Janet Mackenzie, the Solicitor learned, had always been attached to this young

man, and had never ceased urging his claims upon her mistress.

It certainly seemed possible that it was this nephew who had been with Miss French after Leonard Vole left, especially as he was not to be found in any of
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his old

haunts.

In all other directions, the lawyer's researches had been

negative in their result. No one had seen Leonard Vole entering his own house, or leaving that of Miss French. No

one had seen any other man enter or leave the house in

Cricklewood. All inquiries drew blank.

It was the eve of the trial when Mr. Mayherne received

the letter which was to lead his thoughts in an entirely new direction.

It came by the six-o'clock post. An illiterate scrawl, written on common paper and enclosed in a dirty envelope

with the stamp stuck on crooked.

Mr. Mayherne read it through once or twice before he

grasped its meaning.

216 AGATHA Dear Mister:

You're the lawyer cha

efeller. If you want that pai for wot she is an her pa

Shaw's Rents Stepney toni

dred quid Arsk for Missis 1

The solicitor read and rere;

of course, be a hoax, but w]

came increasingly convinced convinced that it was the 01 evidence of Romaine Heilge the line the defense meant t< dence of a woman who hac life was not to be trusted, w. Mr. Mayheme's mind wa; save his client at all costs. H He had some difficulty in building in an evil-smelling son inquiry for Mrs. Mogson third floor. On this door he laknocked again. At this second knock, he and presently the door was < and a bent figure peered out .- . Suddenly the woman, for i and opened the door wider. "So it's you, dearie," shebody with you, is there? No can come in--you can come

: With some reluctance th threshold into the small, dirtjet. There was an untidy umdeal table, and two rickety Mayheme had a full view (apartment. She was a wornai with a mass of untidy gray 1 round her face. She saw hit again, the same curious, toneli "Wondering why I hide i THE WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION 217 aid it may tempt you, eh? But you shall see--you shall see." She drew aside the scarf, and the lawyer recoiled involuntarily before the almost formless blur of scarlet. She replaced the scarf again. "So you're not wanting to kiss me, dearie? He, he, I don't wonder. And yet I was a pretty girl once--not so long ago as you'd think, either. Vitriol, dearie, vitriol--that's what did that. Ah! but I'll be even with 'em--" She burst into a hideous torrent of abuse which Mr. Mayherne tried vainly to quell. She fell silent at last, her hands clenching and unclenching themselves nervously. "Enough of that," said the lawyer sternly. "I've come here because I have reason to believe you can give me information which will clear my client, Leonard Vole. Is that the case?" ^v ^ " ^ Br Her eyes leered at him cunningly. A

"What about the money, dearie?" she wheezed. Two hundred quid, you remember." ^ 1 ;,, I. "It is your duty to give evidence, and you can be called upon to do so." "That won't do dearie. I'm an old woman, and I know nothing. But you give me two hundred quid, and perhaps I can give you a hint or two. See?" m. "What kind of hint?" I? "What should you say to a letter? A letter from her. Never mind how I got hold of it. That's my business. It'll do the trick. But I want my two hundred quid." Mr. Mayheme looked at her coldly, and made up his mind.

"I'll give you ten pounds, nothing more. And only that if this letter is what you say it is." ^ ::

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|. "Ten pounds?" She screamed and raved at him. s Twenty," said Mr. Mayheme,

"and that's my last

.word-" 1^ '

? He rose as if to go. Then, watching her closely, he drew

out a pocketbook, and counted out twenty one-pound

notes.

"You see," he said. "That is all I have with me. You can take it or leave it." i.^ g|hi,?fe

218 AGATHA CHRISTIE

But already he knew that the sight of th<

much for her. She cursed and raved impot

she gave in. Going over to the bed, she

from beneath the tattered mattress.

"Here you are," she snarled. "It's th

want."

It was a bundle of letters that she threw

Mayheme untied them and scanned them I

methodical manner. The woman, watchu

could gain no clue from his impassive face.

He read each letter through, then rerun

top one and read it a second time. Then hi
bundle up again carefully.

They were love letters, written by Roma
the man they were written to was not Lee
top letter was dated the day of the latter's ai
"I spoke true, dearie, didn't I?" whined t
do for her, that letter?"

Mr. Mayherne put the letters in his pocke
a question.

"How did you get hold of this correspond
"That's telling," she said with a leer. "Bi
thing more. I heard in court what that huss
where she was at twenty past ten, the time '
at home. Ask at the Lion Road Cinema. T
—a find upstanding girl like that—curse hei
"Who is the man?" asked Mr. Mayhera
a Christian name here."

The other's voice grew thick and ho;
clenched and unclenched. Finally she lit
face.

"He's the man that did this to me. Many
She took him away from me—a chit of a g

And when I went after him—and went f<
threw the cursed stuff at me! And she lau^
in for her for years. Followed her, I have,
And now I've got her! She'll suffer for this
Lawyer? She'll suffer?"

"She will probably be sentenced to a te:
ment for perjury," said Mr. Mayherne quiet

THE WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION 219

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"Shut away--that's what I want. You're going, are you?"

Where's my money? Where's that good money?"

Without a word, Mr. Mayherne put down the notes on

the table. Then, drawing a deep breath, he turned and left the squalid room. Looking back, he saw the old woman hunched over the money. He wasted no time. He found the cinema in Lion Road easily enough, and, shown a photograph of Romaine Heilger, the commissionaire recognized her at once. She had arrived at the cinema with a man some time after ten o'clock on the evening in question. He had not noticed her escort particularly, but he remembered the lady who had spoken to him about the picture that was showing. They stayed until the end, about an hour later. Mr. Mayherne was satisfied. Romaine Heilger's evidence : was a tissue of lies from beginning to end. She had evolved it out of her passionate hatred. The lawyer wondered '

whether he would ever know what lay behind that hatred. What had Leonard Vole done to her?

He had seemed dumb: founded when the solicitor had reported her attitude to him. He had declared earnestly that such a thing was incredible--yet it had seemed to Mr. Mayherne that after the first astonishment his protests had lacked sincerity. He did know. Mr. Mayherne was convinced of it. He knew, but he had no intention of revealing the fact. The secret between those two remained a secret. Mr. Mayherne wondered if some day he should come to learn what it was.

The solicitor glanced at his watch. It was late, but time was everything. He hailed a taxi and gave an address. "Sir Charles must know of this at once," he murmured to himself as he got in.

n. ^ ,,-. .^The trial of Leonard Vole for the murder of Emily French aroused widespread interest.

In the first place the prisoner was young and good-looking, then he was accused of a particularly dastardly crime, and there was the further interest of Romaine Heilger, the principal witness for the prosecution. There had been

pictures of her in many papers, AGATHA CHRISTIE papers, and several fictitious stories as to her origin and history. The proceedings opened quietly enough.

Various technical evidence came first. Then Janet Mackenzie was called. She told substantially the same story as before. In cross-examination counsel for the defense succeeded in getting her to contradict herself once or twice over her account of Vole's association with Miss French; he emphasized the fact that though she had heard a man's voice in the sitting-room that night, there was nothing to show that it was Vole who was there, and he managed to drive home the feeling that jealousy and dislike of the prisoner were at the bottom of a good deal of her evidence. Then the next witness was called. "Your name is Romaine Heilger?" "Yes." "You are an Austrian subject?" "Yes." "For the last three years you have lived with the prisoner and passed yourself off as his wife?" Just for a moment Romaine Heilger's eyes met those of the man in the dock. Her expression held something curious and unfathomable. "Yes." The questions went on.

Word by word the damning fact came out. On the night in question the prisoner had taken out a crowbar with him. He had returned at twenty minutes past ten, and had confessed to having killed the old lady. His cuffs had been stained with blood, and he had burned them in the kitchen stove. He had terrorized her into silence by means of threats. As the story proceeded, the feeling of the court which had, to begin with, been slightly favorable to the prisoner now set dead against him. He himself sat with downcast head and moody air, as though he knew he were doomed. Yet it might have been noted that her own counsel sought to restrain Romaine's animosity. He would have preferred her to be more unbiased. Formidable and ponderous, counsel for the defense THE WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION 221 He put it to her that her story was a malicious fabrication from start to finish, that she had not even been in her own house at the time in question, that she was in love with another man and was deliberately seeking to send Vole to his death for a crime he did not commit. Romaine denied these allegations with superb insolence. Then came the surprising denouement, the production of the letter. It was read aloud in court in the midst of a breathless stillness. "Max, beloved, the Fates have delivered him into our hands! He has been arrested for murder--but, yes, the murder of an old lady! Leonard, who would not hurt a fly! At last I shall have my revenge. The poor chicken! I shall say that he **Page 120**

came in that night with blood upon him ---that he confessed to me. I shall

hang him. Max--and when he hangs he will know and realize that it was Romaine who sent him to his death. ' And then--happiness. Beloved! Happiness at last!" There were experts present ready to swear that the handwriting was that of Romaine Heilger, but they were not needed. Confronted with the letter, Romaine broke down utterly and confessed everything. Leonard Vole had returned to the house at the time he said, twenty past nine. She had invented the whole story to ruin him. With the collapse of Romaine Heilger, the case for the Crown collapsed also. Sir Charles called his few witnesses, the prisoner himself went into the box and told his story in a manly straightforward manner, unshaken by cross-examination. The prosecution endeavored to rally, but without great success. The judge's summing up was not wholly favorable ; to the prisoner, but a reaction had set in and the jury , needed little time to consider their verdict. "We find the prisoner not guilty." Leonard Vole was free! ' . ; > i ^ Little Mr. Mayhew hurried from his seat. He must congratulate his client. He found himself polishing his pince-nez vigorously, and checked himself before that he went. People then An interest in now, Romaine The case was of Romaine Hi in the house a out against the tropical flower. If he closed 1 ment, her exqui hand clenching time.

Curious thin hand was her h else do it quite 1 He drew in him. The words He stood still possible--Yet,] The K.C. said should. "Congratulations you know. Corn But the little! He wanted o ; to face. He did not s of their meeting "So you guess was in his mind the light of this makeup. "" But why--w "Why did I] remembering the 1 "Such an elal "My friend- woman devoted

^ THE WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION 223 hinted as much yourself. But I know something of the psychology of crowds. Let my evidence be wrung from me, as an admission, damning me in the eyes of the law, and a reaction in favor of the prisoner would immediately set in." " ' . ; , @ : t ' : ^ . ^ "And the bundle of letters?" "One alone, the vital one, might have seemed like a--what do you call it?--put-up job." .., f'. "Then the man called Max?" ? y a ^ || ^ "Never existed, my friend." ** "I still think," said little Mr. Mayhew, in an aggrieved manner, "that we could have got him, qfl? by the--er--normal procedure." ; , , , ; ^ T dared not risk it. You see you thought he was innocent--"

"And you knew it? I see," said little Mr. Mayherne. ; : "My dear Mr. Mayherne," said Romaine,

"you do not

see at all. I knew--he was guilty!"^.' ^ ;^ '

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